

MICHELLE'S
Corruption

KIRSTEN MCCURRAN
WITH KENNY WRIGHT

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APHRODITE OMNIMEDIA

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ONE

MICHELLE PLACED the lid on the box and surveyed her classroom. Another school year was in the books. The end of the term always left her with mixed feelings. She was prideful that she sent another set of students off into the world, having done everything she could to prepare them for what lies ahead. Michelle taught junior and senior AP English. She loved opening the students' minds and challenging them to think differently. It was tough to keep the seniors' attention as the end of their high school careers loomed, but she did her best.

Her pride mixed with melancholy. She'd miss the students who'd left an impression on her. There were always at least one or two students a semester she grew close to, and even though students came back to visit sometimes, it made her sad to think she'd likely never see them again. She did not friend students on Facebook as a matter of policy. She gathered the box and left her classroom for the last time that term.

Michelle was passing the gyms when one of the doors flew open, almost knocking the box from her hands. Her athletic reflexes saved her, and Michelle juggled the box in her arms as she jumped back, but she didn't drop it. She smiled when Declan emerged from the gym. It was very much like him to heedlessly rush through a door. He saw her and held up his hands apologetically.

“Sorry, it’s so quiet down here I thought I was the only one left in the building,” he said.

“We might be the only two. Everyone is in such a rush to get out of here at the end of the year, including us teachers. We’re as bad as the kids.” Michelle laughed.

“You don’t look forward to your summer vacation?”

“I do, but I also love my job. I like teaching, so I’m not dying for the school year to end.”

“And you’re trading hormonal high school students for a summer with the kids. I’m not sure I’d consider that a vacation either. Your kids are great, no offense.”

Michelle laughed again. Declan brought it out in her. “I love my kids! And I love my job. I have a pretty good life.”

“I get it. I think teaching is fun, too. But some part of you must miss the freedom of doing as you please, like you could before the kids.”

“Maybe, I don’t know. I’m actually going to get all the freedom I can handle this summer. The kids will be with Clay at camp for a month now that they’re old enough, and then they’re at the shore with my parents. It’s going to be weird to have all that time to myself.”

“Let me know if you need company. We could always have a drink,” he offered.

“Sure, let me ask my husband if I can go out on a date. I’m sure that will fly.”

“We’re co-workers. Not a date—unless you want it to be. I’m here for whatever you need.” He offered a big, innocent grin, which Michelle didn’t buy for a second.

“One day I might shock you by saying yes to one of your come-ons. What will you do then?”

“Wouldn’t you like to know, Winthrop?”

Declan seemed to notice her box for the first time. “Let me get that for you.”

“You don’t have to,” she protested.

Declan was already taking the box out of her arms. “It’s no problem. I’m walking out anyway. Are you in the faculty lot?”

“Yes. I’m meeting Clay there. He took the kids to help clean out his classroom.”

“He’s usually pretty psyched to see the summer come.”

“Clay likes teaching. He just hates all of the administrative bullshit, and the relentless focus on testing. I’m with him on that.”

“At least you two each have someone to bitch to who understands,” Declan said.

“It is a perk.”

They emerged onto a scorching late June day, the blacktopped parking lot reflecting waves of heat back at them. Michelle felt her pale cheeks go red and sweat pop out on her forehead. She took a band from her wrist and tied her long tawny hair back in a ponytail. It fell halfway down her back. This might be the summer she cuts it, Michelle thought, feeling the weight of her ponytail on the back of her warm neck. She wore a lightweight cotton maxi dress with wide blue and white stripes, but she still felt the heat. She envied Declan in his shorts and tank top. Michelle didn’t know another grown man who wore gym shorts as well as Declan.

Michelle opened the rear of her old Honda minivan and Declan slid the box inside. She perched her slender behind on the bumper, taking advantage of the shade provided by the open hatch. Michelle was keenly aware of the damage too much sun could do and didn’t like to be out in it without a slathering of sunscreen. The mirror reflected back every tiny wrinkle and freckle she’d earned from her younger days frolicking on the beach. She still loved being outside in the summer, though. She’d always been a beach girl.

“What are your summer plans?” she asked.

“Going to spend at least a couple weeks at my parents’ lake house. I’m going to chill, too, but I’ll be spending a lot of time at the ninja gym. And I’ll be around when practices start up again in August.”

“How’s the ninja thing going?”

“Really well. Business has been picking up every week since the show started up again. I’m up to teaching four classes a week. You should swing by and check it out sometime. I’m sure you’d be a natural. The best ninjas are long and lean.”

That perfectly described her. Michelle was tall, with a tight, toned body. She’d worked out through both pregnancies and was out running as soon as her body would allow afterward. Her tummy was tighter now than it was when she was twenty, which was saying something since that was a couple decades ago—give or take a couple years. Maybe it was vain, but Michelle was not going to surrender her body to middle age.

“Thanks, but I don’t know if that’s my thing. I’d fall right on my face.”

“I can teach you some moves.”

Michelle smirked. “I’m sure you could. Speaking of practice, I was hoping to get the returning girls together at least once in July for an impromptu pick-up session.”

“That’s a great idea. Maybe I’ll do it with the boys, too.”

“Let me know if you want to schedule it together. We can coordinate. I like the boys and girls practicing together,” Michelle said.

“Yeah, it’s fun, although it does make my guys’ play sloppy sometimes.”

“Why’s that? I think it’s a good challenge for my girls.”

Declan chuckled. “You don’t remember raging hormones? The boys can get a little distracted when the girls’ volleyball team is around.”

“Girls do not have to take hormonal boys into account when they decide how to dress. Your boys need to get a grip on themselves and focus.”

“I’m sure most of them do, after practice.” Declan grinned.

Michelle realized what she said, and embarrassment added to the heat flush on her cheeks. “That’s not what I meant, and you know it!” She smacked his arm. “I do not want that image in my brain.”

“It’s not just the girls that distract them, you know.”

She stared at him.

“I’ve overheard some of the boys talking about the MILFy girls’ team coach.”

“Eww, now you’re really pushing it, Dec. It’s bad enough you put the image of teenage boys drooling over their classmates in my head, I don’t even want to think about what you’re implying now.”

“You can’t hide from the truth, Winthrop. Guys notice these things. Why do you think there are all those stories about female teachers and their students?”

“Because those women are sick! And there are plenty of male teachers who prey on their students, too. It’s just not as ‘sexy’, so it doesn’t get as much press.”

They were silent for a moment and Michelle tried to push Declan’s sick thoughts from her mind. It was not the first time she’d heard such a thing, although she’d never been told directly that male students were talking about her. Clay sometimes teased her about being the *hot teacher*, and she always gave him the same reaction that she’d given Declan. Her husband did it to prove to her she was still a sexy momma, so she appreciated the motive—although it always felt like Clay enjoyed the idea of male students crushing on her a bit too much.

Sometimes, she wondered if Clay was angling to have some kind of hot teacher roleplay. Michelle would have felt silly doing it, but she would have indulged him if he’d asked. She liked to think she was open-minded. Clay had brought some other things up recently, and Michelle had rolled

with it. She even got into some of it. However, while she'd let Clay tease her about student crushes, she wasn't going to let Declan get away with it.

"You should be flattered, that's all," he finally said. "I wasn't suggesting you should pull one of them behind the bleachers."

"You're impossible, you know that?"

"I'm just saying it's nice to be appreciated. You don't think I've had girls flirt with me here?"

"I'm sure you have." She tried to keep from sounding patronizing. "Do you let them down easy? You'd better."

"A guy's got to be careful these days. Rumors start too easily. I just avoid them if they're persistent."

"You're never tempted?"

"I'm not disgusted like you..."

"They're just so *young*."

"You never look? Not at all?"

Michelle hedged. She didn't, not really. Not in any serious way. She wouldn't let herself go there. But, there may have been one or two boys—seniors—who were very mature, and very fit. But she never looked for more than a second, and it was only in the most abstract way. Younger men just weren't her thing.

Declan caught her hesitation. "You have! You don't want to admit it, but you have."

"*Looked* is a strong word," she prevaricated. Even that was more than she'd ever admitted to her husband. "We're not talking about me anyway!"

"Well, I was just saying, I'm not disgusted by a pretty girl—like you pretended to be with the boys, but I am good at redirecting my thoughts."

"We should change the subject."

"Did you have any teacher crushes?" Declan pressed.

Michelle never had any teachers who looked like Declan. She would have crushed hard on him, back in the day. With his shaggy, sandy hair,

goofy smile, and toned body, Declan always looked like he'd just stepped off a beach. He was also a relentless flirt, which she had given up discouraging. Now she just told herself it was fun and meaningless, but it was nice to have the attention. Declan didn't flirt with all of the teachers, though, which made her wonder how serious he was sometimes. Not that it mattered. Michelle was a happily married woman. She thought back to her own high school days.

"There was one," she confessed. "He was my AP English teacher. He was handsome, in that rumpled professor kind of way."

"That's really your type, isn't it?"

Michelle knew it was a good-natured dig at Clay, and she ignored it. "I only have one type now—my husband. But it wasn't always like that. I liked all kinds of different guys when I was young and single."

"Like hot, built gym teachers?"

Michelle laughed. "Sure, if I was single, I'd let you ravage me. Sorry, Dec. Your timing just sucks. If you invent a time machine..."

"Or you ever find yourself single..."

"That's not going to happen."

"I guess I'll keep working on that time machine then."

"You do that," Michelle said, laughing and patting his leg.

Michelle looked up when she heard her husband's voice.

"What are you two laughing about?" Clay called, crossing the parking lot, with Hayden and Jack in tow.

"Just life, man. Just life," Declan said, hopping off the bumper.

Declan held out his hand, and Hayden came running over to give him a high-five. The ten-year-old looked up to the laid-back coach, and always bugged Declan to teach him to surf. Declan said they just needed an ocean and his parents' permission. Jack hung back, the seven-year-old being the shyer of the brothers. Declan held his hand out for Jack, too, but he stood behind his father.

“Going to get to the beach this summer, little man?” Declan asked Hayden.

“For a little bit with my grandparents. I wish you could be there to show me some moves,” the boy replied.

Michelle hopped off the bumper too, ruffling her son’s dark hair. He pushed her hand away. He didn’t like being treated like a kid in front of Declan.

“I don’t think Dec wants to come on our family vacation,” she said.

“Yeah, he’s got his own stuff to do,” Clay said. “How are you doing?”

“Can’t complain. I’ve got a couple months off to chill and recharge. Life’s good. I hear you’re doing camp again,” Declan replied.

“The money’s not bad, and it means the kids get to go for free. It’s a good deal. I just wish I could convince Michelle to join us.”

“Maybe someday, you never know. I like nature, just not summer camp. If I’m going to take a summer job, I’ll tutor or something. And anyway, I have that continuing ed course this summer. I couldn’t go even if I wanted to,” Michelle said.

Clay chuckled, but it sounded forced. “I think you just scheduled it so you’d have an excuse to stay home.”

“You think ‘Chelle just wanted a couple weeks to herself?” Declan asked. The only time he didn’t refer to her by her last name was when Clay was around, probably because it would be confusing.

“Wouldn’t blame her,” Clay said.

“I don’t know what I’ll do with myself. Maybe I’ll finally get the house clean.”

“I’m sure you could find some trouble if you tried. What do you think, Clay?” Declan said.

“She could, for sure. I’ve heard the stories from her single days,” Clay concurred, an odd gleam in his eyes.

“Hey, the boys are here,” Michelle reminded them.

“Mom’s always good,” Jack chimed in.

“That’s right, Jack, I’m always good,” she repeated smugly. She caught the look on Clay’s face and knew what he was about to say. “Don’t you dare.”

“Can we just go? This is boring,” Hayden whined.

“It is boring when grown-ups stand around and talk, isn’t it?” Declan said. “Listen, if you get bored this summer, why don’t you have your mom and dad bring you by the ninja gym. I’ll show you some moves.”

Hayden brightened. “Can I? Mom? Dad?”

All Michelle could think of was her baby dropping from some bar and breaking something. She wanted her boys to grow up fearless, but she watched *American Ninja Warrior* with the boys, and it looked so dangerous to her. Clay read her expression and took the pressure off of her.

“Your mom and I will talk about it,” Clay said.

“Aww.”

“That’s not a no. If I say we’ll talk about it, we will.”

“Listen to your dad, little man. You can’t go on the obstacles if you can’t listen,” Declan said. That quieted Hayden.

“We’d really better get going. We promised the boys water ice if they were patient,” Michelle said.

“Why don’t you come with us?” Hayden suggested.

“I’d love to, but I have somewhere to be.”

“Hot date?” Clay asked.

Declan smiled. “Something like that.”

Michelle just shook her head. She knew Declan wasn’t one for commitment. There were rumors about him and one or two of the baby teachers—the ones just out of school. They weren’t that much younger than him, but they seemed so young to Michelle. Of course, she was one of those baby teachers once, and that was how she met Clay. After their talk, Michelle even pictured Declan meeting up with some freshly graduated,

perky blonde student. Michelle liked Declan, but they were at such different places in their lives. She made a face.

“What is it?” Clay asked.

“Nothing. Just a bad taste in my mouth, that’s all. Let’s get that water ice.”

“I guess I’ll see you in a couple months, when practice starts,” Declan said, reaching for Michelle.

They shared a tight hug, which lasted just a beat longer than strictly friendly. Michelle let him get his last one in for the year.

“Oh, yeah?” Clay asked, perking up.

“I told you I wanted to have some pick-up practices over the summer,” she told her husband.

“You did. You just didn’t mention Declan would be there.

“I thought it would be good to work out the teams together. Two heads are better than one, right?”

“Sure, makes sense. Spartan strong!” Clay said.

“That’s right,” Declan said.

Clay loaded his box into the back of the minivan, and Michelle got the kids settled inside. She kept an eye on Clay. He’d always acted weird around Declan and liked to make little comments, but it seemed to have been dialed up lately. Michelle chalked it up to a low-level jealousy, which she thought was silly. Sure, Declan was a good-looking guy, but he was so not her type—not for a relationship, anyway—even if Michelle was available. Which she wasn’t!

TWO

THE KIDS WERE IN BED, the sink was cleared of dishes and the house was quiet. Michelle was changed for bed—a loose, soft gray tank and pink sleep shorts—and at this point she was usually headed up to bed to read for a bit before falling asleep. She was tired, but also feeling frisky. Sometimes—when she was truly exhausted—she would take of herself quickly so she could go to sleep, but tonight she wanted to get some and went looking for Clay.

Michelle was pleased with their sex life and believed Clay would agree. They didn't go at it like rabbits anymore, like they did before the kids, but that was to be expected, wasn't it? They still made love a couple times a week, on average. She could have handled more—if she had more energy—but she was okay with it. Those first stirrings came to her at a too-young-age, and Michelle had been ready to go, whenever, wherever, from then on. Her appetite hadn't slaked with age. If there were no kids, and she had the energy she'd had even five years ago, Michelle could still go every day. But they had kids and being pulled in a thousand different directions drained her energy. They typically made love more often in the summer, when their schedule was more relaxed, but Clay would be gone for a lot of it this year.

Clay was in bed watching something with Nazis and gloomy photography. A thin, dark-haired girl looked frightened. Michelle couldn't

keep up with all the shows Clay watched. He didn't even notice she came into the room.

"Are you watching that?" she asked.

"I'm about halfway through. Why? Did you want to watch something else? We have those baking shows you like on the DVR." Clay glanced toward her but kept one eye on the screen.

"No, not in the mood for TV. I was just headed up to bed..."

Michelle had to stare at Clay for a beat before he took the hint.

"Oh yeah. I'm feeling kinda sleepy too."

She smiled and retreated upstairs to their bedroom.

Michelle settled onto the bed and had just opened her book when Clay came into the room. *Took you long enough*, she thought. He looked confused, but she smiled and he realized she was just messing with him. Clay closed the door behind him and clicked the lock. Their kids didn't always understand the concept of privacy.

Clay threw off his clothes as he walked toward the bed. Michelle appreciated that he'd kept himself in decent shape. She had friends with husbands his age who lugged around big beer guts and were shoddy with their grooming. Michelle took great pains to maintain herself, and she was glad Clay at least made an effort. He shaved his head because his hair had receded, and he pulled it off well. He kept his graying goatee neatly trimmed. Maybe he wasn't toned like her, but he was in good shape for his late-forties, and she liked his chest hair. Michelle liked her men manly. He trimmed down below, which she really appreciated on those occasions when she went down on him. One of the reasons Michelle kept herself waxed was because Clay liked it, so why shouldn't he do something? He was already semi-erect. Michelle had always been well-pleased with his cock. Clay wasn't a porn star, but he had more than enough to get the job done.

“Whoa, slow down there, cowboy. Do you think you’re just going to jump on top of me?”

“Actually, no.”

“You have a plan?” Her eyebrow raised.

Clay went into the top of their closet, and she knew what the plan was. He came down with a small bag containing the sex toys he’d bought for her birthday back in March. Michelle was still not convinced this was really a present for her, but she tried to keep an open mind.

“We don’t need those,” she protested, but Clay brought them to the bed anyway.

“You always say that, and then you always really enjoy it.”

Michelle leaned up from her pile of pillows and kissed him. “But we don’t *need* them. What’s wrong with the old-fashioned way?”

“I love the old-fashioned way, but I like to mix it up, too.”

Michelle didn’t feel like they were mixing it up much lately. Clay almost always tried to use the toys when they had sex—unless she put her foot down. She wondered if he was having some sort of mid-life crisis—or worse—suddenly thought she was boring in bed. Michelle wasn’t into being hung from the ceiling, or any other *Fifty Shades* stuff, but no guy had ever complained she was boring in bed. But then, they had been married for fifteen years. And it had been even longer than that since she’d had another opinion. Whatever the cause, Clay had found a kinky streak lately, and while some of it made her hot, it also made Michelle a little uncomfortable.

Clay reached into the bag and Michelle pulled him into a kiss, hoping to distract him. She bit his bottom lip and slithered her tongue toward his. He took the bait, moving his hand to her breast. She broke the kiss long enough to cast her top aside, resuming the kiss with even more passion. She reached into his lap and felt him harden in her grip.

Michelle gasped through their kiss when he teased her thick, sensitive nipple. She had small breasts, but her nipples turned dark red and thick when aroused. She loved having those nipples played with. They were so sensitive she'd even climaxed from attention there, and she loved the way Clay worshipped her tits.

Michelle reclined on the bed, pulling Clay with her. He went for that spot on her neck, sending chills down her spine. She knew most people had their spot, but Michelle had always been embarrassed by how sensitive hers was. A guy who found it could turn her to jelly in a second. Clay nibbled there and she gasped, tightening her grip on his cock. He dipped a hand inside her shorts, finding her smooth slit already damp. They locked lips one more time before Clay kissed his way down to her tits. She sighed, laying her head back into the pillows and closing her eyes. His cock slipped from her grasp as he moved lower.

Clay knew her body so well. The downside was that lovemaking could be rote, but the upside was that he got her going so effortlessly. His fingertip worked the slick groove between her lips, brushing her clit with every motion. His tongue lashed at her nipple. Michelle was on fire, and she gasped his name. She wiggled out of her shorts and hoped he took the hint. Michelle was ready if he wanted to roll on top of her now.

It wasn't his hand that returned to her body, but an object. Michelle knew what she felt, but he hadn't switched it on yet because she didn't hear or feel the telltale buzzing. Her eyes snapped open, and she looked down to see Clay brushing the tip of a slender pink vibrator between her lips.

"Clay," she whined.

"Relax, babe, it's going to be fun," he mumbled, letting his lips briefly leave her tits.

"But..."

Her complaint was cut off when he switched on the toy. Its tapered tip didn't even have to be on her clit for the sweet vibrations to excite her.

Michelle cried out and grabbed a fistful of the blanket. Clay was right. The little vibrator felt good. Very good. He encouraged her to use it on herself when he wasn't around, but she didn't want to. She told him it was only fun when he did it, which was mostly true. Michelle just didn't want to become addicted to the thing, if she was truly being honest. He swept it into her cleft, pressing deeper, and when it nudged her clit, she cried out. The pleasure was almost too intense, and she wished he started on a lower setting.

She moaned breathlessly.

Clay moved the toy lower, slipping it inside her. He was teasing her. Michelle didn't think she liked to be teased until Clay started doing it. She thought it was fun now—within reason. It felt good inside her, but not nearly as good as when he had it where it belonged. Michelle worked her hips at the toy, but it was too slender to fill her. It was meant to tease her clit, not be used like a dildo, but Clay had that covered, too.

“Oh...Clay...” she whimpered. He brought the toy near her clit and circled around, just not touching it. He wouldn't let her come—not yet.

“See, babe, you wanted it, didn't you?” he taunted, grinning up at her.

Michelle nodded vigorously. “Mmhm, yes...”

“Trust me. I know what you like.”

He briefly touched it to her clit.

“Yes!”

Michelle was right on the edge of orgasm, and Clay kept her there. He used to do this when he went down on her sometimes, but that didn't torture her the same way the toy did. The toy made her feel like she was going to melt into a puddle. It also kept her distracted enough that she didn't notice Clay reaching for a second toy. She whined when she felt the fat head against her lips and shook her head lightly, but before she could voice her protest, Clay nudged the dildo forward, spreading her lips. She bit her

bottom lip and tensed. The dildo was always a little uncomfortable at first, but Clay had become an expert at getting her to enjoy it.

Clay had this down to a science, and she gradually relaxed under his dual attack. The slender vibrator buzzed all around her clit, rocking her body with intense pleasure, while the fat dildo gradually worked inside her, spreading her drenched pussy wide open. Michelle had been with a couple large guys in her single days and understood the pitfalls of a large man. If a guy didn't know what he was doing, it just hurt. This wasn't Clay's cock, but he still needed skill, and he had it in spades. He discarded the little vibrator and focused on the thick dildo spreading her open, now that she was accustomed to it. The dildo was lubricated by her arousal and easily slid in and out of her. Her moans came from deeper in her chest.

"That's it, babe, that's it. If you just let go, you love that huge cock, don't you?"

Michelle nodded hard, eyes squeezed shut. The sensation of being filled by the big toy was just as intense as when he used the little vibrator, but so different. Although it was spongy and very realistic, she wasn't tricked into thinking the dildo was the real thing, but when Clay found a nice rhythm and fucked her with it, it was like being with a large man.

"I love seeing how hot it makes you...taking that huge cock," Clay encouraged, moving the toy faster.

The dirty talk was also a recent development, and while it inflamed her in the moment, it left Michelle feeling uneasy in the aftermath. She didn't know how to feel that he was so focused on the toy being a *cock*, and the dirty talk he used when he used it on her kept escalating. It vaguely reminded her of how she would tease him when they first got together—he loved stories of her past sexual encounters—but the tone now was so different.

"That's it, babe. Fuck it, babe."

Michelle indeed pushed her hips at the dildo, taking it so deep. Clay held it at an angle that it brushed her clit with every thrust, and she felt the throbbing in her core expand through her body. She was going to come—and come hard. Her breathing was ragged and her moans high-pitched. Michelle had always been more of a moaner in bed. She only talked in response to Clay.

“Look at it, babe. Look at that big, black cock inside you. Come on, babe. Fuck him.”

She looked down, surprised to see the realistic black dildo nearly disappearing inside her. It was just so *big*. Watching Clay use the toy—rather than just feeling it—triggered something primal in her, and her moans turned aggressive.

“Fuck him! Fuck him, Michelle! You want it, don’t you?” Clay growled.

Michelle nodded, then choked out a guttural, “Yes!”

“You want him!”

“Yes!”

“Fuck that big, black cock!”

She threw her head back and cried out, an intense climax driving through her body. Michelle lost her mind for a moment—the way she always did when she came so hard—and was a quivering, moaning mass of flesh. Clay kept fucking her with the toy, until she violently pushed his hand away. Michelle felt like she’d pass out if he didn’t stop.

In a flash, Clay replaced the dildo with his own cock, hard and strong. Michelle cried out when he brutally thrust into her. She wrapped her legs around him, drawing him into her. This was what she wanted. It didn’t matter how good the toy felt. Michelle wanted flesh on flesh. She wanted her husband inside her. Their lovemaking was frenzied. It felt like Clay couldn’t fuck her hard enough.

“Fuck...Michelle...fuck...” he groaned.

He felt different inside her after being opened up by the large dildo. She was still so stimulated by her last orgasm that she felt herself ramping up to another as soon as Clay was inside her. Clay was on the edge too, apparently. Before she could get there, Clay exploded, shuddering on top of her as his seed shot deep inside her. Michelle only felt a pang of disappointment. She already came, so she couldn't complain, could she?

Clay stayed on top of her, sweaty and gasping, until she pushed him off. Michelle was sweating too—even with the windows open and the ceiling fan running—and she wanted to catch her breath. The aftershocks of her climax were finally fading, leaving Michelle wondering what just happened.

Michelle was skeptical when Clay presented her with the birthday presents. She asked why he thought they needed the toys, and he said they didn't need them. He just thought it would be fun to try something different. She couldn't help being defensive, but she promised to keep an open mind. The slim vibrator seemed normal enough, but the dildo scared her. It was huge, very realistic, and black. It even had testicles at the base. She'd stared at him when she first held it.

"I just thought it was something you might like," Clay had said.

"Really?"

"Let's just give it a try."

It felt shameful to admit after her protests, but she loved the vibrator right away. She'd always thought sex toys were unnecessary, but that thing rocked her world. She got the appeal. Getting Michelle on board with the dildo took some work. She was too intimidated to even look at it the first time Clay brought it to bed. The first time he used it on her was tough. It hurt. Michelle told him it was too big and pushed him away. Clay fell all over himself apologizing and begged for another chance. Once she calmed down, she agreed to try again. The second time went better, and after that Clay worked out the magic formula of using the two toys together. The

vibrator got her so worked up that she was ready for anything. Once she was soaking wet, Clay could deploy the dildo.

Clay got really verbal with the dildo, encouraging her to enjoy it, and “open herself up” to it. As time went on, his dirty talk became more graphic and he referred to the dildo as a *cock*. It disturbed Michelle, but she hadn’t worked up the nerve to ask Clay about it—not until now. Their lovemaking tonight was the most graphic Clay had been.

Michelle turned her head and watched Clay. He looked immensely satisfied. She wanted to talk but was unsure what to say. She began with, “Did you have fun?”

“I always have fun in bed with you. I feel like I should be asking you that question.”

“Couldn’t you tell?” she asked playfully.

Clay chuckled. “Yeah, it seemed like you had a good time. I don’t know why you’re so resistant to…” he paused, searching for the word. “Playing. I know you like it as much as I do.”

“I do,” she replied. Michelle didn’t want to lie, although she wondered if she enjoyed it quite as much as Clay. “But I don’t need it every time.”

“I know. You like it the old-fashioned way. I told you, I do too.”

“I guess I’m starting to wonder about that,” she replied frankly.

“Don’t think that. I love you, Michelle.”

“I know that. That’s not what I meant. But are you…bored?”

“No, never! Babe, you’re hotter than ever. How could I ever get bored?”

“Some people think all guys get bored eventually—it doesn’t matter who they are with.”

“Yeah, I’ve heard that. ‘Billy Joel divorced Christie Brinkley.’ It’s not like that, I swear.”

“Then what’s going on, Clay? You just decided it was time to introduce toys into the bedroom fifteen years into our marriage for no reason?”

Clay was silent, and it looked like a confession was on the tip of his tongue. Michelle's heart pounded, and it dawned on her that she was afraid of what he might say. Anything could come out of his mouth. He seemed so fixated on the big, realistic dildo. Was he trying to tell her he was gay, or at least bi?

"I was reading an article about things couples do to keep their sex lives spicy," Clay said. He quickly added, "Not because they are already bored, but to make sure they don't get that way. That's all I'm trying to do."

Relief washed over Michelle. It didn't feel like the whole truth, but given what he could have said, she was happy to accept that answer. "So, the article recommended bringing in toys?"

"Oh, that wasn't all. It suggested role play, too. I guess I've been trying to do a little of that, too."

"Okay."

Clay's answer made sense, but something was missing, she knew it. She knew him too well. "So that's what the dirty talk about...uh...dicks is all about?"

"Yeah, just trying to spice it up, see what you might be into."

Michelle smiled as she thought about what he'd said while using the dildo. "So, you think I might be into 'big, black dicks'?"

Clay laughed nervously. "I think I said *cock*."

"Sorry. You think I'm into *big, black cocks*?"

"It sounds dumb when you put it that way."

"What makes you even think I want that? Why would you go there?" She was laughing now too.

"I don't know if I thought that. I was just trying to think of something dirty, and it fit. But come on, Michelle, we've been together a long time. You never think about other guys?"

"I don't need anyone else."

“That’s not what I asked. You must have fantasies, ‘Chelle. Channing Tatum never sneaks in there? You did love *Magic Mike*.”

Michelle felt her cheeks going red. “That’s a classic of American cinema! Sure. Everybody has crazy little fantasies. I’m sure you do too.”

“Of course.”

“But it doesn’t mean anything. It doesn’t mean I would *do* anything.”

“Of course not. But what if you could have a hall pass?”

“I don’t want a hall pass. Why? Do you?”

“No. I can honestly say I have no desire to sleep with another woman.”

“But you’d give me a hall pass?”

“I didn’t say that. I was just asking, if you could have one, would you take it?”

Michelle was more confused now than ever. She had no idea what Clay was talking about. Real people didn’t do things like hall passes, did they? She couldn’t imagine. Michelle would never give Clay a pass to sleep with another woman. She never thought he’d do something like that either, but now she had to wonder.

“No. First of all, in the real world, that would only lead to problems. I’d never risk everything we have for a one-night stand.”

“Even if the sex was incredible? Even if you really enjoyed it, and you knew I’d be perfectly fine with it?”

“Would you be fine with it?”

“I’m just throwing hypotheticals out here, Michelle. Don’t get hung up on that part. What if you knew I would never find out?”

“That’s worse! It’s one thing to have a hall pass. It’s another to cheat.”

“Fine. If I was into it, you wouldn’t take a hall pass? What if you ran into Channing Tatum in the produce aisle?”

Michelle considered throwing Declan’s offer of a drink in Clay’s face, but she was afraid he might like it. “That’s not going to happen. How many times do I have to tell you? No, Clay.”

“Okay, just forget about it. I didn’t mean to piss you off.”

“I’m not pissed off, just really confused. I’m going to go get cleaned up.”

Michelle stalked into the bathroom and closed the door. Maybe she was a little angry, but she didn’t know that she should be. Clay was only talking hypothetically, and maybe he had good intentions. His instinct wasn’t wrong. Although she still thought it was weird, she did really enjoy when they played with the toys. Even his dirty talk turned her on, which she didn’t want to think about too closely. *Fuck that big, black cock!* he told her. For a heartbeat, Michelle put herself there, with a strange lover, a well-endowed black man. It gave her the tingles and she banished the thought immediately. And why did Clay go *there*? Neither of them was the least bit racist, but the fantasy suggested being taken by a black man still some kind of taboo. She knew there was a lot of interracial porn. Yes, on the very rare occasion Michelle watched porn, but it was always the soft, romantic type. She did not seek out interracial porn. The weird thing was, Clay seemed even more excited by it than he expected her to be. What was that about?

She was exhausted and couldn’t over-analyze it any longer. It was best to let it drop anyway. Michelle would give Clay the benefit of the doubt. It was sweet of him to try something new—even if it was out there. She should be making the same kind of effort. She would have to think of something to do for him before he went off to work at the summer camp.

THREE

THEY SPENT the next couple weeks doing as many things together as a family as they could before the busy part of the summer hit them. Michelle was sad to think they would all be spending most of the summer apart. Clay's job as a co-director of Camp Lenape meant he would be away virtually the entire summer. After his first week there, the kids would be joining him for three weeks. Michelle would have them back for a few days, but then they would be off with her parents for a couple weeks at their Shore house. She would spend a few days with them at the Shore, but she had to get back for the start of volleyball team practices. Michelle wasn't sure if she should feel sad or liberated that she had most of the summer free of her family. Clay promised he'd try to get home a couple weekends a month so they could spend some time together, so she had that to look forward to.

Compacting all of that family fun into two weeks left Michelle exhausted. As she came in from her run that morning, she thought she just might spend the whole week lounging in the hammock in the backyard—reading and drinking wine. It would be the true start of her summer vacation.

Michelle went straight to the kitchen and grabbed a bottle of water. She caught Clay staring at her. "Am I that gross?" she asked.

“I think you look really hot, actually,” he replied, reaching for her.

“Hot as in sweaty and worn out.”

She pivoted away from him, slipping out of his grasp. Michelle had done her usual five miles, but the morning air was thick with humidity and she had to push hard to get through. She doffed her loose tank top halfway through the run, finishing in just her sports bra and black leggings. She’d learned to ignore the comments guys shouted as they drove by. Didn’t those guys know that shit wasn’t acceptable anymore? Besides, Michelle knew she looked good—she didn’t need their input. She worked hard for that body, and she wasn’t going to cover it up and roast because men couldn’t behave. She might have quirked a smile from their attention, but she’d never admit it.

Michelle knew Clay liked her in the multicolored, racerback sports bra. He’d bought it for her. If Clay had his way—she suspected—she’d run around in workout gear all the time. He grabbed for her again.

“Come on, hon. The kids are completely distracted in the other room. They’ll never look up from their screens.”

Clay got her again—their kitchen wasn’t that big—and hauled her close by the waist. He kissed her, and Michelle melted against those familiar, sensual lips, but pressing against him only highlighted how sweaty she was. She tried to pull away again, but he held her by the butt. Michelle tipped her water bottle on his head.

“Hey!” Clay shouted, jumping back and wiping at the cold water on his scalp.

Michelle laughed. “You need a cold shower, but not right now. I’m going up there. I promise, you can have your way with me tonight. You only have a couple more days to ravish me, and then I’ll be left to my own devices.”

“At least now you have some devices.”

“I think I need a few more lessons on how to use them,” she suggested, smiling.

“Really?” Clay brightened.

“Tonight, babe. But I really have to get in the shower. That photographer is coming at noon and I need to get myself and the house ready.”

“Okay. I need to run some errands, but I promise I’ll be back in time. I’ll even take the boys with me so they’re out of your hair.”

“Are you sure you’ll be back in time? You need to be back by 11:30 because the boys are going to need to get cleaned up and changed for the pictures.”

“We’ll be back, I promise.”

“Just think about the reward you’ll be getting tonight if you keep me happy,” she said, punctuating her point with a deep soul kiss to keep him wanting more.

Michelle left him in the kitchen to think about that and went upstairs to shower. After setting the water temperature, she peeled off the sweaty workout gear and tossed it into the hamper with the thong that had been underneath. She sighed when the refreshing water hit her.

The toys had stayed stored away since that last night when things got weird. They made love several times since then, but Clay hadn’t tried to pull out his new, favorite trick—and he seemed disappointed about having to hold back. Michelle felt guilty. She might have overreacted, she conceded, and it had more to do with her own feelings than it did with Clay. She knew he loved her and didn’t mean anything crazy in introducing the toys, but the way he used them stirred up strange feelings and left her confused.

Clay had gone a long way to reassuring her that he wasn’t bored, but she still thought some part of him must be if he was looking for ways to spice up the bedroom. She could let that go—mostly. Michelle was more

concerned with the particular fantasy Clay chose. Why did he even bring up sexual hall passes? She was even more concerned that he seemed so excited when talking about other men's dicks. Michelle really wanted to believe that was all about her. She couldn't understand it, but maybe he had a fantasy about a threesome with another guy. Didn't most men want threesomes with two women? Her mind kept going back to the same disturbing place; was Clay trying to tell her he was gay? Or bi? No, Michelle just couldn't accept that her husband might be gay. She knew him too well. She was sure of it. Could he be bi? That would be just as shocking, but was it something she could live with? Could Michelle be the good wife and indulge his fantasies?

The other side of the equation—the one she really didn't want to ponder—was how she reacted. The dirty words her husband used, the scenario he set up for her, made her orgasm intensely. Michelle really did not want, or need, to sleep with another man, so why did Clay suggesting the fantasy turn her on so much? Michelle wanted to believe it didn't mean anything, but two semesters of college psychology made her think there may be something deeper. Her past suggested that was true, but that was something she didn't like to think about. In her wilder, younger days, Michelle had a threesome, of sorts.

Michelle hadn't asked for the threesome, and it wasn't anything that was planned. She was fooling around with her college boyfriend, Rob, in his apartment living room when one of his roommates, Perry, walked in on them. Rob sent Perry to his room and they kept going. Michelle couldn't recall why they didn't just go to Rob's room—not that it would have mattered. The walls in that dive apartment were paper thin. They were probably just too drunk to make it to Rob's room. They kept fooling around and Michelle looked up and saw that Perry was watching them again. It was no surprise. Perry always had a crush on her. Before she could say anything, Perry crossed the room and started touching her. Rob didn't stop him.

Michelle didn't stop him, even though she knew she should. It was an intense experience, and Michelle blamed horniness and booze for letting it get as far as it did. Things went way too far before she ran away and locked herself in Rob's bedroom.

Clay knew about that threesome, most of it anyway. It was his favorite of her past sexual exploits. She confessed that Perry touched her, and she was too drunk and horny to stop him. She also passively accepted it when Perry put her hand on his dick. Jerking off Perry while Rob went down on her was surreal. It felt like she was watching someone else have sex, rather than doing it herself. Michelle blamed that feeling for letting it go further. She ended up on the couch, making out with both guys while they touched her, a cock in each hand. She told Clay that was when she pushed both guys away and fled, locking herself in Rob's room.

The whole truth was too slutty to confess. This had been early in their relationship and she couldn't tell Clay how much she'd lost control—how they got her on her hands and knees on that couch, and how she'd sucked Perry until she blew his load in her mouth, while Rob fucked her. Perry came so fast she didn't have time to react and push him away. Michelle did run away, but only after she climaxed with Rob and she finally came to her senses.

God, she hadn't thought about any of this in years. It still felt like it must have happened to someone else. She couldn't believe she'd ever been so wild—or so stupid. Nineteen-year-old Michelle loved attention, and when she drank too much, she didn't care much how she got it. She was the girl who'd make out with a girlfriend at the bar to drive the guys around them crazy.

Clay had been so excited when she told him about that night. It led to a fun night in bed, but Michelle also went out of her way to tell Clay how the threesome soured her on Rob. She didn't understand how Rob could share her if he really cared about her. Had Clay forgotten that part?

Michelle pushed all the negative thoughts away. She wanted to be a supportive wife. If this was something Clay was really into, she wanted to give it another try, and then maybe he would open up to her about what was really on his mind. She was pleased with her open-mindedness as she lathered her hair. She did all her best thinking in the shower.

The trip down memory lane had her so distracted that she didn't realize she was no longer alone. She started with a yelp when she felt Clay's hands on her. The dirty little bugger had followed her! His hands were freezing, but the warm water flowing down her body soon warmed them. He laced his fingers in her hair, massaging her scalp as he helped her rinse the shampoo out of her long, chestnut hair.

"Mmm, that feels nice," she cooed.

"Why don't we do this more often?" Clay asked.

"I don't know. The boys, I guess?"

Once her hair was clean, Michelle turned and kissed him. They didn't have one of those giant, modern showers, so it was a tight fit as they stood in the tub between the sea-foam tile wall and the shower curtain. Clay kneaded her ass, while she reached for his thick cock. He was aroused already. Clay loved her ass. He blocked most of the spray from her, but stray water needled her face. Shower sex could be fun, but now she recalled it also had its downsides.

Clay took the body wash and lathered her body, hands sliding over her smooth, wet skin. Michelle loved his soft touch but was surprised by how quickly she became aroused. She'd always been sexual, so it didn't usually take much, but she felt all the tingles as soon as Clay began touching her. He spent a lot of time caressing her breasts, and Michelle moaned when he lightly pinched her nipples. She tightened her grip on his prick and tugged it toward her, hoping he would take the hint that she didn't need more foreplay.

Instead, Clay rinsed his hands and took the showerhead down from its mount and used the wand to rinse her. Clay turned her to face away from him and rubbed her long back as the water hit it. He brought the showerhead around her body, close to her breasts, letting the stinging needles of water jet right onto her tender nipples. Michelle's moan was low and sultry, and she backed her tight butt into his cock. He kept teasing her nipples until she couldn't stand it anymore, and she covered her tits with her hands. Michelle panted in the humid shower.

"Honey..." she moaned.

"Yeah?" he asked, sweeping her heavy, wet hair aside to kiss her neck.

"You don't have to tease me. I'm ready."

"But I like teasing you." She couldn't see his face but heard the amusement in his voice.

Clay swept the showerhead down her toned stomach then lower. The needles of water on her overheated mound made her squirm, but Michelle jumped and gasped when he gave the showerhead a twist and turned on the massage jets.

"Uhn...god..."

Michelle backed her ass up hard against his cock, grinding on him. Clay held her hip and kept the jets focused on her pussy. The pounding water sent intense pleasure throbbing through her body. Clay used to love making her come with the showerhead when they had shower sex. She didn't know why, but she just never did it for herself. He turned the showerhead so that the jets went up and down her slit, and every time he returned to the top she jumped and cried out. It vibrated right to her clit, and Michelle couldn't stand it. She held onto the wall as her knees went weak. She squirmed under the jets, unsure if she needed to escape or focus them. The pleasure was that intense. Finally, he locked the jets right above her clit and Michelle wailed. The kids were downstairs, but she couldn't help herself. She braced her hands on the wall and hung her head, mouth open as she tried to

breathe. Michelle came fast and hard, nearly folding in half when it hit her. She swatted the showerhead away, afraid she might tumble over.

“Oh my god,” she gasped when she caught her breath. “Oh my god.” She trembled from her fingertips to her toes and was afraid to let go of the wall lest she fall over. Michelle squeezed her thighs tight against the pleasure that still throbbed through her. Her clitoral orgasms were always so powerful, wracking her body in a way others didn’t.

“We really need to do this more often,” Clay pronounced, pleased with himself.

Michelle spun on him, driving him against the back wall. He almost slipped, but Michelle didn’t allow him to fall. She kissed him hard, but only for a second. She dropped to her knees in the tub and sucked him into her mouth. Michelle didn’t tease or use finesse. She just sucked his shaft hard and pumped the base with her hand. She attacked his cock, and it put Clay back on his heels. He held her head, but he didn’t need to force her. Michelle devoured him. It was the first blowjob she’d given him in ages.

“Michelle...shit...” Clay grunted.

His fingers tightened on her head, and Michelle knew what that meant. She had a wicked thought. *I’m in the shower anyway.* She pulled back and jacked him hard, staring up at him. The water beat on her back. Clay stared down at her wide-eyed. He exploded across her cheek and nose. Michelle redirected him, and Clay finished on her tits as she pumped him. Clay looked deflated and stunned, but thrilled. Michelle beamed, feeling dirty and sexy. *Well, that wasn’t boring,* she thought. She let him look at his mess for a moment then turned and rinsed it off her face and tits. Clay offered her a hand to pull her to her feet.

“That was awesome,” Clay praised her.

She kissed his cheek. “You got me in the right mood, I guess.”

“I need to know how to do that again.”

“Well, I was thinking about you and what you were going to do with your bag of tricks tonight,” she said, relishing the surprise on his face.

“I’d better not disappoint.”

“You’d better not,” she agreed. “Feels like the hot water’s running out. I’m out of here.”

Michelle left him in the shower and wrapped herself in a fluffy towel. Playing with Clay and blowing his mind was fun. She was in a great mood. Maybe he was right about mixing things up.

FOUR

THE REST of the morning went by in a whirlwind. Michelle wanted to make sure the backyard was just right for the family pictures they were taking. Michelle was surprised when Clay told her he wanted to get the family pictures done. He wanted them done quickly too, before they parted for the summer. It had been ages since their last family portrait, but he always balked at the price. She was suspicious when Clay said he heard about a deal, but she checked out the photographer's website and his work was quite good.

The backyard was Michelle's sanctuary. The family ate many of their dinners in the summer outside on the low deck, where Clay manned the grill. She'd miss that this year. She loved to lounge in her hammock with a glass of wine at sunset, looking up at the twinkling lights she'd strung across the yard. Her birdfeeders were always bustling with cardinals and blue jays and squirrels. She didn't mind the seed thieves like others did. Michelle found squirrels amusing. Her mother always hated it when squirrels got at the birdfeeders, but Michelle didn't mind the ingenious little furballs.

Michelle collected stray sticks and children's toys and mowed the lawn. She artfully draped a white sheet across the ivy-covered trellis in the corner of the yard, thinking it might make for a pretty backdrop. Finished, she

needed to shower again before changing into the flowy, blue sundress she laid out for the photoshoot. A floral pattern of eyelets covered the thin cotton bodice. One couldn't really see much through them, but she wore a bright white tank top underneath anyway. Her men would be wearing blue and white too—if they ever got home. They were a few minutes late and she was getting nervous. Clay was notorious for losing track of time. She would text him when she was done with her makeup.

She just finished applying a touch of mascara to her cat-slanted eyes when the doorbell rang. Clay shouldn't need to ring the doorbell, but the photographer shouldn't be there yet. The last thing she needed was the photographer coming early when Clay was running late with the boys. The doorbell rang again, and she cursed under her breath. A quick application of pale lipstick and she was done.

"Coming," she announced on her way to the front door.

Michelle opened the door and found the proverbial tall, dark stranger standing there. His smile blinded her, and she just stood there staring at him.

"I'm looking for Mr. or Mrs. Winthrop?"

The stranger's voice was smooth and deep, fitting such a large man. Although she was a bit taller than average, he loomed over her, filling the doorway. A large, strange man at the door should have been threatening, but he exuded calm. Everything about him was pleasing.

"I, uh, I'm Mrs. Winthrop. Michelle, I mean. I'm Michelle."

"I was sure you were the nanny."

"Nope, no nanny here."

"No one in their right mind would hire a nanny as pretty as you anyway. I'm Wes Charles, the photographer. Hope it's not a problem I'm a little early."

"You're a smooth one, Wes Charles. You caught the *Mrs.* part, right?"

“It’s still okay to compliment a pretty lady, isn’t it? It doesn’t mean I have an agenda.”

“I’ll take your word for it.”

Michelle finally noticed his out-stretched hand and took it. The hand was huge, and his handshake conveyed quiet power. She realized she was grinning like a fool but couldn’t help herself. She may have teased him about it, but Wes Charles was damned charming, and he was even handsomer than in the photos on his website. His hair was grown out more than on his website, short twists of curls shooting everywhere. She liked the controlled chaos. He surely wasn’t hitting on her when he was about to shoot her family portrait. He was probably just angling for a bigger tip. Michelle wasn’t even sure if one tipped a photographer.

“May I come in?” Wes asked.

“Oh, jeez. Sorry. I was, uhm, distracted. You caught me getting ready.”

Wes tilted his head like he was regarding her with his photographer’s eye. Michelle felt heat rise to her freckled cheeks. Her damp hair was swept over her left shoulder and she self-consciously twisted it in her fingers.

“You’re ready.”

“Is that so?”

“I’m the professional. You can trust me.”

Wes came through the door, almost brushing her as he passed, and she felt a charge between them, like static electricity. Michelle watched him walk into the house and decided his muscular butt looked even better in his tight, strategically ripped jeans than his broad chest looked in the black, V-neck t-shirt stretched across it. *He doesn’t need the charm*, she thought. She was sure he had no problem with the ladies, looking how he did.

“Sorry, my husband isn’t home yet. He’s out running errands with the kids. I’ll text him and tell him to hurry.”

“There’s no rush. I can use the time to look around and set up. Where would you like me to shoot?”

“The backyard. It’s through here.”

Michelle led Wes through to the backyard and it occurred to her how strange it was to be alone in her house with a strange man. She wasn’t the type to be concerned by such a thing, but it made her more aware of his size and his presence. It was probably all in her head, but Michelle swore she felt Wes’s eyes on her as she walked ahead of him. She could imagine what Clay would say. *You wish he was watching you.*

“This is a great space, Michelle. I can see why you want to do the photos out here.”

“Thanks. It’s kind of my sanctuary, on those rare occasions I have some time to myself.”

“It’s important to take care of yourself. The light is great. I love the way it filters through the trees. It almost feels like a secret garden. You’d never guess you’re smack in the middle of the suburbs.”

“That’s how I’ve always felt!”

“I’d make this my retreat, too.”

Wes fixed her with that smile again, and this time she noticed his rich brown eyes. She guessed Wes was in his early thirties, but he had the eyes of an old soul, and for a moment Michelle found herself lost in them. She didn’t do a lot of portraits, but she decided she would love to paint him.

Michelle watched Wes wander the backyard, looking at it from different angles and thought this was just the sort of scenario Clay would love. If she didn’t know better, she might have guessed he arranged this. Michelle alone with an impossibly handsome black man. She blamed her husband and his crazy fantasies for the way she reacted to Wes. Wes was hardly the only handsome man she’d been around, and she didn’t usually react this way. She chuckled as she thought that Clay’s fantasies were pushing her buttons on some deep level—not that she would ever admit that to her husband. If Clay got wind of how attractive she found Wes, she’d never hear the end of it.

“I’ve got some ideas already,” Wes said. “This is going to be fun.”

“Do you enjoy your work?”

“When I have the right subject.” He flashed that smile again.

Michelle laughed. “You just can’t help yourself, can you?”

“Can you really blame me?”

“I’m going to check and see where my husband is, Mr. Charming.”

“I’ll get my gear from the car.”

Wes went back out to his car to fetch his equipment and Michelle texted Clay, who insisted he was on his way. She considered teasing him about leaving her alone with Wes, but she didn’t want to get him started. Michelle scooted upstairs for a final check in the mirror. Her hair was air drying nicely. She liked the slightly wild look her long chestnut locks took on when she let her hair dry naturally. It was just so thick she didn’t usually have the time. She’d gone back and forth on leaving it down and ultimately decided she would. She was having a good hair day.

The bedroom overlooked the backyard and Michelle watched from the upstairs window as Wes went about setting up his equipment. She was pleased he did not break out an extensive lighting rig. She preferred as much natural light as possible. It was gratifying to see that Wes agreed. Watching the photographer from the safety of her bedroom window, she laughed at the way she reacted at the front door. She was a grown woman—she was a mother—she wasn’t supposed to act like some crushing schoolgirl when she met an attractive man. She resolved to play it cool when she went downstairs.

Wes squatted by a camera case and looked over his shoulder when he heard Michelle come into the yard. Michelle purposely avoided looking at his butt. She asked, “Can I help you with anything? Would you like a drink?”

“Maybe later. It’s not too warm yet. I’m good to go, I think. Just need the rest of your family.”

“I texted Clay. He’s on his way.”

“Cool. In the meantime, you can help me get used to the light out there.”

Wes stood with an expensive DSLR in his hands, which he hoisted to his eye. Michelle was suddenly self-conscious, fixed by the camera lens. She quickly turned away, a sweep of hair veiling her face.

“That’s not necessary,” Michelle said, holding up a hand.

“You asked how you could help. This will give me something of a head start. I can get a feel for the lighting and the best way to shoot you.”

Even as she tried to hide, Wes circled Michelle and snapped away at her. She couldn’t help laughing, and she gradually surrendered, pushing her hair back so he could see her smiling face. Wes didn’t give direction, but just let Michelle react naturally. Once she relaxed, it was easy—even fun—to have her own impromptu photoshoot. It reminded Michelle of the old days, when she did some local modeling for print ads and a couple catalogues. She’d always loved being in front of the camera then, and Wes was bringing that feeling back.

“What an amazing, smile,” Wes encouraged. “You really are stunning. Your cheek bones are incredible. I think you missed your calling. You should have been a model.”

“I kinda was,” she admitted, hoping to catch Wes off guard. He was way too sure of himself.

“Where would I have seen you? The cover of *Vogue*? *Cosmo*? You could easily do *Shape* with that body.”

“Please...stop. *This body* has had two kids,” she replied, blushing again.

“No one would guess.”

Michelle posed by her favorite tree and Wes kept snapping away. Her body moved fluidly, naturally, like it had a mind of its own. “Thanks.”

“I think I have it now. I’m sure I saw you in a Victoria’s Secret catalogue,” Wes said, with a sly grin.

“Oh my god! I don’t think so.”

“That’s too bad. But it’s never too late.”

“You’re just too much.”

“I think I’m just right.”

Michelle laughed heartily and thought how Wes would fit right in with some of the photographers she worked with back in the day. Most of them, even though they were middle-aged, were always on the make, even with the girls her age. She was in her late teens and early 20s back then and never took it seriously. They were not, however, as handsome as Wes. If they were, they wouldn’t have had to resort to empty promises of furthering the models’ careers to get laid. Michelle may have hooked up with a photographer or two, but only because she liked the guys, not to get ahead. She didn’t believe their lies and would never sell herself for work anyway. But if asked about it, she would claim those memories were hazy; just like she would never admit to the couple lingerie photoshoots she did back then.

Wes directed her onto the hammock—one of Michelle’s favorite places—and she hopped up onto it, giggling as it swung wildly behind her. Her flowy sundress flew up as her bare feet went into the air, but she couldn’t smooth it down without toppling back into the hammock. Michelle didn’t quite flash him, but Wes got some great shots of her long, toned legs scissoring in the air. It was just as she was wrestling the hammock under control that she noticed Clay was standing on the deck. She didn’t understand why, but Michelle felt guilty about having so much fun with the handsome photographer. She planted her feet in the grass and stopped the hammock’s swing, hopping free.

“Don’t let me interrupt the fun,” Clay said.

“We were just killing time until you got home,” she hurriedly replied.
“You were late as usual.”

“Yeah, sorry about that.”

Wes extended his free hand to Clay. “I’m Wes, the photographer your wife hired.”

“I figured, y’know, with the camera and all,” Clay replied.

“I hope you don’t mind that I borrowed your wife for a few minutes.”

“Not at all. It looks like she’s having a good time. She’s all yours. I’m going to duck in and make sure the boys are ready.”

“I’ll take care of it,” Michelle interrupted. “I want to make sure everything is right.” She turned to Wes. “We’ll be right back out.”

“Take your time,” Wes answered.

Michelle brushed past the men, unable to wipe the wry smile from her lips. *She’s all yours*, Clay had said. She thought about his bedroom fantasies and couldn’t help but wonder how literally he may have meant it. Then she laughed, realizing how absurd it was.

FIVE

MICHELLE RETURNED Clay's tight hug, they kissed, and exchanged *I love you's*. He hugged the kids, jumped into his beat-up old Jeep Cherokee and he was off to camp. Michelle rounded up the kids and ordered them inside. She preferred the kids didn't play out front unsupervised, as cars came rushing down their street much too fast. Jack went through to the backyard to play, but Hayden went in the house and plopped down on the couch to go back to his videogames. They tried to limit the kids' screen time, but it was particularly difficult in the summertime. Jack would go read, or play, but Hayden never wanted to do anything else.

"Half hour," she called in to Hayden.

"Mom," he whined.

"I mean it. It's beautiful outside."

"It's hot!"

"You're not spending the entire summer sitting in front of a screen. Better get used to it now."

Grumbles were her only reply. She could accept that. Sometimes, Michelle wondered when the rewarding part of parenting kicked in, but that wasn't fair. They were good kids. Hayden was just testing the boundaries. Michelle fetched a glass of iced tea and settled on the back deck.

Clay was leaving her with unusually mixed feelings after last night. In keeping with her pledge to stay open-minded, Michelle played it cool and didn't show her inner turmoil, but she was trying to process everything that happened the night before. Just like the last time the toys came out, things got weird in the bedroom, only this time Clay went to even wilder places.

The night started well. Michelle went into the bathroom to change, while Clay prepared the bedroom. He put on some of the emo 90s music she liked and got his bag of tricks ready. She slipped into a form-fitting babydoll. The pink-ivory lace was entirely see-through, and it closed around neck with a big keyhole slit between her breasts and had an open back. She wore a matching thong. Michelle preferred lingerie that showed off the work she put into maintaining her body, rather than flowy things that hid it. She fluffed up her hair, applied her best trappy makeup, and presented herself to Clay.

Clay was suitably impressed, unable to take his eyes off her as she walked across the room and put one knee up on the bed. Michelle was proud that she still got that reaction from her husband after so many years together. Maybe he wasn't bored after all.

"Where do you want me?" she asked.

"Why don't you lie down in the middle of the bed?"

The duvet was folded down to the foot of the bed, and Clay had folded the sheets to the side. Michelle arranged herself in the middle of their queen-sized mattress and folded her hands over her stomach. She tingled with anticipation. Clay could be up to anything these days.

"Let's start with this," he said, holding up a black blindfold.

"Clay," she said, before stopping herself. The blindfold made her feel weird the first time they tried it, but she was trying to be open. She silenced her objection and nodded.

Michelle put on the blindfold on herself, after Clay caught her hair in the elastic band when he tried to do it. She was tempted to leave a peek at

the bottom, but she played along and tugged it into place until she saw nothing but darkness. She laid back down, feeling the empty space with her hands.

“Okay, don’t do anything too crazy now,” she said, giggling nervously.

“Guess I should tell the guys not to jump out of the closet, then.”

A shiver shot to her gut. “I don’t know. Does my hair still look good?” She instinctively smoothed her chestnut hair down over her shoulders. It was just long enough to reach her nipples.

“You’ve got the best hair I’ve ever seen, babe. I love that you still keep it long.”

Michelle smiled. “Then they can come out and look, but they have to keep their hands to themselves.” She stiffened, almost expecting something to happen. She took a deep breath, fighting off the paranoia. “Is it anyone I know?”

“Maybe I invited Wes back.”

“Haha. Very funny.” Michelle stuck out her tongue, but a tiny shiver went down her spine at the possibility the handsome photographer could be there watching her. He’d probably have his camera and be snapping photos of her in her lingerie. Thinking of Wes seeing her that way as a touch too exciting, but if she ever would allow herself to be shared, she could certainly do worse.

Her remark was followed by silence. The room was still, except for the soft background music and the hiss of the central air. Her skin pricked up, and her nipples stiffened in the cool air. Clay was making her wait, but for what? He could have been deciding what to do, but she had a feeling he had some kind of a plan. She strained for an audible clue—anything.

His fingertips barely brushed her arm, and Michelle jumped. Seconds passed, then a caress on her leg. Another pause, another touch—this time her shoulder. Clay kept teasing her, letting seconds pass, followed by a random caress. Her pulse raced as she anticipated the next touch, hoping it

would be somewhere naughtier. This was different than the way Clay used the blindfold the first time, and she liked this better. The teasing was like a game. Michelle felt like she was suspended in darkness and she could be touched anywhere, at any time—by anyone. She didn't know where that last thought came from, but from the different ways Clay touched her, on different body parts, it could have been several people sampling her body, testing her reactions. Maybe he did have men hidden in the closet and they were just very quiet. The possibility titillated and frightened her.

Fingers teased her nipple through the stretchy lace. Michelle gasped and arched off the bed. Clay took his hand away. She settled down, and he touched her other breast. Michelle pushed at him, and he pulled away again. Now her heart was pounding. She whimpered. Michelle was ready to pull the blindfold off. He was just being mean. She took a deep breath and stilled herself. Clay touched her again, teasing both nipples this time. Michelle whimpered again, but this time in contentment, and she kept still, letting Clay touch her as he chose.

“Having fun?” he asked, voice soft.

“It's frustrating...and exciting.”

“You don't like being passive.”

She slowly shook her head. “No,” she breathed.

“But what if you had no choice?”

“Are you going to tie me down now?”

“Would you let me?”

Clay continued teasing one puckered nipple, but his other hand dropped, and fingers brushed her bare thigh, just below the hem of her short babydoll. Michelle trembled.

“I don't know,” she gasped. Her answer would have been a firm no before, but he had her in a pliant frame of mind.

He took her arms and raised them over her head, pushing them down into the pillows. She wasn't fastened, but it felt like it. Michelle breathed

deep and tried to maintain control. Excitement made her vibrate like a struck piano string. Clay raised the babydoll to her waist and rolled her thong down her legs. She might as well have skipped it for how long it stayed on her body. His fingers played back up her legs, one hand touching her firmly, the other gently. The varying touches energized her. Michelle could remember feeling like this before.

Clay unfastened the babydoll at the neck and folded back the top, revealing her breasts. Michelle had the oddest sensation she was being exposed to an unknown audience, but knew it was crazy. *No one is here*, she assured herself. Then, *Wes is not here*. Clay was just creating a mood—perfectly so.

After a pause, Clay was touching her again. His hands sculpted her breasts, he pinched her nipples until she gave a little shriek, and his fingers danced all over the delicate flesh. Her nipples throbbed with pleasure, making her clit seem to throb along with it. Michelle's mouth hung open as she moaned. She was dying for Clay to touch her pussy. His fingers grazed her mound. Michelle cried out. The varied caresses really created the illusion that more than one person was touching her. She was so aroused.

Something touched her parted lips. Michelle's tongue peeked out by instinct. She was surprised to find the dildo pressed to her lips. She didn't think, she just opened her mouth, and Clay eased the thick head past her lips. She sucked like it was a cock. It felt so dirty to be sucking a toy like that, and it made her fires burn brighter. Clay's fingers dragged over her smooth mound, and Michelle moaned into the toy.

"Damn, you're soaked, babe," Clay marveled.

Michelle moaned into the toy.

"I don't think you've ever been so ready to fuck."

"Mmhm," she moaned into the toy. Clay took it from her mouth. Michelle gasped and moaned his name.

"Let's see how ready you are."

Michelle desperately wanted Clay to fuck her, but he pressed the dildo to her pussy. She nudged forward even though it wasn't what she really wanted. She needed something inside her. The thick, cock-shaped dildo slipped right inside her, spreading her pussy wide. The thing effortlessly speared inside her. Michelle didn't need the vibrator to prep her tonight. She was ready for the big toy. Michelle didn't think about any of that. She just started moving against the toy. Clay fed it inside her until the sculpted testicles at the base rested against her. Michelle worked her pussy onto it.

"Yeah, you're ready, aren't you?" Clay asked. He was breathless.

"Yes," she hissed, loving how the dildo filled her. It didn't seem too big at all.

"You like that big cock inside you, Michelle?"

"Yeah...mmm..."

"It doesn't even matter who's it is, you need it."

"Yes!" she moaned sharply. "Mmm..."

"You want it?"

"Yeah...don't tease me...give it to me..."

"Tell me, Michelle."

"Fuck me," she begged. The response was instinctive. "Fuck me."

Michelle didn't think but reacted. She realized what Clay was doing, but she didn't care. He'd played his game perfectly. In the darkness of the blindfold, Michelle's imagination ran wild. She did not think of a specific stranger—not at first—but she did think of a big stranger's cock inside her, pleasing her. The dildo was so different from her husband that she couldn't pretend it was him. It didn't upset her this time because the whole game was surreal—and it felt so damn good. And then, crazily, Wes popped into her head again. Michelle gasped when she imagined it was *him* inside her. It was easy to imagine the built photographer was as big and solid as the toy inside her. She thought of the many times he touched her that afternoon to pose her for the photographs. The rest of the family didn't seem to need

so much direction. Michelle didn't mind it one bit. She felt guilty immediately, but that didn't stop the low moan that escaped when the toy—when *Wes*—pushed deep inside her. *No*, she thought, almost gasping it aloud. It was one thing to think of a handsome stranger, but quite another to imagine someone specific. Why did he have to be so damned charming, handsome and flirty? She pushed thoughts of Wes from her mind.

“Who is it, babe? Who are you fucking?” Clay whispered, his voice thick with need.

“I don't...you...I...”

“Not me, Michelle. You know it's not me—not fucking you like that.”

“Clay...please...”

“It's okay, babe. You know I like it. You know it makes me hot to see you taking some big, hung lover.”

“Clay...I don't...”

“I should have brought someone in here. I know you'd do it.”

“Yes...yes...just do it...” Michelle groaned. He was driving her insane. She hated how his words tortured her, but it felt so good. The thick toy inside her combined with his outrageous fantasy created a heady brew she could not deny. Michelle was captivated by it.

“Maybe I should have invited Wes back. I saw how he looked at you. How you looked at him...”

“No...god no...Clay...I...”

“It's okay. It's hot, Michelle. It would be so hot if Wes was here fucking you right now.”

“God...Clay...mmm...”

Michelle burned with lust and shame. It was like Clay read her mind. She didn't look at Wes any kind of way, she was positive. It was all in Clay's head. This was his crazy fantasy, she insisted. But her body told a different story.

Clay slowly worked the dildo in and out of her. The slow fucking was torture, and it felt amazing. She had always loved a slow, satisfying screwing, but so few men knew how to do it well. Most men were in too much of a hurry to get off themselves. Even Clay didn't usually have the restraint with his own cock, but he was a master with the toy. It felt like he was turning her world inside out. Michelle's moans were from deep in her chest, from deep in her core.

"Damn, you're sexy, babe. I love watching you take that big cock. You're fucking amazing, Michelle," Clay moaned.

Michelle just ignored him. She focused on that cock inside her. Yes, in her pleasure, she thought of it as a cock. Clay increased the tempo, steadily fucking her, and a storm brewed inside her.

"You want it harder?"

"Yeah...fuck me..."

Clay plunged the dildo deep inside her. Michelle cried out. He slowly withdrew, then slammed home again. Michelle wailed. "*Beg him*," he ordered.

"Please fuck me," she begged. "Fuck me, dammit!" Michelle wouldn't do it. She would not name another man—would not name Wes. She would not go that far to play Clay's game.

Clay kept working the toy in her, and Michelle was barely aware of the bed shifting beside her. She didn't think about anything, except her impending orgasm. Clay turned her head, twisting her torso. Michelle tried to protest, but Clay shoved his cock into her mouth. She gagged in surprise, but he pushed it deeper. She experienced a moment of panic, but once she realized what was happening, instinct kicked in and she began sucking.

"That's it, babe, suck my dick. I need you so bad, but your pussy is taken. Give me that pretty mouth," he groaned.

It was hard to sort out what was happening. Michelle was not thinking clearly. And when she tried it was too difficult to focus. The dildo kept

plunging into her pussy, and now Clay's cock filled her mouth. She was being pinned by two cocks. It was a stunning turn. How did it happen?

Michelle immediately flashed back to that night in college. In the snap of a finger, she was a twenty-year old coed, on her back on that filthy couch in Rob's apartment. Her boyfriend, Rob was going down on her, and Perry, his roommate played with her tits. She was so lost in a swirl of conflicting emotions that night that she just let it happen. She knew she shouldn't be doing it, but it felt so good. Michelle came once, and Rob kept going down on her. He loved making her climax multiple times. Perry stopped teasing her tits and put his cock to her face. She stared up at him but didn't react. When her lips parted with a moan, Perry pushed it into her mouth. Michelle just started sucking. Rob moved from licking her pussy and started fucking her, and next thing she knew, Michelle had two cocks inside her. Even twenty odd years later, she felt like she lost her mind that night. She let Perry use her mouth while her boyfriend fucked her. She bounced between their cocks, and in the moment, she loved it. She eagerly sucked Perry. It seemed like the orgasms just kept rolling over her. Michelle felt utterly used. She only put an end to it when they changed places. Perry came the second he entered her and feeling that freaked her out. She pushed Rob away and locked herself in his room. Michelle couldn't believe what a whore she'd become, and she couldn't believe Rob just let it happen.

All of those old feelings bubbled up and warred inside her again. But Michelle wasn't a naïve coed anymore. She'd grown confident in her sexuality in the intervening years, and while she didn't know how to process what Clay was doing to her, she was able to enjoy it this time. She did not shove her husband away as she had eventually done to Rob. And just like on that night back in college, Michelle thrived on being used by two cocks. She climaxed—hard and fast—her shouts muffled by Clay's prick in her mouth. One orgasm rolled into another.

“Damn, babe...damn, babe...fuck that’s hot...” Clay groaned. “You love two cocks...you’re fucking incredible, babe...”

Clay came in her mouth and she choked, unprepared for it. He got overexcited when they played with the toys, but he never came that fast. He pulled out, shooting cum across her cheek, and Michelle spit out the thick mess. And she still came. She closed her thighs around the toy pinning it inside her, and she rolled away from Clay, shaking as her pussy gripped the dildo. She kept the toy in her until the orgasm began to subside, then pulled it out and tossed it across the bed.

They didn’t really talk about it afterward. Clay told her how amazing she was, and how she’d never been sexier. Michelle had never felt sluttier. Maybe because she was now someone’s wife and mother it felt so much more wrong to have those feelings and lose control like that. It seemed so much dirtier than it did back when she was a coed. And then there was the way her mind went to Wes when Clay had her imagining a fantasy lover. That was so very wrong.

Yes, she’d enjoyed it—she still felt the contentment of her orgasms the following morning—but that wasn’t the point. It was a dark, improper fantasy, wasn’t it? Michelle stifled all her questions afterward, smiled and cuddled against Clay, but her mind reeled. She was determined to play the good wife.

Sitting on the deck the next day, she still had all the same questions she’d had before, and she no longer believed that Clay was just trying to spice things up in bed. He was so eager when he used those toys. She could still hear the excitement in his voice when he whispered Wes’s name to her. It could be her own guilt over her mind going there on its own, but she didn’t think so. There was more to this, something her husband didn’t want to tell her. Michelle had to find out what it was.

SIX

MICHELLE STEWED over the change in her marital sex life. Days passed, and Clay texted and called at night, but she didn't mention her concerns when they spoke. He tried to initiate phone and text sex, but she put him off each time. She was not in the mood for that. Instead, she weighed all the reasons her husband could be acting so differently in the bedroom. She landed on an affair.

Clay having an affair didn't make sense on the surface. Until he went to camp, he didn't have a lot of unaccounted for time—unless he was sneaking off while she was coaching, but he usually had the kids then. Michelle could ask the kids if daddy ever went out and left them with someone else—they were close with their neighbors—but she didn't want to involve the kids. She went back through the last several months and tried to find times when Clay could have been with someone. There were hours here and there when he was supposed to be running errands, but he would have to have been quick to maintain an affair like that.

Her next step was to try and decide who Clay may be sleeping with. Michelle mentally checked off all of the teachers they worked with. She didn't think Clay would be attracted to any of the women their age. Maybe it was vain, but Michelle knew she was better looking than all of them, so it wouldn't make sense—not that affairs were always about looks. Michelle

considered the younger teachers, even Clay's student teacher from last fall. She was a pretty little blonde named Piper. Piper was full of enthusiasm and looked up to Clay. Michelle could see her husband *wanting* to sleep with the girl but didn't see Piper reciprocating the feeling. She didn't want to sell Clay short, but she just didn't think a pretty girl in her early twenties would jump for him. Was that mean? Michelle didn't want to think Clay was that weak anyway. The man she married would never do anything like that. Then again, Michelle started dating Clay when she was a brand new teacher, just out of college, and Clay was her staff mentor—him being a few years older and more experienced. It wasn't the same as the relationship a student teacher had with their faculty advisor, but it was close enough. Clay was much older now, though. It was ickier when he was in his late forties and the girl was in her twenties. Michelle and Clay were only a couple years apart when they met. It wasn't a fair comparison, she decided.

Michelle ran through the women they knew at church. Clay had a thing for Kristen Spencer, but then so did most of the men at church. Kristen was awesome, though, and Michelle couldn't see her sleeping with another woman's husband.

She didn't want to believe Clay was having an affair with anyone, but why else would he suddenly be so weird in the bedroom and not say why? She did keep flirting with the possibility that Clay was trying to come out of the closet—given the weird obsession with dicks in his fantasies—but she just couldn't go there. That man was not gay or bi. She'd never seen any other sign that he was into men. She even considered taking it all at face value. What if Clay really did want to see her sleep with another man? A quick internet search taught her this was a fetish called cuckold. As an English teacher, she mostly thought of the term in the Shakespearian context. Michelle understood the general meaning, of course, and even knew that people on the far Right had taken to using it as an insult against liberals. But these videos had nothing to do with politics. It only took a

quick search to learn that Cuckold was its own genre of porn, where husbands got off on their wives humiliating them with other men. She only got through a couple websites before she felt she needed a shower. Michelle examined that possibility from every angle and just couldn't understand it. Clay never showed any propensity to be humiliated in any way. It seemed as far-fetched to her as him being gay. She came back to Clay having an affair. The toys could have been something he did with his mistress. Maybe he wanted to see if Michelle would go for it. It creeped her out that Clay would try something with her he did with another woman. The very idea made her stomach churn and her brain burn with anger. She hoped it wasn't true. She didn't want any of it to be true. But pushing her to sleep with another man could be his way of assuaging his guilt or trap her into some strange kind of moral standoff.

Clay was unable to come home from camp for the first couple weekends because they were still setting things up for the incoming children and Michelle didn't see him again until it was time to drive Hayden and Jack to camp. She packed the kids into the minivan with three weeks of supplies and they took the two-hour drive into the mountains to Camp Lenepe.

The drop-off scene was hectic, and Michelle marshalled the kids through the crowds to the sign-up line, waited while they endured the lice-and-tick check, and then met their counselors. One of Jack's counselors, Shawn, was extremely friendly, and Michelle got the crazy impression that the boy was flirting with her. He had to be under twenty-five, which was truly a boy in Michelle's eyes. Boy or not, she still noticed he was tall, handsome, and well-built, with black hair tied back in a ponytail. But she didn't allow her mind to go there with someone his age.

"It's nice of your sister to drop you off," Shawn said, flashing the perfect white teeth of an expensive orthodontist job.

Jack just rolled his eyes and got to meeting his new campmates.

"Very funny," Michelle replied.

“You’re not?” Shawn seemed dumbstruck.

Michelle patted him on the shoulder. “That’s very sweet, but I’m not buying I look like I’m a teenager.”

“You could be in college. Jack could be an oops baby.” Shawn’s smile turned sly.

“I was there. He’s not an oops baby.”

“Oh well. You must get it all the time, though.”

“I’ll tell my husband you said so. He’ll be very happy you think I look so young.” Michelle flashed her ring but didn’t bother to tell the boy who her husband was.

Michelle left Jack with the counselors after fighting back tears, and shook her head as she walked away, but the counselor’s flirty attention put a spring in her step and a smile on her lips, pushing away her separation anxiety. Hayden was already with his friends, so she set off to find her husband. Clay was in the administration building, directing the chaos with a clipboard in hand. Watching him among the kids and parents, Michelle didn’t think he looked like the sort of man who fantasized about his wife screwing other men—or the type to have an affair. He just looked like the same old Clay—the man she fell in love with, and the father of her children. Clay spotted her and broke away from the group. He led her to a side office and closed the door. It was a small space with a bookshelf and an ancient metal desk.

“I can steal away for a few minutes,” he said. Clay stepped back and looked her over. “Wow, you’re a sight for sore eyes.”

Michelle smiled. Despite her questions about the state of their marriage, she had put some effort into her appearance. She hadn’t seen her husband in weeks. Her chestnut hair fell down her back, and she wore a loose green swing dress—with little white and pink flowers—from Old Navy. It fell just above the knee, showing off her long, tanned legs. She thought it was flirty and fun.

“Oh, this old thing? I just threw it on.”

Clay grabbed her by the waist and kissed her. Michelle instinctively responded, melting against him. It felt so good to be in his arms, and her concerns evaporated with the kiss. His hands drifted to her ass and pulled at the back of her dress.

“Hey, what are you doing?” she asked, keeping her lips to his. She pushed his hands down.

“I *really* missed you. I don’t think you appreciate how much I missed you.”

Clay pulled at her dress again and Michelle laughed while swatting at his hands playfully.

“Maybe you should think twice about taking a job that takes you away from me all summer.”

“Or you could start coming up here.” Clay turned them and backed her up against the small, battered desk. The kissing heated up again, keeping them from speaking. Michelle’s hands smoothed over his shaved head. Clay kissed along her jawline, moving to her neck. “There are lots of places to sneak off to here. I know the counselors do it all the time.”

“We’re not a couple of sexed up teenagers,” she reminded him.

“It could be fun to pretend we are for a couple hours.”

“And if we get caught? Mmm...” Michelle sighed when Clay nibbled on that special spot behind her ear. If she didn’t push him away soon, she wouldn’t be able to.

“We wouldn’t. No one goes looking at night. I don’t catch the kids. I just know what they’re up to. Some things don’t change with time.”

“You could show me all your old spots. Mmm, babe, you need to stop.”

Michelle pushed lightly against his chest, and Clay stepped back, but only a couple inches. He looked desperate to rip her dress off, and she’d be lying if she claimed she wasn’t feeling it too, but there were dozens of people milling around right outside that door. It was a crazy risk. She

grabbed him through his cargo shorts and felt he was fully hard. Michelle massaged him.

“I thought you wanted me to stop,” he moaned.

“Maybe I just like torturing you. You’re not the only one who can tease in this marriage.” He throbbed as she grasped him through his khaki shorts. “You’re just as bad as your counselors.”

Clay’s hands rested on her legs, and he slid them upward, pushing her light dress higher on her thighs. “What do you mean by that?”

“Your counselors are clearly oversexed. One of Jack’s was flirting with me when I dropped him off.”

Clay perked up. She felt his cock surge through his shorts, and he gripped her thighs tighter. “Really?”

“Yeah, he gave me the old *you must be his older sister* routine.” Michelle laughed.

“What did you do?” Clay asked. *Was that excitement in his voice?*

Michelle narrowed her eyes as she looked at him. It could have been her paranoia kicking back in, but he certainly looked excited. “What do you think I did? I gave him my number and told him to text me.” She let it hang there for a moment, filling the tiny room, trying to read his reaction. Clay’s eyes were wide and eager, but that could just be because she was grabbing him. Michelle didn’t know what to think. “I put him off, what do you think I did? He’s a goddam kid, Clay.”

Clay forced a chortle. “Yeah, of course. Yeah, that’s crazy.”

“You think I should have dragged him behind the boathouse? Shouldn’t you be jealous or something?”

His answer was a kiss—a ravenous kiss. His tongue flicked into her mouth, and it was so sudden, so passionate, that it took her breath away. Michelle moaned as she kissed him back, his hands moved right up and gripped her hips. Clay boosted her onto the edge of the desk and pressed in again. Her arms went around him, and he grinded his package against her.

Michelle didn't feel much from it, but the motion was sexual, and it filled her with forbidden thoughts. Her pussy tingled with unmet need. It had been a long couple weeks without him, and touching herself wasn't cutting it. Michelle even deployed the massaging shower head the way Clay used it on her, but none of that satiated her hunger to have a man inside her. That pressing need swept her questions away. Michelle hooked her heels behind his legs. Only when Clay reached for the waistband of her panties did Michelle come to her senses. She had to use force to push him away this time.

"Clay, stop. I mean it. I'm not fucking you on this desk." The words came out in a breathless rush. Just because she wasn't going to do it, that didn't mean she didn't *want* to do it.

"Fuck, I need you, 'Chelle."

"You're going to have to take care of yourself until you come home to see me," she said. Michelle was not going to admit she was just as horny as he was.

"That's weeks away..." he whined.

"It's a good thing you have porn on your iPad then, and plenty of lotion."

"You're a teasing bitch," he said, smiling.

"One of us has to be rational. Now let me down."

Michelle gave him a peck on the lips and hopped off the desk. She knew her cheeks were probably flushed, and she fanned her face. The little office was suddenly sweltering. She pulled her dress back into place.

"Someone's probably looking for me anyway," he grudgingly admitted.

"Probably. Don't worry, we'll pick this up later," she promised.

"There's always Facetime."

"Facetime sex? Hmm? We'll see."

They left the office, and Michelle couldn't help feeling like anyone looking at them could tell they'd been fooling around. They were both

adults—and married—so she didn't know why it bothered her. If they were going to be judged, she thought, maybe they should have just gone ahead and done it. The aching down below told her she should have done it. Michelle thought they just might need to try Facetime sex later. Clay tried to get her to do it last year during camp, after failing to get her to sext and send dirty pictures, but she balked.

The pictures were not going to happen. She was too afraid of those falling into the wrong hands. Even Facetime sex just felt strange to her. If she was going to touch herself, she'd rather do it without any distractions, but maybe she would do it for Clay. His crazy new libido hadn't faded since he went to camp, that was for sure. Michelle fought back her fears of his infidelity, but that became much harder on her way back to the minivan.

Counselors still gathered their groups of kids on the big lawn outside the administration building and Michelle wound between the groups like she was navigating a minefield—until she stopped dead in her tracks upon spying a familiar blonde with a group of twelve-year-olds. Michelle stopped and stared, sure she had to be mistaken. She flipped up her sunglasses and squinted, moving closer. *It can't be*, she thought. Michelle was so fixated on the blonde that she tripped over a sleeping bag. Stumbling forward, she caught herself with hands before she went to the ground fully, but skinned her knees. Michelle was incredibly flexible.

“Hey, are you okay, ma'am?” Michelle knew that voice and she cringed.

“Yeah, I'm good. I need to pay attention to where I'm going. How are you, Piper?” Michelle hopped to her feet like nothing happened.

“Great! Oh, hey, it's you Mrs. Winthrop. Are you dropping off the boys? Clay said you'd be bringing them up.”

“He did? He didn't mention you were working up here this summer. What a small world!”

Michelle forced a tight smile. Camp Lenape was hours from the city. It would be an *amazing* coincidence if the busty blonde ended up there on her own. The young teacher was looking particularly busty in the tight baby blue camp t-shirt that stretched over her boobs. Michelle wasn't generally the type of woman who judged other women's choices, but the size-too-small t-shirt and shorts Piper wore hardly seemed appropriate to wear around a bunch of hormonal boys.

Staring down at Piper—the girl was a full head shorter—Michelle couldn't help but think the girl was everything she was not: blonde, short, busty, and—of course—*young*. She could hardly blame Clay for wanting to screw the girl. And looking at the girl in front of her, Michelle was *sure* Clay wanted to screw Piper.

"Clay helped me get the job up here. I didn't know what I was doing for the summer, and I needed some extra cash, and he said the camp is always looking for help."

"I didn't know you two were still in touch."

"You know, online, email. Clay's been such a great mentor."

"He's a giver, all right."

"Clay really is sweet. You're so lucky," Piper said brightly, missing Michelle's snark. The girl was practically bouncing up and down as she talked about Clay.

"Tell him I said hi when you see him later. I'd better get moving. It's a long drive home."

"Sure thing, Mrs. Winthrop."

"Oh please, do call me Michelle."

"Awesome... Michelle."

Michelle gritted her teeth as she walked back to the minivan. She didn't realize her fists were clenched until the nails digging into her palms became painful. After slamming the door closed behind her, she sat in the hot minivan taking deep breaths and pushing away dark thoughts.

Piper is at camp? Why wouldn't Clay mention that? Michelle could only think of one reason. Did Clay try to screw her in his office because he was so horny, or because he felt guilty? She darkly thought, *I wonder how Piper feels about Clay's little bedroom games?* The blonde seemed too bubbly and innocent for talk of threesomes and sex toys, but weren't younger girls much more sexually open these days? If Clay was sleeping with Piper, Michelle would almost rather her husband was gay or bi. That would take competing off the table. Michelle didn't see how she could compete with a younger girl like Piper.

Michelle started the Honda and cranked the radio, trying not to spew gravel as she drove away angry and confused.

SEVEN

THE QUIET WAS REPRESSIVE. Michelle sat in the family room with a glass of wine, flicking through social media on her phone. A stand lamp in the corner provided limited light, keeping the room dim. The sun was setting outside the windows. It didn't provide the distraction she'd hoped it would, and now left alone in the dark house, all the questions about her marriage swarmed.

Michelle tried to wrap her head around the idea that Clay was having an affair with Piper. They just didn't seem like a match. She thought her husband was attractive for his age, but would a pretty young woman like Piper be interested in a guy in his late forties? Piper could have a daddy thing. A lot of young women did. And she could see why Clay would be tempted by the busty blonde, but would he really cross that line and sleep with one of his mentees, even after the fact? Michelle wanted to believe she knew her husband better than that, but how well do you really know anyone—even after fifteen years of marriage? Something had to explain Clay's bizarre behavior. An affair was the only logical explanation to her. The other possibilities were too fantastical.

It only took a couple minutes to find Piper's Facebook profile. It didn't look like the girl was very active on there, but that wasn't surprising. Younger people had mostly abandoned that social media platform to their

parents. It made her feel old, something she did not need at the moment. Michelle searched Piper's friends and Clay wasn't there. She turned to Instagram next. As she expected, Piper posted a lot on there. Piper looked to be quite the party girl, at least that was the impression she put out there. She always seemed to be out with her friends, and they always seemed to be at some bar or club. Michelle learned Piper went to Florida for spring break. There were dozens of selfies—many of them in bikinis or other skimpy outfits. Michelle had to concede the girl had a great body. Piper's navel was pierced, and she had lines of script tattooed on her ribcage. Michelle didn't mind tattoos, but she'd always thought having a saying tattooed on your body was silly. She could remember the words that were important to her. Piper wore a lot of crop tops and tiny skirts. Clay must have loved that. Michelle noticed a lack of visible tan lines on the girl, but that wasn't the only thing missing. There was no evidence of a boyfriend either.

Michelle went to the list of Piper's followers. The girl had a couple hundred, and Clay was in there. Michelle didn't even know he was on Instagram, but his username was obvious. It was the same as his email. When she tried to click on his profile, it was private and locked. She stared at her phone, fuming. Clicking through Piper's bikini photos, Michelle found that Clay had liked every one of them. He commented on a photo of Piper in a little black dress, marveling at Piper's tanned legs. Her boobs were popping out of the dress and Michelle was surprised Clay even noticed she had legs. Michelle found it creepy even if her husband wasn't sleeping with the girl. Piper was just so *young*. She didn't know whether to laugh, scream or cry.

Clay's laptop was on his desk in their home office, and she fetched it. He only took his iPad to camp, after experience had taught him that he didn't need his laptop and it was just another thing to lug around. Virtually anything he could do on the laptop he could do with the tablet—especially since he'd bought the keyboard for the iPad. Michelle silently thanked her

anal husband for leaving the laptop plugged in and charged. She stopped in the kitchen to top off her wine and returned to the family room, snuggling into the corner of their large sectional couch. Michelle booted his computer.

The couple knew each other's passwords, so there was no barrier to logging into the laptop. Michelle stared at the screen and wondered where to begin. She went to Clay's email and was surprised to find that he'd changed his password. Fair or not, she took that as a sign he was cheating. Why did he change his email password after all these years, unless he had something to hide? Michelle turned to his iMessenger account next. Miraculously, that was wide open, but then Clay could be careless. The app popped up on the screen and there was Piper glaring at her from the contacts list.

Michelle paused. Did she really want to go through with this? She felt guilty snooping on Clay—even if he was cheating. Her suspicions didn't make snooping right. If she thought her husband was cheating, she should ask him, but Michelle was afraid of that conversation. If she was right, then what? And if she were wrong, it could cause a huge rift in her marriage. She put her moral qualms aside and opened the iMessenger chat.

The last exchange of messages occurred days earlier. Michelle didn't know whether to be relieved by that. Piper sent Clay a message telling him how excited she was to get to the camp and thanked him again for getting her the job. Clay replied with a smiley face. Piper replied that she was all kitted out and sent a picture. She was in the camp t-shirt, but it was tied off at the bottom, stretching it even tighter over her big boobs and exposing her tanned, taut stomach. Piper wore it with a tiny pair of running shorts. It was a version of the outfit that would never fly at camp, but Clay approved. He replied with an emoji of his eyes popping out of his head. Michelle was annoyed by Clay's use of emojis. What did he think he was, a teenage girl?

The last message was from Piper. The girl said, *See ya soon!* The message was punctuated with a kissing emoji.

Michelle fumed. Her hopes that she was wrong about Clay sank lower with each passing second. There was no reason Piper should be sending a middle-aged married man selfies. No *good* reason, anyway.

Scrolling back through the chats, Michelle found most of them were flirty, but benign. No plans to meet. No sexting. But the flirting was certainly inappropriate, in her mind. Piper liked to send Clay photos while she was out and about with her friends, or when she was getting ready to go out. She sent Clay a selfie of herself in a black tube top and a short skirt, asking if it was appropriate to go out in. Piper's nipples stared at the camera. Clay's cheeky response was, *Not if I was your father.* Piper's reply: *I'm glad you're not!* Michelle cringed and drained her wine.

Another photo was from Piper's spring break trip and it was taken in a hotel room. Piper was wearing a denim overall dress, very short, with nothing under it. The dress was meant to be worn with a top underneath and Piper's boobs spilled from the sides. If she turned just a little bit, she would have shown everything. Disgust for the girl churned in Michelle's gut. Who did Piper think she was, sending such pictures to a married man? Clay didn't discourage her. His response was another eye-popping emoji followed by, *Think you forgot something.*

Piper followed with another photo showing she wore a lacy black bra under the overall dress. One side of the overall was unfastened, letting it hang down to show off her bra-covered tits. She asked, *Better?* Clay replied, *Better for me!*

Michelle snapped the laptop closed. She hadn't found a smoking gun, but she'd seen enough. She couldn't take anymore. If Clay were there, she would have been throwing things at him, and she had a great arm. He wouldn't have stood a chance. She stared up at the ceiling fighting back tears. Michelle had no idea what to do next. She never thought she would

be in this position. The sobs came, her body shook. Her scream echoed through the empty house.

“No!” Michelle shouted. *I am not going to play the victim!*

The laptop was laid aside and she returned to the kitchen. She didn’t bother refilling her glass but drank directly from the wine bottle. Michelle drank until her head was spinning. Her anger glowed like a hot poker. She wasn’t thinking clearly as she ran up the steps to their bedroom, stumbling as she went. Her lingerie drawer was flung open, and Michelle threw skimpy, lacy things aside as she looked for the perfect thing. It made her realize that she didn’t really have a lot of truly slinky, slutty lingerie anymore. She wore a lot of soft, lacy bralettes these days, many of them more cute than sexy. When did she let that happen? Did Clay think the lacy things were sexy or boring? Was that why Clay was accepting pictures from Piper?

Michelle tossed her clothes on the bed and dressed in a tiny bra and panty set—green satin with black lace trim. The panties were a T-back, showing off her tight little ass. She posed in the mirror, her inebriated brain making the inevitable comparisons to Piper. Michelle smugly decided her tummy was flatter than Piper’s. Her body was leaner than the girl’s in general. She was tight everywhere. Thinking of Piper’s curves, she wondered if she was *too* lean. Her tall, athletic body wasn’t va-voom like the blonde’s. Michelle’s hips were narrow, and her boobs were small.

She touched her breasts. When she was younger, Michelle had been self-conscious of her little boobs. It seemed like she barely had enough to fill the smallest bra. She was excited when they finally blossomed into small B-cups, and she’d never been above augmenting them with a padded bra to fill out a sweater. They swelled with pregnancy, and afterward settled to a perky pair she thought suited her body. She didn’t need huge tits to feel sexy now that she was more mature. Clay called them his handfuls, which always made her laugh. The upside of little tits was that she could skip a bra

when she chose to, and wear those lacy, comfortable bralettes without underwires. As she got older, she grew to appreciate the trade-off.

Over the years, she'd joked with Clay about getting implants, maybe go up to a large C-cup. He practically dared her to do it, knowing she never would. He insisted he loved her breasts, that they were perfect for her body and that they defied gravity and age. But what if Clay was lying all this time? He seemed to like what Piper had. Michelle felt insecure about her boobs for the first time in years.

It took some digging through her closet, but Michelle found her old overalls. It wasn't a cute little dress like Piper wore—Michelle had no idea overalls were even back in style—but baggy faded denim overalls she wore back in her twenties. She wasn't worried about fitting into the overalls. If anything, they were baggier on her now than they were back then. She was proud of that. One side was left unfastened, and Michelle strategically folded it back to reveal her bra. Her tits weren't spilling out like Piper's, but the effect was still there. Michelle snapped some pictures with her phone, careful to keep her face out of the shots. She didn't trust Clay anymore. Only her long, chestnut hair hanging over one shoulder provided a clue to her identity. When she had a photo she was happy with, she sent it to her husband.

Clay didn't respond for close to twenty minutes. Michelle wondered if he was too busy with Piper to look at her picture. His reply was underwhelming.

[Clay] *lucky no one was looking over my shoulder when I opened that!*

She had no idea how to take that. Clay had been begging her for pictures and sexting forever and that was his response? He didn't seem like the man who couldn't keep his hands off her that morning.

[Michelle] *sorry guess I shouldn't have sent it*

[Clay] *didn't say that. you're hot babe*

[Michelle] *think I forgot something? Like a shirt?*

[Clay] *perfect just the way it is*

[Michelle] *Should I go out like this? Wore it all the time back in the day*

[Clay] *you'll certainly get attention.*

[Michelle] *my dad never wanted me getting that kind of attention*

[Clay] *good thing I'm not your dad*

Michelle fumed at his response. That seemed to be his favorite line. She pushed on.

[Michelle] *you're not worried about the kind of attention I might get?*

[Clay] *I trust you*

Michelle was exaggerating. She never wore the overalls out without a tank top under them. She unfastened the other side and let the bib drop over her waist, cocking her hip to keep the baggy overalls from dropping off her completely. She sent another photo to Clay.

[Clay] *now that might not be appropriate*

[Michelle] *but it'll get me the kind of attention you want*

[Clay] ?

The overalls dropped off her body completely when she moved, but they'd served their purpose. If Clay caught the connection to Piper, he was playing innocent. There was one more piece to her trap. She took what Clay called his bag of tricks from the top of the closet and found his favorite toy. She sent him a photo of the big, black dildo. He replied with that eye-popping emoji he was so fond of.

[Michelle] *are you alone? Facetime me*

[Clay] *give me 10 minutes*

Michelle took that time to arrange herself on the bed and wonder if Clay was cancelling late night plans for Piper to sneak out of her cabin and meet him. Or maybe she was already there, and he had to get rid of her. She shuddered with disgust thinking Clay might have shown Piper her pictures, some shared joke between the adulterous couple. That was paranoid, she

realized. The Facetime call came through and Michelle took a deep breath, steeling herself for what came next.

“Hey sexy,” Clay said, putting on a bedroom voice.

“Sorry if I bothered you.” She plastered on a smile and got the hostility out of her voice.

“You kidding? I haven’t stopped thinking about you since this morning. Sorry if I got out of hand. You’re not still mad?”

“I wasn’t expecting you to chase me around your office like a randy boss, but I guess your heart was in the right place. Or some other part of your anatomy, anyway.”

“You just have that effect on me.”

Not just me, she thought. Clay couldn’t very well chase Piper around the camp like that, but Michelle was fair game.

“You look hot, babe. Does this mean you’ve reconsidered the whole online thing?”

Michelle forced a smile. “I told you I’m trying to keep an open mind. What do you want me to do?”

Clay looked eager on the screen. Mostly, she saw his face, but the wall of his cabin was visible behind him. As the director, he didn’t have to share space like the other staff, and he didn’t seem worried about being interrupted. But then, he wasn’t worried about it in his office either, with hundreds of people milling around outside. Clay was being reckless, and it had to be connected to everything else. Michelle hated to think he was willing to blow everything up over some sort of midlife crisis. Something was going on with him, and it scared her.

“Take off your bra, babe. Show me your tits.”

“You want me to put on a show?” Michelle cooed, easing a strap off her shoulder. Clay nodded on screen. He looked like he was ready to explode already. “Are you touching yourself?”

“Yeah, babe. This is fucking hot.”

If she weren't so angry and drunk, she would have felt silly. This just wasn't her. She didn't know what to do or say. Michelle thought about Clay's crazy new fantasies. "I bet you wish someone else was here with me, don't you? I bet you wish you weren't the only one watching."

"Babe..." Clay breathed.

Michelle, the MILFy girls' team coach took a strap from her shoulder and peeled her bra down, stopping just short of her nipples. They were thick and dark with excitement and she didn't understand why. She wasn't doing this to turn herself on, but her body had its own ideas. She shifted on the bed and felt that familiar surge between her thighs. Michelle forced it from her mind.

"Tell me, Clay..."

"Yeah, babe?"

"Do you still think my tits are perfect, or do you like Piper's better?"

Clay's face went blank. She thought the colored drained from it, but it was difficult to tell with the lighting and the poor resolution. His lips moved, but he didn't say anything. Michelle stared at him, stony-faced. She wasn't giving anything away.

"What?" he finally replied.

"You didn't hear me? I know mine are much smaller, so whose tits do you like better, mine or Piper's?"

"Uh...babe...what...what are you talking about?"

"I know about Piper. I know what's going on."

"What's going on? What are you talking about, Michelle?"

"I know you've got her up there."

"Yeah, I got her a job. I was just trying to help. So what?"

"You give her a lot of help, don't you?"

"I don't know what you think is going on, but you're mistaken."

"She likes your help with her outfits, doesn't she? Do you help her take them off, too?"

“Michelle, listen, you’ve got the wrong idea. We’re just friends. I was her mentor when she started at our school...”

“I know, that just makes it worse. It’s disgusting.”

“Nothing is going on, Michelle!”

Michelle gritted her teeth. “Don’t raise your voice at me.”

“Then don’t make crazy accusations.”

“Why didn’t you say she was up there this summer? Why did you hide it?”

“I’m not hiding anything. I just didn’t think of it. It’s not a big deal to me.”

“Fucking a girl half your age isn’t a big deal? Good to know.”

“I am not fucking Piper! Jesus, Michelle! You are losing your mind.”

“Fuck you, Clay. I’m not crazy. You’re the one acting crazy. You’re the one with the crazy fantasies and sex toys...”

“That’s not fair. You like that stuff as much as...”

“Stop saying that! Just because I get off on it doesn’t mean I would have brought it up, or I want it!”

“Don’t be so fucking uptight, Michelle.”

“I should be looser? Like Piper?”

“Nothing is going on with Piper.”

Michelle wanted to throw her phone, but she wasn’t done with him. Instead, she gripped it so tightly she was surprised she didn’t crush it.

“I saw the chats, Clay.”

“What?”

“Your laptop is here. I went and looked at your iMessenger. You really should be more careful.”

“You went snooping on my laptop? What the fuck, Michelle?”

“*You’re* mad at *me*? Are you kidding me? I’m not the one getting dirty pictures from some kid.”

“She’s not a kid.”

Michelle laughed bitterly. “That’s what you’re hanging your hat on?”

“No, I mean, that’s not what I meant. We chat, I guess it gets a little flirty sometimes, but it doesn’t mean anything. That’s just how things are these days. You know how the kids at school are.”

“I don’t have any of them sending me sexy pictures. Do you? Piper’s not the only one?”

“Just stop it, Michelle. Nothing is going on with Piper—or anyone else. This is all in your head.”

“I know what I saw!”

“I can’t believe you spied on me.”

“I had to. You’re acting crazy. I had to find out what’s going on somehow.”

“Michelle...it’s not what you think...”

“Then what is it?”

Clay didn’t answer. She could only surmise he didn’t answer because it was exactly what she thought. Clay was having an affair with a girl half their age and he brought the girl to camp so he could spend the summer with her.

“What is it, Clay? I can’t think of anything else. Tell me what this is all about if it’s not that. Do you want to give me a hall pass because you’ve already taken one?”

“Michelle, no.”

“Do you want me to fuck another man to assuage your own guilt?”

“I told you, it’s not like that. You’ve got it all wrong.” Clay sounded defeated.

“If you’re not screwing Piper, if there’s something else going on, tell me, Clay.”

Her husband just stared at her through the screen. Michelle was equally speechless. She wanted to believe his denials. He seemed sincere, but he’d been messing with Piper for months and never let on. Clay was a much

better liar than she'd thought. If he wasn't going to give her an alternative, she had to believe what the evidence told her. Her anger blazed hotter with every second she waited for an answer. If she weren't careful, the conflagration would consume her.

"If you want me to believe you're not screwing that little blonde you need to open up to me, Clay."

"I have, Michelle. I told you, I'm not fucking Piper."

"And you've only been doing that stuff in the bedroom because you thought we needed to spice things up? You thought I needed you to blindfold me and fuck me with a toy? I needed to fantasize about other men?"

"It's...Michelle...come on..."

"I guess we're in an open marriage now. You're screwing around, so I guess I can too. Maybe you'll finally get your wish and I'll fuck someone else," she spat.

"Michelle..."

"Maybe I'll get you some pictures or something, if you're lucky."

Michelle closed the Facetime and finally threw her phone anyway. The tears came, and she let them. But then she realized her bra was still half-off and she felt ridiculous and laughed through the tears.

EIGHT

MICHELLE'S new solitude was both a blessing and a curse. She finally had the time to do the things she enjoyed and clear her head. She couldn't remember the last time she'd taken out her paints, but now she took them to the backyard every morning at sunrise and began work on a watercolor of the giant white oak that canopied most of the yard. Michelle had long been torn about removing the tree, wishing they had more sunlight in the backyard, but she really did love the way the sun filtered through it. Later in the morning, after a run, she took her yoga mat into the sunnier front yard and went through a half hour of poses while the sun warmed her skin.

Unfortunately, the day had twenty-four hours to fill and that left plenty of time for Michelle to dwell on the state of her marriage. Clay tried to contact her several times after their angry Facetime session, but she had no desire to speak with him. Unless he was willing to come clean, he had nothing to say she was interested in hearing, and the messages he left just contained more denials and lame excuses. Nothing Clay had to say convinced her she was wrong about Piper.

Michelle should have been catching up with her friends, but each night Michelle stayed in with a bottle of wine her only companion and obsessively studied Piper's Instagram, looking for more clues. Piper did not post much to Instagram from camp, but that only fed Michelle's obsession.

The scorned wife decided the girl was too busy sneaking off to fuck her husband to bother with social media.

Michelle was relieved when her continuing education class started and gave some structure to her days. There was only so much binge watching and cleaning she could do to fill her time. The house had never been so immaculate. She'd hated her required continuing ed classes in the past—they often felt like a waste of time—but this time she practically raced to the local community college for the first one. Michelle was thrilled she hadn't chosen the online option.

The campus was surprisingly busy for a summer evening. Michelle expected it to be deserted, with only few adults milling around trying to improve their careers or earn new certifications, but found many younger students still taking evening classes as well. She had never been so happy to be out among people and took time to wander around campus before going into her class. The county had put a lot of money into the campus in the last several years—when the school had entered into an association with a local university—and it showed.

The new quad was gorgeous. Michelle could see herself arriving early for class and sitting in the grass to study while other students passed by. Being on campus reminded her of her own college days and how carefree she felt back then. *You don't appreciate the kind of freedom you have when you're young*, she reflected. *It's only when life takes all that from you that you understand what you had*. Her college days were some of the happiest of her life. Michelle could live some of that again with Clay and the kids gone for most of the summer. Perhaps she should take advantage of her newfound freedom while it lasted. She needed the distraction. Her marital troubles were never far from her thoughts, like an oppressive cloud that followed her everywhere.

Michelle found a comfy spot in the quad under a tree and settled in with a coffee. She slipped off her sandals and the lush grass tickled her toes. She

watched the students passing by, paying special attention to the male ones. She tried to put herself in Clay's position and understand the temptation. Some of the younger guys were rather handsome and fit—she'd even go as far as sexy. If one of them approached her, if she found him interesting enough, could she sleep with a kid in his twenties? She watched several young men who were tempting. If she was their age, she'd be all over them. But they just looked so *damned young*. She just didn't think she could do it, even if they outright propositioned her. She thought of that cute camp counselor. No real temptation there. Even with her big boobs, how did Clay look at Piper and he see anything other than a kid?

Her phone chirped, pulling Michelle away from unpleasant thoughts. It was an email from Wes. She'd forgotten all about the handsome photographer. He lingered in her thoughts for a few days after the portraits—and after Clay's bizarre sex games—but then everything else went down and she'd forgotten all about him. She opened the email, and it was a bit of a letdown. Wes could be a real temptation, she realized. He was certainly younger, but not a kid. The email was all business. *What were you expecting?* she thought. Wes was probably the type of guy who always flirted. It was probably like breathing for him. The email was about their family portraits. Wes wanted to set up an appointment to go over proofs. Michelle thought that sort of thing was done online these days, but maybe Wes was old school. Millennials were always striving for a more authentic experience. He'd included his cell number as the best way to get in touch with him. Michelle had some time before class and shot him a text.

[Michelle] *this is Michelle Winthrop. You wanted to make an appointment?*

[Wes] *sorry for the delay. It's wedding season u know. Hope u don't think I forgot about u*

Michelle chuckled, thinking, *He really can't help himself. Two can play this game.* Clay deserved it.

[Michelle] *I'd be crushed if you forgot our magical afternoon!*

[Wes] *hey we had a vibe going before everyone else showed up 😊*

[Michelle] *everyone else being my husband and children*

[Wes] *yes them. more fun when I had u all to myself*

[Michelle] *you're terrible. Still not convinced you don't do this with everyone*

[Wes] *I told u. only the hot ones. U had a good time too*

[Michelle] *how can you be so sure?*

[Wes] *I have photographic evidence. U were luminous that day*

[Michelle] *big word!*

[Wes] *it fits. See...*

An image came through on her phone, followed by two more. They were photos of Michelle from when they were goofing around before Clay returned with the boys. At least, she considered it goofing around. But the photos were good. *Really good.* Wes was legit. Michelle tried to keep it humble, but she had to admit she looked great in the photos. The first was a close-up of Michelle with a shy smile, brushing hair from her face. The second caught her in mid-air hopping in the backyard. And the third was of her swinging in the hammock, flashing a dangerous amount of leg. Wes caught the light perfectly and seemed to instinctively know her best angles. Michelle could be overly critical of pictures of herself, but she swore Wes made her look ten years younger. It felt good with all the things going on in her marriage. She kept flipping between the photos, marveling at them.

[Michelle] *you're good*

[Wes] *helps to have such a perfect subject*

[Michelle] *you should be doing serious work, not kid's portraits*

[Wes] *this is my serious work.*

[Michelle] *you're seriously good*

[Wes] *u made my work better. U should let me shoot u again sometime*

[Michelle] *now you're laying it on thick*

[Wes] *I'm serious. Think about it. u said u used to model*

[Michelle] *I'll think about it*

Michelle had no actual intention of thinking about it, but Wes's attention was flattering, and she was happy to play along. She needed it right now. Even through the remove of text messaging, it was easy to fall for his charm. She smiled at her phone, picturing Wes in her backyard in his tight t-shirt and jeans. It was the first time she'd smiled like in weeks. Flirting with Wes was just what she needed. Maybe she shouldn't be so quick to dismiss him. She checked the time. Class loomed, and she was disappointed she had to wrap up her exchange with Wes.

[Michelle] *about the proofs...*

[Wes] *yes. We need to get together*

[Michelle] *to go over the proofs*

[Wes] *that too*

[Michelle] *don't you do this online?*

[Wes] *I find it better to go over the photographs in person. U and ur husband can tell me what u like, what u don't. I can tweak things for u*

[Michelle] *Clay is away working. I thought I mentioned that when I made the appointment. That's why we needed to rush*

[Wes] *we can wait until he comes back if you'd like, but I'd like to take care of this sooner. I'm sure he trusts ur judgment*

The mention of Clay reminded her that he could be in his cabin getting a blowjob from Piper at that very moment. Her tummy did a little flip and she groaned. It was funny that Wes mentioned trust and judgment. Neither of those were things she currently associated with Clay, but of course Clay could trust her judgment. Michelle always did the right thing. Clay could trust her alone with the handsome photographer. Maybe he shouldn't, she thought with a devilish smile.

[Michelle] *no we don't need to wait for him. I'd be happy to see you*

[Wes] *my place or urs?*

The rebellious part of her that wanted to act out backed down when she thought about being in her house alone with Wes. It would be wrong to invite him into her family's home. Michelle wanted to be bad—to a point. Or more accurately, she liked *the idea* of being bad and getting back at Clay, even if she knew she would ultimately behave herself. While she weighed all that, her phone chirped.

[Wes] ?

[Michelle] *yours. Let's keep this professional*

[Wes] *I'm always a professional!*

[Michelle] *I bet you are*

[Wes] *how is Tuesday @ 7*

[Michelle] *perfect*

Any time was perfect. Michelle had nothing but time for the summer.

[Wes] *see u then*

Wes ended the conversation by sending through one more picture. Her skin glowed in the late morning light, but the dusting of freckles across her cheeks and little button nose were still visible. There was fire in her cat-slanted, jade eyes, even as they were shaded by stray locks falling over her forehead. The picture left Michelle breathless. Those were *fuck me* eyes. She had no idea she gave Wes that look when he was snapping the pictures. What did he think of the picture? It was the best photograph anyone had ever taken of her. Perhaps she should pose for Wes again. Michelle tucked her phone away and hurried to class, her head smarming with thoughts of the sexy younger photographer.



“I am so jealous,” Eva announced, sipping her wine and reaching for another nacho.

“Me, too. I don’t care what you say, ‘Chelle,” Sarah echoed.

“I’m telling you guys, endless free time alone is not all it’s cracked up to be. If I wanted to spend all this time by myself, what was the point of having a family?” Michelle questioned.

“I ask myself that every day. *Especially* when they won’t give me two minutes to myself.” Violet punctuated her statement by pouring more wine into her glass.

“Stop it. You know what I mean,” Michelle said.

The solitude finally got to Michelle and she invited the girls over. It had to be a weeknight as most of them had family commitments on the weekends. They were gathered in the backyard in the late evening, lights strung above them fighting the deepening darkness. At the horizon, inky blue slipped into black. Nominally together to paint, their hands were filled with wine glasses more often than paint brushes. They’d moved outside once they realized no one had much interest in painting. The night was humid, but at least there was a breeze. It was good to be with the girls and it helped Michelle forget about Clay for a night. He kept calling and texting every day and aside from replying she was fine by text and asking about the boys, Michelle refused to engage with him.

“I guess. If I were you, I’d make the most of this time,” Violet said, also refilling Michelle’s glass.

Violet was a feisty instigator. Whenever they got together, she pushed the booze, and after that she tried to push them out of their comfort zone. Michelle appreciated it—she’d been friends with Violet the longest—but Sarah was a goody-two-shoes who chafed at Violet’s boldness. Sarah was the kind of woman who turned bright crimson anytime the conversation took the slightest turn into risqué territory.

“I know I would. I can’t believe how clean your house is. That’s the first thing that would go,” Eva said.

“You know me better than that. Having the house like this, and not fighting to maintain it every day, is nirvana for me. The constant chaos of having two boys drives me insane,” Michelle replied, quickly adding, “But I love them to death.”

“Of course,” Eva said. “Being a mother is the greatest job we’ll ever have.”

Eva raised her glass for a toast and the women just managed to chink their glasses together before they burst out laughing—Sarah perhaps not as robustly as the others. Sarah added, “And being a wife.”

“Right,” Eva replied. “Maybe if he wasn’t as bad as those kids. I swear, it’s like I have four of them.”

“I’m sure Michelle still misses Clay, right?” Sarah insisted.

Michelle stiffened at her husband’s name and hoped it didn’t show. “Of course,” she tightly replied.

“I don’t know. I don’t find I miss having a husband around,” Violet said. She was divorced two years and never happier.

“I understand why you got rid of Tommy. Clay isn’t like that,” Sarah said.

Michelle just smiled and drank instead of speaking. Violet divorced her husband after learning of his five-year relationship with his receptionist. Suddenly, having the girls over wasn’t making her feel better.

“I don’t know. I think they all have it in them. It’s just about opportunity,” Violet said.

“Then I guess I’m lucky Frank has no opportunities,” Eva said, cracking herself up. She’d already had a glass of wine too many. “I mean, *I* appreciate him, but I don’t see any women knocking down his door. Besides, I keep him happy, so he doesn’t have to go looking.”

“Ha, you do that for yourself, you big slut,” Violet snorted.

“Maybe,” Eva answered, smiling. “I bet you miss *that*, even if you don’t miss the rest of him.”

“Eva!” Sarah exclaimed.

“Oh, chill out Sarah. Regular fucking is part of a happy marriage,” was Eva’s retort. “And you and Clay have that handled, right ‘Chelle?”

Michelle took a deep draw on her wine glass and felt her cheeks redden. “That’s never been a problem. Well, not most of the time—depending on what you consider a problem.”

“Just what does that mean?” Violet asked, sitting up.

Michelle didn’t lay it all out there like some of her friends, but she wasn’t as reserved as Sarah either. She wasn’t shy about sharing what a great sex life she and Clay shared. It was a point of pride, especially considering how hard it could be for people married so long to keep the spark alive. But she hadn’t mentioned any of Clay’s new weirdness to her friends. She didn’t want them thinking Clay was some kind of freak, and she didn’t want them judging her for going along with it—even enjoying it. Michelle was too tipsy to keep her mouth shut completely now though, and it was difficult to keep some of the truth from seeping out.

“I didn’t mean anything,” she replied.

“Doesn’t sound like it. Is something up with you guys?” Eva pushed.

“No, not really. Just things got a little *interesting* before Clay left.”

“Do tell.” It was Violet.

Michelle stared up at the sky, sorted through her possible responses, and said, “Before he left...Clay got me...he bought me a sex toy.” It wasn’t the whole truth, but enough of it for her friends. She fixed Eva with narrowed eyes and added, “Do not ask me to describe it.”

“Why not? I’m not shy about mine. It’s got that little fork on it that hits the button perfectly. It is *magical*,” Eva replied, grinning at her friend’s discomfort.

“Those are pretty good. I still prefer my Hitachi, but I like those too,” Violet said.

“The magic wand scares me. It’s like a jackhammer,” Eva replied.

“But nothing is like the real thing. Did he get you the toy to help you while he’s gone?” Violet said.

“He’d better be careful. You might decide you like it better by the time he gets back.” Eva snorted.

“I guess that’s why he bought it. But we used it together before he left. Have you guys done that, y’know, with your husbands?”

“I wish,” Eva replied, laughing again. “I admire Clay for bringing in reinforcements. Most men aren’t that confident.”

“He didn’t need reinforcements,” Michelle shot back.

“I think it’s a good thing he shook things up,” Violet said. “Got to keep things from getting stale. Right?”

“Sure,” Sarah added, finally rejoining the conversation.

“How do you and Eddie keep it hot?” Eva asked.

Sarah stared at her glass, turning the same color as the wine in it. “You know, we do things. I’m not as uptight as you guys think. Just because I don’t talk about it doesn’t mean we don’t do stuff.”

“So, like what stuff?” Eva pressed.

Michelle felt bad for Sarah. She appreciated that Sarah wasn’t as bawdy as the others and liked her for her sweetness. She was going to save Sarah when her friend answered.

“You know, like lingerie and stuff like that.”

“You dress up for Eddie?” Eva’s eyes were wide.

“Like outfits and stuff? Or just lingerie?” Violet probed.

“I have some outfits.” Sarah’s response was barely a whisper.

“Wow! I’m seeing you as the naughty schoolgirl Eddie has to discipline. Have you been naughty, Sarah?” Violet said sternly.

Sarah did not answer.

“I bet that yard stick stings!” Eva said.

“This is why I don’t tell you guys things!” Sarah protested.

“Come on, guys. Knock it off. Everyone has their things. Who cares if something is weird if both people like it? Right?” Michelle turned to Sarah and quickly added, “I’m not saying you’re weird, hon. I think that sounds like fun.”

Eva squeezed Sarah’s arm and said, “Sorry. I think it’s cool. I wish my man had that much imagination.”

“Yeah. We’re talking about Michelle anyway. So, do you hop onto Facetime and use this thing for him?”

“Do I look like that kind of girl?” Michelle asked, flashing her crooked smile.

Violet smiled back. “Do you want me to answer that?”

“Maybe not,” Michelle replied, laughing.

The girls stayed late, but everyone had to go eventually. Eva insisted she was sober enough to drive, while Sarah played it safe and called Eddie, even though she looked soberer. Michelle waved their Prius off and returned to the house, where Violet had stayed behind to help clear the mess they made.

“You can go home, really. I can tackle this tomorrow,” Michelle insisted, taking glasses from her friend’s hands.

“I might if I thought you’d let it sit until tomorrow. It shouldn’t take too long for us to tackle this together anyway.”

“Thanks.”

They were in the kitchen washing dishes when Michelle decided to seek some advice from Violet. Of all the girls, Violet was the only one she thought might understand, because of her own divorce. She was probably closer to Sarah emotionally, but she just didn’t think Sarah could relate. Although, if Sarah was dressing up for Eddie, maybe... Besides, Sarah taught at their school and she didn’t want to risk any of this leaking. Instead

of washing the glass in her hand, Michelle poured the dregs of a bottle into it and drank before speaking.

“Did Tommy show any signs of what he was up to before you knew for sure?”

“I guess. I mean, at first he was all over me, like he was overcompensating, but then it dropped off almost completely.”

“Did you suspect then, like when he was all over you?”

Violet placed the glass she was drying into the rack beside the sink and faced Michelle. “I don’t think so. Your mind doesn’t just go there. I get the feeling you’re not *just asking*.”

“I could be paranoid...”

“But?”

“I don’t know. I shouldn’t say anything. I’m probably paranoid and wrong. I don’t *want* to believe it.”

Michelle retreated from the kitchen to the living room and sat at the table. It was long and dark wood, with four padded chairs along each side. She’d always thought it was too dark and too big for the room, but Clay loved it. It seemed that Clay loved a lot of things Michelle was unsure about. Violet followed and sat beside her.

“Chelle, honey, tell me. I think, in general, we know.”

“I know. Like I said, I don’t want it to be true.”

“Lay it out for me.”

“Okay. There’s this girl who was a student teacher under him last fall...”

“Oh boy,” Violet said, taking Michelle’s hand.

Michelle took a deep breath. She started with all the Piper stuff, working back to the kinky bedroom stuff. She needed to steel herself to expose that part of their lives. The words did not come easily. Michelle didn’t know how to describe Clay’s fantasies with any subtlety and she still felt the urge to protect her husband, even if he was having an affair. She

settled on simply saying he told her crazy, kinky things while he used the toys with her.

“It sounds like they made you uncomfortable,” Violet replied, after some thought. She did not push her friend.

“Mostly.”

“Mostly?”

“I, uh, I guess part of me...uhm...liked it too.”

“What’s wrong with that? I think everyone has some kind of hidden desires they don’t want anyone to know about.”

“Clay talks about me being with other guys. It’s like he gets off on me screwing other men—so he says. I’m still not sure I believe it. I think it’s a smokescreen to hide his affair. The one he claims he’s not having.”

Michelle felt like a weight had been lifted. She was afraid of being judged, and she didn’t want to out Clay, but she realized she needed someone to talk to about this. It was too much to carry on her own. Violet was a good friend. She wouldn’t gossip on her.

Violet sighed. “A lot to unpack there, ‘Chelle. You could be right. It would make a lot of sense. If he gets you fucking other men, he has cover if you find out about this girl...”

“Piper.”

“Yes, Piper. What are you going to say about him sleeping with Piper if you’re running around with other men?”

“Except, I’d supposedly have his ‘permission.’”

“Like you need his permission to do anything. You’re your own woman.”

“Right!” Michelle agreed.

“It could be this is his way to an open marriage. He just got a head start on you. Clay gets you sleeping around and comes out about Piper. You guys have an open relationship and live happily ever after.”

“He should know better than that.”

“Maybe. Or...”

“Or what?”

“It could be that he gets off on it.”

“Gets off on what?”

“On the idea of you with other men. Yeah, it sounds weird, but that must be a thing, right? Everything is a thing for someone.”

“You think so,” Michelle replied doubtfully. “I mean, it’s *possible*, but does someone just get a fetish like that? If he’d had it all along, I’d surely have known about it.”

Violet shrugged. “I don’t know. People keep secrets.”

Michelle chewed on that. If Clay had some kind of fetish about her sleeping with other men, she could probably accept it, if he didn’t try to make her do it. She liked to think she was open-minded. She couldn’t see ever making it a reality, especially while Clay sat in the corner and watched. That would be creepy. But if he wanted to have fantasies, that was okay, wasn’t it? Clay’s fetishes, however, were not her immediate problem. Piper was.

“But you do think he’s having an affair, right?” she asked.

“Oh, for sure.” Violet nodded. “Maybe I’m jaded, but I don’t trust any of them. He brought her up there for the whole summer for what? So he could flirt with her? Clay is a man. He’s going to want more than flirting.”

“I totally get why Clay would want her. She’s young, sexy, likes being half-naked...”

“We’re still young, ‘Chelle, and I bet you still look pretty damned good half-naked. He’s got you. He doesn’t need her.”

“Ha! Thank you, but is it about need?”

“No, and I get where you were going. Why would she? Come on, you never slept with an older man when you were younger?”

Michelle smiled slyly. “What’s older?”

“Exactly. Listen, he’s an authority figure—that can be hot. She probably has daddy issues. Don’t need to be Freud to figure this one out.”

“Let her find a daddy who’s not taken. Clay is an actual daddy! Doesn’t she care about destroying a family?”

“Who knows? What are you going to do about it?”

“I have no idea. He denies it.”

“Yeah, of course he does. Tommy denied it at first too. He didn’t admit it until I threw the evidence in his face.”

“I don’t have any real proof. I don’t know what I can do without a smoking gun. You hired that PI and were able to prove it. Should I hire a private investigator to go traipsing through the woods and catch them?”

“Might not be a bad idea. It’s pricy, though. Maybe if you press, he’ll confess.”

“Maybe. He was pretty strong in his denials. But I could tell there was something he wasn’t telling me.”

“You need to do something, unless you want to stay at this impasse.”

Michelle stared at her empty glass and asked, “Did you ever think about getting back at Tommy?”

“Do you mean...”

“You know what I mean.”

Violet smiled and said, “What makes you think I didn’t?”

Michelle looked up from the wineglass and stared at her friend. “Really?”

“I don’t blab about everything I do. I have some secrets. Why? Are you thinking about...”

“No, not seriously. But I am pissed, and lonely, and there’s that guy who did our family portraits. I told you about Wes, didn’t I?”

“I remember. How could I forget with the way you described him?”

“Even if he wasn’t so built—those eyes. Oh my god.”

“He sounds perfect for a revenge fuck.”

“I’m seeing him tomorrow. He wanted to meet to go over proofs.”

“Don’t you do that online these days? Sounds to me like he found an excuse to see you again.”

“You think so?”

“Chelle, you’ve got to stop selling yourself short.”

“He is pretty flirty. It’s nice to have a younger guy flirting with me.”

“You didn’t mention he was younger.”

“Not like a boy, but yeah, Wes is younger, probably in his thirties. I didn’t card him. He’s the second one, actually. There was this other kid—he was more of a kid—who hit on me when I dropped the kids off at camp. He was pretty brazen about it, too.”

“Look at you. Michelle Winthrop, MILF bait.”

Michelle swatted Violet on the arm. “Stop it. Don’t you find MILF a little offensive?”

“Why? I want someone to fuck me, and I am a mother. Would you prefer cougar?”

“Really, stop. I am not a MILF. I am not a cougar. I am not on the prowl.”

“Sounds to me like maybe you are. What’s his name, Wes?”

“I’m sure he’s just being flirty, and it doesn’t mean anything. He’s just left an impression on me, that’s all.”

“Bet he’d make quite an impression into your mattress.”

“Violet!”

“If Clay can play, why can’t you? Besides, you said he’s practically given you permission.”

“Two wrongs don’t make a right. Screwing some hot photographer isn’t the solution to my martial problems.”

“But it will feel so good while you’re figuring it out.”

“You didn’t regret it?” Michelle asked, suddenly serious.

“Not for a second. Actually, I think going out and finding a guy gave me the boost of courage I needed to move on and do what needed to be done.”

“I just don’t think I could do it. No offense, but I’m not wired that way. I don’t think I’m a cheater.”

Violet squeezed Michelle’s arm. “Listen, ‘Chelle. I like to think it’s not cheating if they did it first. And I’ve found that I don’t know what I’m capable of until I’m in the moment. I think most people are like that. I could tell you some stories...”

“Okay, I’m kicking you out now. It’s late and we both need to go to bed.”

“You just don’t want me filling your head with any more ideas.”

“Maybe...”

“Or you need your rest for Wes tomorrow.”

“Stop it.”

“If you don’t go for it, I want his number,” Violet insisted.

Michelle pulled her best innocent waif look for a beat and both women laughed. Michelle saw her friend to the door, and they embraced tightly. It felt good. Michelle couldn’t remember the last time someone had hugged her. She missed physical contact, being on her own. Violet’s taillights disappeared down the street and Michelle went around the house turning out the lights before heading up to bed.

The nightstand lamp was the only light left on in the house and she was in bed, lotioning her long legs before turning in for the night. Michelle had been hedging with Violet. Wes had been on her mind more than she would even admit to herself. On those lonely nights, after too many glasses of wine, his eyes and soft lips came back to haunt her. Her talk with Violet made that worse.

Michelle snuffed the light and lie back in bed. Visions of Wes came to her in a flash. There he was in those tight jeans that made his buns look so delicious. She easily pictured the way his t-shirt stretched over his arms.

And then that smile. That smile that said Wes saw her—really saw her. He didn't treat her like was she was a nonperson because she was a mother and a wife and over forty. Wes saw her, and in her mind's eye he wanted her. She imagined him stepping closer in the backyard, stroking her hair back, and kissing her. Michelle's lips parted in anticipation, and she sighed.

Shifting on the bed, Violet's words came back to her. *Bet he'd make quite an impression on your mattress.* Michelle imagined Wes there with her, lips seeking her delicate neck, hands teasing her tender places. Wes moving atop her, parting her thighs.

"Ahh..." she moaned into the darkness.

Michelle touched herself, a hand inside her loose sleep shorts. She was slick and her fingertips easily found their path between her folds to that little pearl. Michelle gasped. Wes would fill her, she was sure. Her mind went to Clay's bag of toys and how she could make the fantasy more real. She imagined Wes was that big and gasped again as she fantasized how it would feel. The bag of toys beckoned, but she would not respond. That was Clay's game, and she was angry with her husband—that cheating bastard. It would serve him right if she screwed Wes when she saw him.

Now Clay's words echoed in her brain. *You like that big cock inside you, Michelle?* Her response had been a passionate *Yes!* like she was begging for it. He said, *Damn, you're sexy, babe. I love watching you take that big cock. You're fucking amazing, Michelle.* Clay had asked if she wanted it harder and she begged.

Wes replaced Clay as she frantically rubbed herself, fingers working back and forth. It was his thick cock inside her, not some toy. Michelle drew her legs up and her toes curled as the climax crashed through her. She hammered her heels on the sheets and cried out, rigid like steel before going dish-rag limp. A deep sigh tore from her chest and her mouth was parched, but she couldn't help smiling.

It was a nice fantasy. A crazy fantasy. *I could never do it, though*, she told herself. *Could I? No. That's not me.* Michelle could be bad, but only within boundaries. *No, I never could. Could I... He does deserve it...* But that wasn't the point. Clay's bad behavior didn't give her permission to become an adulteress. Violet may think so, but Michelle didn't. But she could finally admit that it was fun to think about it. Wes was a nice distraction from her problems.

NINE

THE RIDE into the city reminded Michelle of the old days. When she and Clay first moved to the area, and before the boys, they had a tiny apartment downtown, off South Street. It had probably originally been an efficiency, but someone threw up a wall and created a long, narrow “bedroom,” which was hardly wider than their mattress, turning it into a nominal one bedroom. They were happy with what they had back then, and they were so in love and all over each other that they didn’t mind the lack of space. The tiny apartment was *cozy*. Nowadays, they got into the city with the kids every once in a while, but Michelle couldn’t remember the last time he’d gone down there by herself. She relied on her phone to navigate her to the address Wes had given her.

The address was in an old industrial district that had been sketchy the last time Michelle ventured around there. Gentrification had struck in the intervening years and many of the old warehouses had been turned into condo buildings and old light manufacturing factories were now brew pubs, restaurants and artist studios. It looked like such a fun place to live and work, but Michelle felt out-of-touch being there. A mom from the suburbs could never be hip enough to live down there, she realized. Her boho days were behind her. She found a curbside space and parked her minivan among the Minis and Priuses.

Wes's place was in one of the big old brick warehouses that had been made over and she suspected this was where he lived as well, not just his studio or office. Butterflies launched in her stomach and she thought that being alone with Wes in his condo might not be a good idea. A check of her phone told Michelle she was right on time. It would be rude to cancel now. She quickly stabbed the button on the intercom like she feared it might burn her finger. Wes told her to come on up, and the door buzzed.

Michelle could not keep Violet out of her mind all day. Her friend's voice got louder the closer she got to Wes. *If Clay can play, why can't you? Besides, you said he's practically given you permission.* Violet made it sound like getting her first revenge fuck was the best thing she'd ever done. Michelle understood the primal logic. And if she was going to screw anyone, well Wes was a perfect candidate. She just couldn't do it.

The heavy, sliding door to Wes's condo loomed in front of her and Michelle fought the urge to run away. She didn't knock, but the door rolled aside anyway, startling her.

"Hey, there. Come on in. You didn't come all the way down here to hang out in the hallway, did you?" Wes had that smile turned up to eleven.

"Right. Of course. Thanks," she murmured.

Wes stood to the side, but not far enough that Michelle didn't have to brush against his muscular chest to get by him. He wore another expensive-looking, black V-neck t-shirt that flattered his gym-hardened body and she wondered if it was some kind of uniform for him. She pretended not to notice how it showed off his impressive build and passed into his place.

The loft was massive and mostly open space. A large open plan kitchen greeted her first, beside a large living room area with black leather couches and a glass-topped coffee table organized around an area rug. A back corner held a weight bench and a rack of free weights. To the left of that was an office space, where a massive monitor topped a glass and steel desk. Beyond was a closed off area she assumed contained a bathroom and maybe

closets or a guestroom. Open stairs led to a loft above that, which acted as a bedroom, but Michelle couldn't see much from down below, beside a large bed. The most startling feature of the amazing, open space were the giant windows looking out on the neighborhood below. Wes would be able to see everything from his vantage point. Michelle wondered if that also meant all of the neighbors could see into his place.

"You look great. Love that skirt. I may have to break out my camera again," Wes commented, coming close behind her after closing the door. She stood near the large island at the edge of the kitchen area.

"That's sweet, but it's nothing special."

Michelle's cheeks heated at his compliment, but she played it cool with her patented *this old thing?* attitude. She would argue that he wasn't, but Wes was very much on her mind when she changed to go meet him. Off went the cut-offs and comfy old t-shirt she'd been lounging around the house in, and she changed into a burgundy faux-wrap bodysuit paired with an old brown corduroy skirt closed by three big buttons up the front. She'd had the skirt so long it was back in style again and it was shorter than most of the skirts and dresses she wore these days, hitting a few inches above the knee. The bodysuit had a deep V neck, which she probably would have worn with a camisole under other circumstances. She didn't really have cleavage to show, but the top did flash a lot of skin. The lace fringes of her bralette flashed when she moved, but Michelle didn't mind that if Wes didn't. She hoped he wouldn't. The outfit was meant to be cool without looking like she was making an effort.

"I guess that means you're sexy without trying." He moved around to the kitchen side of the island.

She couldn't suppress her smile, even as she chided, "Do you really talk to all the married women you meet this way?"

"Only when it's true, and only if they don't smack me for it the first time."

Michelle regarded him, trying to avoid those deep, soulful eyes. “I couldn’t smack a boy as pretty as you. What if I left a mark?”

“I don’t mind if you leave marks, as long as I can too.” His smile was dazzling.

“Wow, that wasn’t even subtle,” she complained, her cheeks shading an even deeper crimson.

“Like I said, you haven’t smacked me yet. I get the feeling you like the attention.”

“Do you now?” she chuckled. “Because you know me so well?”

“I think I know a bit about you, and what I’ve figured out so far intrigues me. Makes me want to know more.”

She leaned forward on the island, pushing between the bar-height chairs lining the outside. resting her elbow on it and pressing her chin in her hand. “Oh? Do tell. I’d love to hear what you’ve got figured out about me.”

“How about some wine first? I peg you for a white wine girl. I’ve got a great Angeline Chardonnay.”

“I’m impressed. That’s a very good guess.” Michelle loved California whites.

“Is that a yes?” Wes was already pulling the bottle from the refrigerator.

“I shouldn’t. It’s a long drive home.”

“A single glass won’t kill you.”

“Mmm. I guess so. Just one. You really are a full service photographer, aren’t you?”

“I aim to please.”

Michelle watched him open and pour the wine. One glass wouldn’t get her drunk, and it would calm her nerves. She felt like Wes had her off balance from the moment she stepped into his office/condo, and it wasn’t just because she was on his turf. Wes was working the charm hard, and she

was in the perfect receptive mood. He handed her a large glass of wine and poured one for himself.

“Okay, so tell me all about me,” she said, smiling.

“Sure, but if I’m right, you have to tell me more.”

“Like what?”

“Whatever I ask.”

It was a dangerous game, but she was in the mood to play. Besides, she doubted the cocky photographer really had her all figured out. “Okay, go for it.”

Wes stepped back and looked her over, running a hand through his afro, mussing the springy curls. Michelle obliged him by standing back from the island and striking a momentary pose. His appraising eyes gave her goosebumps and reminded her they were alone with a bed somewhere close by. She returned to leaning against the kitchen island, wineglass in both hands.

“You’re not a typical suburban mom,” he started.

“Really? That’s what you’ve got?” She laughed.

“You’re happy with your life, but there’s something restless underneath. You just thought it would all be a little more exciting. Your routine is comforting, but a little boring. You miss the trips into the city to go to the art museum or find the newest hip little boutique.”

“That’s all still pretty general.” *But not inaccurate*, she thought.

“I think you like attention.”

“What?” She giggled nervously.

“You like attention, but you’re uncomfortable admitting it because humility is in your nature. You mentioned you modeled when you were younger. You don’t get in front of the camera unless you enjoy the attention. You like being looked at. You like being admired.”

“That’s just crazy,” she insisted, even as the flush rising to her cheeks gave her away.

“I don’t think so. I saw how you came alive in front of my camera. You’re very pretty and you know it.”

“You make me sound conceited.”

“No, not conceited. That would make you less attractive. I hate it when a hot woman knows her hotness and wields it as a weapon.”

“You’re saying I’m hot now?”

“You know you’re hot.”

“Do I?”

Wes smiled and came closer. The island between them suddenly felt tiny. Michelle looked up at him. Those eyes...that smile... She nearly swooned there, right in front of him. Michelle nervously tucked her hair back behind her ear and sipped her wine.

“Maybe you don’t think of yourself as hot, but you know you’re attractive and you like the attention it brings you, even if you have trouble admitting it. You put that outfit on today and you knew you looked good in it.”

“What’s wrong with that?”

“Nothing. It’s sexy when a woman knows her value. I’ll go even further. You like that I think you’re sexy. It makes you squirm a little, but you like it.”

“You’ve got me pegged. You have me all figured out.”

Wes came around the island and was next to her. Michelle stood to her full height, but the butterflies in her belly made her feel off balance. Wes was too close. Close enough to kiss. He put his hand on the island and when it brushed hers it was electric.

“You don’t like that I think you’re sexy?”

“I don’t want you to call me ugly...”

“But you *like* that I think you’re sexy.”

“I do? Don’t forget I’m married.”

“How can I when you keep reminding me? Maybe that makes you sexier.” Wes hooked her pinky with his.

Michelle was frozen. She was sure he was going to kiss her, but she didn’t move away from him. None of the stuff with Clay mattered in that moment—even if it gave her an excuse. Her body didn’t react to Wes like that because her husband was cheating on her. It reacted because Wes was a sexy man and he was so close she felt the heat coming off his body, and it ignited her own. But when she did think of Clay, she thought it would serve him right if she kissed Wes, wouldn’t it?

“What about those proofs?” she asked, clearing her throat. Michelle slid away from Wes and the tension was broken—for the moment.

Wes smiled. He knew exactly what was going on with her. Michelle saw it in his eyes. But he didn’t press. “Have a seat on the couch. I’ll bring the tablet over.”

The black leather couch was deep, and Michelle sunk into it, making it difficult to keep her skirt from riding too high. Wes came over with a large tablet, and although she chose the far end of the couch, he sat unnecessarily close, leaving plenty of open space on his other side. Wes flipped open the leather cover of the tablet and flicked through folders with a stylus until he brought up the photos he took of Michelle’s family. She pried herself out of the couch, flashing a lot of thigh in the process, and balanced on the edge of the couch to lean forward and look at the tablet. She tried to ignore how close Wes sat.

“These are really, really good,” she commented. “Go back one.”

“This one is my favorite, too. The posed ones are good, and they make for nice Christmas cards, but I think it’s the photos like this that I snap in between that really capture the essence of my subjects.”

“You’re right.”

The photo caught the boys laughing and Michelle trying to push Jack’s hair back in place. Clay had an arm around her waist, and he looked

perfectly content to be with his family in their backyard. They really did look like the perfect all-American family, which made it so hard for Michelle to reconcile Clay having an affair with a girl almost half her age. Would Clay really risk everything because he was bored? Even if Piper seduced him, shouldn't Clay have had enough reason to stay strong and resist her?

"Are you okay?" Wes asked, resting a hand on her knee. His touch scorched her.

"Uh, yeah. I guess I just miss them all. They're all gone for most of the summer. I'm not used to it."

"I can see that. I'm sure you're a great mom. And wife. Clay's lucky to have you. So are the boys."

"Thanks." She smiled weakly.

"But you're also your own person, y'know? Rather than just missing them, maybe you should take this time and be selfish for a change. Make this summer about you. I think you deserve that."

"Yeah, is this more of how you have me figured out?" Michelle smiled, shaking off her melancholy. She was getting whiplash from how rapidly her emotions swung back and forth these days.

"I'm sure you deserve it as much as anyone. Make it the Summer of Michelle."

"I like that. You're right, you know. It's never just about me. There's always something that demands my attention."

"So now you can put that attention where it needs to be. On you. What would you love to do that you never normally do?"

The tingling that she'd felt when Wes brushed her hand in the kitchen had now spread through her entire body. He was pressed to her side and he left his hand on her knee. It was a reassuring gesture, she knew, but it felt like so much more than that. Her skin was hot where his big hand rested on her bare skin. Michelle wished her skirt were a little longer, because then he

wouldn't be touching her bare skin and maybe she wouldn't be so tempted. She could only think of one thing she'd love to do in that moment. She'd never felt such temptation. She glanced down at Clay in the photograph again and instead of looking content, she decided he looked smug. He looked like he was hiding a secret. Clay had his cake, and he was eating it, too. He knew the day after that picture was taken that he was leaving to spend the summer with that little tart Piper.

What did Michelle want to do for herself? She wanted Wes to pin her down on the couch and kiss her until she was ready to faint. Her eyes flitted sideways. His lips looked so soft. She imagined he was a great kisser. He was right there. She could just lean over. Michelle realized his question still hung in the air.

"I, uh, I don't know."

"Are you sure about that?"

The tension was killing her. Michelle could see Wes knew what she wanted but couldn't do. Did he enjoy torturing her? Was he just toying with her? Or was he a decent guy and he wasn't going to just kiss a married woman?

"I think you like pushing my buttons," she replied.

"You do owe me a confession. I think I've figured you out pretty well."

Michelle jumped off the couch, pushing his hand away. She couldn't be that close to Wes for another second. Her self-control was at its breaking point. She walked to the windows. "You've got an amazing view here. Is that why you picked the place?"

"Part of the reason. It also has the space I need to work, and I got in here before the prices skyrocketed. I like being in the center of things. I can feel the energy of the neighborhood."

"It must be fun, living down here." She kept her eyes fixed on the street below, refusing to look back at Wes. Her heart still hammered in her chest.

"You should come down here and hang out. I think you'd really like it."

“Maybe I will.”

“We could go out and get a bite to eat, if you’d like.”

Michelle wanted to say yes. God, she wanted to say yes. But she wouldn’t let herself. “We should probably wrap this up so I can get back home. I don’t want to be stuck in the city too late.”

“You have a hot date planned?”

She turned and smiled at him, deciding to push back. He stood a few feet behind her, a camera in his hands. “What’s that for?”

“I want to take your picture, of course. You’re the perfect subject, Michelle. I can’t help myself. You must understand the feeling, the compulsion to do something.”

“Maybe I do,” she replied, her smile quirking.

“Of course you do, if you’re leaving for a date. You didn’t answer. Do you have a hot date?”

“What if I did? Would that fit in with the image you have of me?”

“It depends. A fling or an affair?”

Wes lifted the camera and snapped her picture. Michelle didn’t raise a hand to block his lens this time or try to hide. She smiled for the camera while she decided how to answer him. It wasn’t a question she’d ever pondered before—a fling or an affair—because neither was ever a possibility in her mind. An affair, like Clay was having, was worse than a fling or a one night stand. It was a bigger betrayal. Maybe—yeah right—Michelle could give herself permission for a one night stand, but not an affair. She could never live with the guilt.

“It’s a fling. It is the Summer of Michelle after all, isn’t it? I need to be able to go back to my normal life when the fall comes. Summer flings are the best.”

“Someone you know, or a stranger?”

Wes moved around her, snapping more photos. Michelle instinctively posed for him. Muscle memory from her modeling days returned. She knew

how to position her body best for the camera. She placed a hand on her hip, cocked her head as she smiled. It should have felt silly, but it didn't. Wes's attention felt anything but silly. It would be so easily to have a fling with Wes. He was neither stranger, nor someone she really knew. But if not Wes, who?

Michelle immediately thought of Declan and his relentless flirting. What would he do if she called him on it? She liked to think of the hunky gym teacher as the dog who chased the car. He wouldn't know what to do if he caught her. It could be fun finding out though, couldn't it? *That* would be the perfect way to get back at Clay. Her husband was obsessed with the way Declan flirted with her. But no, she wouldn't do that with a co-worker. It had to be someone outside her normal life. Someone like Wes would be perfect. *If* she would ever do that sort of thing. The photographer kept snapping away while she pondered.

"It couldn't be a complete stranger. I couldn't do that. I have to know *something* about the guy."

"So not a neighbor or a co-worker, but someone else you've met in your life?"

"Yes, he's someone exactly like that. He's just a good time, with no entanglements."

"He's a lucky guy, this fling of yours."

Michelle's smile grew wider. "You have no idea. But he doesn't like being kept waiting."

"Your smile is enchanting, Michelle. Here, turn this way, just a bit. Yeah, like that. If I were this guy, I'd wait as long as I needed to, and be happy for it."

"You sound jealous."

Michelle moved back to the island, half-sat on one of the stools, her leg bent and her arms spread back to lean on the island. Wes started away from

her, but he came close and she felt its unblinking gaze crawling over her. She had goosebumps and shivered.

“You are a beautiful woman. Thinking about you letting go and having a fling is hot. I’d be a fool if I didn’t wish it were me.”

“That’s sweet, Wes.”

“I don’t know if *sweet* is the word, Michelle. Here, climb up, sit on the counter.”

“Are you serious?”

“You said I’m good. Trust me, Michelle.”

Wes kept shooting as she climbed used a stool to climb up and sit on the island. Her skirt rode up too high and he obviously caught it. Michelle hoped she didn’t flash the narrow crotch of her bodysuit, but had a naughty thrill thinking she might’ve. The skirt stayed high on her thighs, and she kept her legs tightly closed.

“You have amazing legs, Michelle. Truly. You must work out.”

“I run, do yoga sometimes. I’m a coach at school and I think it’s important to set an example and stay in shape.”

“That’s not the only reason. Here, lean like this.”

“No?”

Michelle’s whole body vibrated when he touched her. He nudged her to the side. Her body elongated and she leaned onto her elbow on the island counter top. Wes touched her leg, just behind the knee. She bit back the moan—just barely. “Cross your legs, baby.”

The baby was too familiar, but it made her glow. She crossed her legs and kept them tight. The pressure felt good against the damp heat growing between her thighs. This was turning into a full-fledged photoshoot. Michelle didn’t anticipate that.

“There, that’s nice, Michelle. Hot. And no, the kids aren’t the only reason. Like I said, you like attention. You stay in shape because you like the attention it brings you.”

Michelle smiled and chuckled. “You don’t know what it’s like to be a woman over forty, Wes.”

“You still get attention. You know you do, Michelle. Tell me. Tell me about a man who’s noticed you lately.”

Michelle couldn’t wipe away her smile. It was wrong for a married woman to dwell on such things, but didn’t Clay? If her husband like her garnering attention from other men, was it wrong if she liked it too? Michelle really didn’t focus on men noticing her until recently. She didn’t count the men who cat-called her when she was out running. But lately, she couldn’t miss men noticing her. There was always Declan, of course, with his incessant flirting. There was the camp counselor, although she didn’t think of him as a *man*. Still, he noticed her, just like Declan claimed the boys on the volleyball team noticed the *MILFy* coach. Michelle thought she caught a glance or two from men in the supermarket.

“There’s a co-worker. He flirts all the time, but it doesn’t mean anything.”

“It always means something, Michelle.” He paused to snap photos and then touched her again. His touch was scorching and she both wished he’d stop and wished he’d never stop. “We don’t flirt with people we’re not attracted to.”

“I guess,” she answered. “But he’s harmless.”

“Only because you want him to be. If you responded...”

Wes left it dangling while he moved around her. Michelle was laying on the countertop, head propped up on her hand, her body elongated. The camera clicked relentlessly. Wes moved her hand, lowered her head. Michelle closed her eyes, enjoying his hands on her way more than she should. He kept snapping while her eyes were closed. She imagined him laying the camera aside. Her body relaxed and she got a dreamy feeling. Her eyes fluttered open. Wes was above her, standing on the slats of a stool, shooting down at her. It felt like his lens was looking deep within her.

Michelle's heart pounded and she realized her nipples were hard points showing through her bralette and the bodysuit. She was embarrassed, but hoped Wes noticed.

"Do you mind?" he asked, touching her skirt. Michelle didn't respond, which he took as consent. He opened one, then two, of the big buttons closing her skirt. He spread the skirt open, exposing a dangerous amount of thigh. Wes leaned back to snap photos of her whole long, lean body. Michelle relaxed her thighs, letting them part. Her crotch may have been shadowed, but Michelle hoped he saw it. She wanted him to see the wet spot there. She wildly courted danger. The moment was so intimate. A thrill ran down her spine and she was suddenly fearful—hopeful—something might happen. She had to take control back. She licked her dry lips and found her voice.

"We need to wrap this up. I have someone waiting for me, remember?"

"Of course. Don't want to keep your lover waiting. I can only be grateful I had this time with you, Michelle."

Wes stepped down from the stool and offered a hand. He was strong as steel as she pulled and sat up. Michelle hopped down and quickly pulled her skirt in place. She was glowing. Wes watched her while pretending to fuss with his camera. She thought he was wondering if she really had a man waiting. A lover, as he put it. The word almost made her giggle.

Michelle was pleased. She felt like she'd taken control back from Wes. He'd had her off-balance from the time she'd arrived and now she was the provocative one. The condo was still filled with erotic tension, but she didn't feel like she was dying for Wes to kiss her anymore. It felt like he was waiting to see what she might do. Having the power was a heady feeling. She'd been powerless since she'd found out about Clay's affair. Teasing Wes with her hypothetical affair was fun. Maybe the real thing would be worth it.

Michelle returned to the couch, sitting on the arm as she reached for her purse. Wes sat too. It gave him a great view of her long legs in that short skirt—especially with those buttons open—and she didn't mind teasing him a little. It served him right. He couldn't keep his eyes off her legs and that kept the tingling inside Michelle going strong. The temptation to jump Wes returned. She thought about kissing Wes, but as long as she kept some daylight between them, she felt like she could control herself.

They wrapped their business. Michelle chose which photographs she wanted prints of and when they were finished, she found she was disappointed that their appointment was over. Wes had dialed it back and behaved like a professional, but the energy still crackled between them. Neither of them forgot the sexy, impromptu photoshoot. She didn't understand how he played it so cool, but she tried to match him.

"Do you mail those out, or should I come to pick them up?" Michelle asked, tearing the check out of her checkbook.

"I prefer you pick them up. Or I can bring them to you. I don't trust the postal service not to mutilate things."

"All the way out to the suburbs?"

"Seeing you again is worth the trip, Michelle."

Their hands touched when she handed Wes the check and there was that electricity again.

"I guess I'll be seeing you again then. I can come here." Having this man in her house felt more wrong than ever.

Wes smiled. "Should only take me a couple days to get the prints ready."

"Great. I look forward to it."

"Me too. Maybe you'll let me take you for that bite to eat then."

"Sounds like you're asking me on a date."

"You don't need to remind me again that you're married, Michelle. I just like spending time with you. You're allowed to have male friends,

aren't you?"

Michelle thought about it. Did she have any male friends? There was Declan, of course, but she really didn't see him socially. She realized she didn't, but it wasn't because she wasn't *allowed*. Clay didn't allow her to do things. Their marriage wasn't like that—at least it hadn't been. Michelle wasn't sure what her marriage was now.

"I'm a grown woman. I can do whatever I please," she replied.

"Good to hear. Is that a yes?"

"It's a 'we'll see'."

Wes saw her to the door and Michelle didn't want to leave but leaving was the smart thing to do. She'd avoided disaster by taking back control of the evening, but she couldn't count on that continuing if she stayed. Besides, there was no reason to stay, other than embracing the forbidden.

"Goodnight, Michelle," he said, leaning in his doorway.

"Goodnight, Wes. See you soon."

Michelle took a few steps down the hallway and turned. He was still in the doorway, watching her. It made her warm in all the right places. He stared at her and she wanted to melt. No, she wanted to run back up the hallway and jump into his arms. It was a good feeling, knowing she was wanted.

"Wes."

"Yes?"

"Thanks."

He didn't need to ask why. "Sure. See you in a few, Michelle."

Michelle ran down the stairs, stopped at the bottom and leaned against the wall, grinning like an idiot. Her heart pounded like she'd run a marathon, but it wasn't from the steps. It had been over a decade, but Michelle remembered this feeling well. She remembered going on a date with a guy she really liked and how she felt when it ended—which always felt too soon. *This was not a date*, she chastised herself. But if she let Wes

take her to dinner next time, would it be? Seeing Wes again could only lead to trouble, but she wouldn't stay away. Clay was having his fun, she should have some fun of her own. After all, wasn't it the Summer of Michelle?

TEN

MICHELLE SPENT the next several days torn between regret and relief. Wes was branded into her consciousness. She fixated on his broad shoulders and those deep brown eyes. He turned those eyes on her and she lost herself. Michelle kicked herself for not kissing him. the moment had been ripe, and she missed it. She could almost feel those granite arms wrapped around her. She closed her eyes and sighed. Wes wanted her. She knew it, and she didn't think her being married would get in his way. He'd almost said as much.

The pivot to relief wasn't easy, but it made her feel better for her choice. Michelle was relieved she didn't cross that line. She had plenty of justification—Violet told her so, but two wrongs did not make a right. Being a cliché didn't make it less true. Fooling around with Wes would not fix her marriage. It would not stop Clay from screwing Piper—or whatever he was up to. Deep down, she still held out hope that there was another explanation for Clay's behavior. If it turned out Clay wasn't cheating, Michelle would really be relieved she didn't cross any lines with Wes.

Doing the right thing made her feel better, but that faded fast when he texted her some of the photos he took that night she was at his place. Wes captured her essence and his lens brought out her sexiness in a way she didn't know was possible at her age. At first, she wondered if the pictures

were really her. Wes had obviously edited the photos, but they weren't overly airbrushed. Her eyes sparkled in the photos and her skin glowed. Wes made her look like she had the body of a twenty-year-old. It was all the magic of his vision. The photos were really of her, and they were beautiful. It was a window into how Wes saw her and looking at herself as he did made Michelle feel dazzling. The erotic charge of the photographs was not lost on Michelle. The photos Wes took after unbuttoning her skirt did not show all. Her sex was hidden in shadow, making them so much hotter. *I would do me*, she thought, smiling naughtily. Michelle was tempted to send the photographs to her husband to remind him of what he had at home and show him that another man really was interested in his wife.

Wes was right back on her mind, front and center. His lush lips and dazzling smile occupied her idle moments, and then all of the justifications to cheat flew through her mind. Michelle didn't know what was wrong with her. She'd never been so tempted in fifteen years of marriage, and she couldn't lay it all on her husband. She wanted Wes in a way she'd never wanted a man before. In bed alone at night she touched herself thinking of him and easily brought herself to orgasm. She smiled ruefully afterward, thinking that Clay would go crazy if he knew she was doing that.

Clay called that week and she finally answered him. The thing with Wes pushed her. Michelle didn't want to look too closely at her motivations but wanted to give her husband another chance to explain himself. Whether it was to stop her from doing something crazy or to give her a reason to go for it, she couldn't say. She just knew she had to talk to Clay.

"Hey." Clay sounded surprised that she answered.

"How are the boys?" Michelle asked, voice flat.

"Good. They're loving camp. I think they'd stay all summer if we could afford it."

"That's great. It's good for them, as long as they're behaving and not trying to get away with anything because you're there."

“No, they know that wouldn’t fly. Anyway, we’ve raised good kids. You’re a great mom.”

“It’s not all me, but thanks.”

The conversation dropped right into a lull. Michelle found it difficult to press Clay when she wasn’t fiery with rage.

“What have you been up to?” Clay asked.

“School. Seeing the girls. The usual stuff.” Almost as an afterthought, she added, “I saw Wes and went over the proofs for our family portraits.”

“Oh?” Clay noticeably perked up.

“I went to his studio downtown. He works out of a loft he lives in.”

“How did that go?”

“Fine, I guess. I picked out the pictures I want to order.”

“Good. That’s great. He seems like a good guy.”

“I guess. It’s not like we’re friends.”

“No, but you’ve spent time with him now. You must have an opinion,” Clay said.

Michelle was tempted to share her thoughts on Wes in vivid detail. The temptation to send Clay the photographs from Wes flared. She resisted, deciding it was more delicious to keep them as her secret. It was better to keep Wes as her secret fantasy, rather than dangle it in front of Clay. It would torture her husband, but in a way he would enjoy and he didn’t deserve that. His probing about Wes already had her suspicious. His head was probably filled with fantasies of her alone with Wes. If only he knew how close his fantasies were to becoming reality.

“He’s nice, I guess. Very charming. But it wasn’t a date, Clay. I was there to go over *family* portraits.”

“Yeah, I know.” He sounded disappointed she wouldn’t engage.

Michelle tried to read her husband over the phone. His voice was tight. Clay seemed to be probing, but what was he looking for? She recalled their sex play the night before he left. God, it seemed like that was ages ago.

Clay told her, *It would be so hot if Wes was here fucking you right now*. Was that what her husband was thinking about, hoping she did something with the sexy photographer? She couldn't believe he'd go there, given the state of their marriage. But she wondered, what would Clay say if she told him? Maybe that would push him to come clean about Piper. If Michelle told Clay she would do what he claimed he wanted, would he lose his nerve? She seriously thought about calling his bluff.

"Are you still there, 'Chelle?" Clay asked.

"Yeah, sorry."

"When do you go to pick up the pictures?"

"Tomorrow. Wes told me to come back then."

"That's nice. It's a good excuse to get out of the house. You should take advantage of it."

"What does that mean?" she asked. "Take advantage of what?"

"I just meant that you'd be in the city, that's all."

"Is that all? I still don't believe you're being honest with me, Clay."

"Honey, I don't know how to convince you. I am not doing anything with Piper. I am not sleeping with her. I have not touched her."

The mention of his whore's name ignited Michelle's anger. "Even if I believe you, flirting online with a girl half your age is still disgusting, Clay."

"Okay, that's true. I'm sorry about that. That was a lapse in judgment. But I swear, I haven't touched her."

"Then why all the secrecy?"

"I guess I felt some guilt. I think she may have a crush, or she just likes flirting, I don't know. I liked the attention and I got carried away. Listen, I'm a middle-aged man and a pretty young woman was coming onto me. It was flattering."

"And that's why you got her a job up there, because she flirted with you? It wasn't because you wanted her closer?"

“Of course not. Michelle, I am not fucking her.”

“Even if I believed you haven’t yet, I bet you got her up there so you could take your shot.”

“There’s no shot to take!”

“Really?”

“I don’t know what she’s thinking, but it doesn’t matter. I have no interest in her.”

“That’s not what it looks like, Clay.”

“I know that. How can I prove this to you?” Clay raised his voice.

Michelle almost said, *Fire her!* But she didn’t want to be *that wife*. Piper deserved it, just for the flirting, but Michelle would not be the wife who demanded her husband had no attractive women around him.

“Michelle,” Clay said, more softly.

“Clay, I want to believe you. You know I do. But you were keeping the Piper thing from me and you were doing all that weird stuff in bed.”

“I know how it looks, but I promise, the two things aren’t related. I am all about you.”

“Even when you’re looking at Piper’s bikini pictures?”

“That was a mistake. I told you. I meant in the bedroom. That stuff is all about you.”

“Wanting me to fuck other men is all about me? How is that? I only see it as being cover for your fling with Piper.”

“I swear it’s not.”

“If that’s the truth, tell me what it’s about, Clay.”

“I’ve told you over and over again. I thought it would be fun to try something different and kinky in bed. Some crazy fantasies. I was just going with the flow and that’s where it went.”

Michelle’s mind went wild. She meant it when she said she wanted to believe him, but he had to be honest for that to happen. Clay was hiding *something*. She considered what Violet said. It could be that Clay got

off on her fucking other men, but Michelle couldn't comprehend that. She didn't want to judge, but that was just so weird. Men did not want their women—their wives—having sex with other men. Men were possessive. And if Clay had some kind of weird sexual fetish, why did he wait fifteen years to bring it up? Surely there would have been a sign before now. They didn't keep those kinds of secrets—or so she thought. Michelle didn't have any secret sexual fetishes she hid from Clay.

“That just doesn't make sense to me. It's so out of the blue. I mean, do you really want other men to fuck me?”

“I don't know. I told you, it just seemed hot in the moment. I got carried away.”

“Because you know I wouldn't do something like that,” Michelle insisted. She felt like a hypocrite, considering how Wes tempted her, but if Clay was cheating, she still held the moral high ground.

“I know,” he replied contritely.

“Why would you offer me a hall pass unless you were looking for one for yourself?”

“Michelle, I don't know what to tell you. I don't know how to convince you you're wrong about Piper.”

“I don't know what else to say to you. We keep going round and round in circles. Maybe I should come home this weekend, so we can talk face to face.”

Her stomach lurched at the thought of seeing her husband. Michelle hoped Clay would say something to convince her he wasn't sleeping with Piper, but he hadn't. And believing he was sleeping with the girl, she didn't want to see him. She wasn't ready.

“That's not a good idea. I'm going to go now,” she said.

“Okay. I love you.” Clay sounded low.

“Goodnight.”

Before she could end the connection, Michelle heard him squeeze in, “Have fun tomorrow night.”



The chain restaurant was crowded, providing a din of background noise, but Michelle still felt self-conscious discussing her marriage in a public place, so she leaned across the table and spoke in a low voice.

“I talked to Clay last night.”

Violet finished chewing her salmon before answering, “How did that go?”

“I don’t know. He still denies he’s up to anything, but what else is he going to say? Is he really just going to admit it?”

“I told you, Tommy didn’t admit it until I threw the evidence in his face. He couldn’t deny it at that point, but I think he was prepared to bullshit me to the end before that. It’s funny, he actually had the nerve to be pissed I went out and got the evidence. He was offended I went spying.”

“Clay tried that defense, but I didn’t let it fly.” Michelle picked at her salad, but she wasn’t hungry, despite the killer run she’d done that morning in the heat. The conversation robbed her of her appetite.

“You want to believe him, don’t you?”

“Of course, I do. We’ve been together almost twenty years. He’s the father of my children. I don’t want it to be over.”

“You’ll leave him if it’s true?”

“I don’t know. Don’t I have an obligation to try and work through it?”

“I’m the wrong person to ask.” Violet chuckled. “I threw Tommy out on his cheating ass. There was no way I’d ever trust him again.”

“How could you?”

“Exactly. I think, once a cheater, always a cheater.”

“It could just be that he couldn’t resist the temptation. If Piper didn’t...”

“Don’t blame the girl. I mean, yeah, she’s a ho, but it’s not her fault your man cheated on you. *If* he cheated. If you want to believe him, why don’t you?”

Michelle sipped her water while she considered the question. “I don’t want to be that fool. Pride? I don’t want to be that wife who just refuses to admit her cheating husband could do it. And if he is doing it, and I let it go, what’s to stop him from carrying on? He’ll keep screwing Piper and then there’ll be the next one. I won’t be played for a fool.”

“You only have two options. Believe him or not. Forgive him or not. You can’t stay in limbo forever.”

“It’s easier with him being away.”

“He won’t be gone forever.”

“You’re not helping.”

“Okay. Maybe getting some for yourself will clear your mind. You can let Clay slide if you get some of your own. How did it go with Wes the other night?”

“It was a meeting. It didn’t *go*. Nothing *went*. We went through the pictures,” Michelle replied, staring down at her salad.

“It was all business?”

“Yes. Mostly.”

“Mostly? Come on, ‘Chelle. Get real,” Violet demanded.

Michelle smiled and looked up. “He was pretty flirty. Maybe I flirted back. And then he took out his camera.”

“That sounds fun. What kind of pictures?” Violet sounded eager to hear something juicy.

“Not like that, Vi! I didn’t strip for him! Who do you think I am?”

“You’re glowing, hon. I don’t think he just snapped a quick photo and was done with it.”

“Okay, it was a bunch of pictures...and he got close...and yeah, it got a little steamy. There’s just something about Wes, and the way he makes me feel.”

“Just imagine how he could make you feel with your clothes off, hon.”

“Vi!”

“Forget the Clay stuff. I like seeing you like this, ‘Chelle. You’re a sexy momma and it’s good to see you remembering it.”

Michelle waived and then pulled out her phone. She brought up the photos from Wes and passed to phone to Violet. Her friend took time, closely examining each photo, flipping back and forth. Michelle knew how sexy the photos were and it felt strange showing them to her friend, but she was just so damn proud. Violet finally handed the phone back with a sly smile.

“That boy definitely wants to fuck you, hon.”

“Really?”

“Stop playing coy, ‘Chelle. You know it. You don’t take pictures like that unless you want to fuck someone. Wes was fucking you in his mind the entire time. If you said yes...”

“I know,” Michelle admitted. “I just...I don’t know...”

“Send the pictures to Clay. It’ll shock the fuck out of him. It might be the wake-up call he needs.”

“I thought of that. I don’t want him jerking off to me right now.”

Both women laughed.

“Seriously, hon. You’re a fool if you don’t go for it. This can’t be coincidence. Wes landed in your lap right now for a reason.”

“It’s still cheating, and it’s still wrong, Vi. I know he’s interested. He’s done everything but come right out and say it.”

“What are you waiting for, girl? You have a hot guy who wants you. You think your husband is cheating on you. I mean, it’s like the universe is screaming for you to do it!”

“And if I do it and then find out Clay really is innocent?”

“Let’s be honest, ‘Chelle. That man isn’t *innocent*. You saw what he’s up to online.”

“Clay drooling over Piper doesn’t give me an excuse to go sleep with another man.”

“I think you need this to clear your mind. It’ll give you some perspective.”

“Sleeping with another man will give me perspective?”

Violet smiled. “I’m trying to help you here. Don’t analyze it too much. Listen, something happens with you and Wes and you find out somehow that Clay isn’t messing with that girl, then it’ll just be your little secret.”

“And I’ll feel horribly guilty!”

“‘Chelle, you need to go see him, have a few glasses of wine, and just let go. Have a night to remember and you and Clay will be even when he comes home. Life goes on.”

“You make it sound so simple.”

“And you’re making it more complicated than it needs to be. I’m telling you. If you let this chance go by, you’ll always wonder what might have happened.”

“And I’ll still be able to look myself in the mirror.”

Violet just stared at her. Michelle invited her friend to lunch in hopes that it would clarify things for her, but she was more conflicted than ever. Much of what her friend said was right, of course. She had to decide she believed Clay, or that she didn’t. If she believed him, she had to let it go. And if she didn’t... Michelle didn’t know, but she did know that sleeping with Wes wouldn’t fix her marriage. It would just be a selfish reaction. Did she deserve it? Probably. If anyone deserved to indulge herself, it was

Michelle. She tried to rationalize. *If I just fool around with Wes a little bit...* Violet was right. Clay was not innocent, even if he didn't screw Piper. If Michelle wanted to see where all the flirting with Wes was going, she was within her rights, given what she did know Clay had done.

"You so want to. It's written all over your face. You're just trying to find reasons *not* to do it," Violet said.

"I'm married. That's a pretty good reason not to do anything with Wes."

"Did that slow Clay down?"

"Ouch!"

"Sorry, but it's true. Just pick up the phone and call Wes. See what happens. If it doesn't feel right, you'll keep your morality intact. I have faith in you."

"I'm seeing him tonight," Michelle conceded. "I have to pick up the prints."

Violet laughed and slapped the table so hard people around them looked over. "You already have a date with him?"

"Keep your voice down," Michelle hissed. "It's *not* a date. I'm just going to pick up the family portraits. Remember, I have a family? I'm a married woman?"

"On a Friday night."

"That's when he was available."

"Chelle, you've never been a good bullshitter. You want me to talk you into it. That's what this lunch is all about."

"What? No!" Michelle wasn't even convincing herself.

"You're going to see Wes tonight and you're going to do what feels right, in the moment."

"Even if it's wrong?"

"Think about Clay drooling over that blonde's tits and tell me it's wrong."

“Stop.”

“And as soon as you’re done, you’re going to text me and tell me everything that happened.”

“You won’t be busy?”

“I can make time for this.”

“You’re terrible, you know that?” Michelle said.

“And that’s exactly why you called me! If you won’t be honest with me, at least be honest with yourself.”

“I’m trying. I’ll let you know how it works out.”

ELEVEN

MICHELLE SAT in the minivan and stared at her phone. A text—cancelling her meeting with Wes—sat on the screen there, waiting to be sent. She was right outside his loft, but she could still send it and drive home. The text had lingered in her drafts since lunch with Violet, but every time she went to send it, she found a reason not to. She told herself, *It's a meeting. It's not a big deal. I'll pick up the prints and be in and out.* That probably wasn't true, and Michelle knew it. But she did insist it was a *meeting* and not a *date*. She would not call this a date, even if it felt very much like a date. She had that nervous feeling she used to have before dates. And she'd put a lot of thought into her outfit, as if she were going on a date.

At first, she was going to go with something totally chill. Mom shorts and a plain, boring top. That would cool Wes down. She just couldn't do it, though. The desire to look good for Wes was irresistible. She wanted his attention, just like he said. Wes complimented her outfit last time and she wanted that again, but she didn't want her outfit to scream *date*. The floral romper she tried was too cutesy. A short navy dress with polka dots was too sexy. She finally went with a blue and white tie-dye maxi dress. The long dress had a slim-fitting silhouette, which flattered her trim body, and a side slit up to her knee. She always wore a white t-shirt underneath—to avoid

showing too much skin up top—but for Wes, she left it off and chose a navy bralette to wear underneath. The wide, lacy straps were obvious under the spaghetti straps of her dress and it reminded Michelle of her younger days, when intentionally showing your bra straps was all the rage. She hoped Wes would like the little flash of lace, even though she knew she shouldn't. A sweater sat on the seat beside her in case she lost her nerve and wanted to cover up.

This is ridiculous, she thought. Michelle stared at the phone like a teenage girl hoping it would ring. She didn't drive all the way downtown to sit in her car and stare at her phone. And if she was honest, she didn't do it to turn around and go home either. *It's time to be a big girl*, she thought. *Go up there. If it feels wrong, grab the prints and run.* The phone went into her small handbag and she locked up the minivan, leaving the sweater behind.

It was a warm summer evening, and the neighborhood was vibrant with life. The bistro on the corner was crowded, its outdoor seating filled with happy young couples on dates. Groups of people passed her on the sidewalk as she stared up toward Wes's building. She couldn't see into his loft from her angle, but she imagined he was there, looking down for her. In case he was watching, Michelle strode up the sidewalk with a deliberate, confident swish to her hips. He buzzed her right up.

"I was starting to think you stood me up," Wes said, as she passed him to enter the loft.

"I couldn't stand you up because this isn't a date."

"Right. You must have a date with someone else tonight then."

Michelle laughed. "Why do you say that?"

"You look hot, momma. You're dressed up for someone."

He's smooth, I'll give him that, she thought, as her cheeks colored. *He knows how to notice a woman without being creepy.* And Michelle liked being noticed. His eyes poured over her, following the lines of her body under the thin cotton dress. She looked away, pretending not to notice.

“Maybe I am. It is Friday night, after all,” she replied, a playful smile on her lips.

“Is this the fling we were talking about?”

“I don’t remember admitting to anything.”

Wes came and stood near her by the couch. Their hands rested near each other on the arm, almost touching. Michelle almost pulled her hand back but didn’t want to be timid. She didn’t know how it was possible, but Wes just got hotter every time she saw him. The handsome black man smiled down at her and Michelle literally squeezed her thighs tighter. His black dress shirt looked like silk and she wondered how it would feel pressed against her.

“No, not quite. I think you wanted to leave me guessing.”

“Shouldn’t a woman have some mystery to her?”

“Sure, every man likes a challenge.”

“Is that what I am? Am I a challenge?”

“Michelle, you’re so much more than that. But yeah, you’re a challenge, too.”

“I never said I wanted to challenge you.”

“Not everything has to be said.”

Michelle’s heart pounded, and she took a step back to gather herself. The night was off to a quick start. “You’re trouble, Wes. You’re trouble, and you know it.”

“I am what I am. I don’t look to cause trouble, but sometimes trouble finds me, and I don’t hide from it.”

“What am I going to do with you?” she sighed.

“I’m sure you could think of something.”

“Ya think?”

“If not, I have a lot of ideas.”

“Wes,” she sighed, with mock exasperation. She *should* have been exasperated, but she was enjoying their banter.

“So, Michelle, is this all for another man, or are we going to dinner?”

“I guess we could grab something, as long as it’s quick. I mean, I have to eat anyway.”

“Right? You do have to eat. Take a look at the prints while I get ready.”

Wes took a large envelope from his desk and placed it in her hands. Michelle watched him move around the loft and thought he looked more than ready to her. She had to force herself to stop watching Wes and look at her family portraits. Her family was the last thing on her mind in that moment.

The portraits were beautiful. They were even more vivid printed than they had been on the screen. The colors really popped, and the lighting was perfect. They were far from the old school Sears Portrait Studio pictures her family always did when she was young. Michelle shuffled through the pictures and they tugged at her heart strings, making her question what she was doing alone in a strange man’s loft. But then she focused on Clay and not the boys and all of his weak denials came rushing back to her. She was there because she wanted to do something selfish, just like her husband had. She had the right.

After the pictures of the family, she found several prints of photographs Wes took of her alone in the backyard and in the loft during her last visit. Michelle blushed just looking at them because they made her feel beautiful. The photos were sexy without even trying. It gave her goosebumps to think this was how Wes really saw her, to know that he wanted her. They were adults and the only thing stopping them from doing anything was Michelle’s willpower, but her strength wasn’t infinite. It was fun to play with Wes like this, but if he really did move on her...

Clicking distracted Michelle from the photographs. She looked up to see Wes moving around her, camera in hand, snapping away. She froze, eyes following him.

“Go back to what you were doing. You don’t have to look at me,” Wes said.

“I didn’t say you could take my picture.”

“Looking like that, you’re begging me to take your picture, Michelle.”

She smiled. She couldn’t help it.

“There you go. Show me that pretty smile.”

Michelle smiled wider and her cheeks flushed.

“Look up, that way, away from me. I like the way the light is behind you.”

She did as instructed, looking up toward the platform where his bed waited. Did her curiosity show? Her pulse quickened and she tried to keep her face neutral.

“Now come here right here, Michelle.”

Wes used his free hand to guide her, and heat flowed from where he touched her. He sat Michelle on the arm of the couch, the light from the big windows catching her profile. The photographs slid from her lap and when she reached for them Michelle fell forward. She reached out and caught herself on the back of the couch. She was stretched out, like she was posing for Wes, and the slit in her dress fell open to flash her legs. He came around her side, going low and high, snapping away. Michelle didn’t move, but let Wes have his way with her—with his camera, at least.

“That’s perfect...so sexy, Michelle. You’re wasting your talents,” Wes encouraged.

“How so?”

“You were born to be in front of the camera. I could shoot you all night.”

“If you try to do that, I’m going to get hangry. Just warning you. A girl needs to eat.” Michelle laughed.

“Then perhaps I should feed you and we can pick this up later.”

“Right,” she replied, drawing the word out.

Wes extended a hand and pulled Michelle upright. She ended up right against him, feeling his body heat. His cologne was intoxicating and masculine. She rested a hand on his ribcage, but just for a moment, before jerking it away. He carried the camera back to his desk and Michelle stood, tugging her dress into place. She was eager to get out of the loft—not because she was starving, but because she didn’t want to be alone with Wes there another moment.

“Shall we?” he asked, holding out a hand toward the door.

As they walked through the Friday night crowds on the street, Michelle wondered if people looked at them as a couple. Wes, tall, dark, handsome. Michelle, slender, tanned, but very much the suburban mom. She couldn’t help seeing herself that way. She was confident in her own environment. She knew she looked good there, but this was not her scene. Did they look like they belonged together? She wanted to think so but being out in public with Wes made her self-conscious. It was a crazy pendulum, but now she wished it were just the two of them again. Wes walked by her side and they constantly touched as the crowds pushed them together. It certainly felt like they were a couple, and when Michelle pushed her insecurities away, it felt good.

They arrived at a little Middle Eastern place around the corner, a doorway so narrow Michelle didn’t see it until Wes pointed it out. He ducked inside and emerged moments later with two small glasses, which were detailed in gold leaf. Michelle took one and the filmy-clear contents smelled sweet and strong. Ice chinked in the glass.

“Our table will be ready in a moment,” Wes said.

“What’s this?” She sniffed it again and crinkled her little button nose.

“A gift from Talib, the owner, while we wait. It’s Arak.”

“It seems strong.”

“Don’t be a baby. Just try it.”

Michelle wanted to be adventurous with Wes, and she sipped the booze. It was sweeter than it smelled, but it was spicy too, tasting of black licorice. It reminded Michelle of ouzo, but it wasn't as thick. She didn't *dislike* it, but she was used to twelve-dollar wine and craft beers, not exotic liquors.

"It's good," she said, unconvincingly.

Wes smiled. His smile made her tingle. "The more of it you drink, the easier it goes down."

Michelle laughed. "You're not getting me drunk tonight. I have to drive home."

"So you said last time. I have plenty of space for you to stay over, you know."

"Haha. Nice try. I don't make it habit to have sleepovers with strange men."

"You don't stay overnight with your fling?"

"Never. It's casual, remember. I get what I need, and I go. At least, that's how it would be if I were doing it." Her eyes sparkled as she sipped her drink and let the words sink in.

Talib came out and fetched them for their table. The restaurant was long, narrow and tiny—although Michelle knew they would call it *cozy*. The left side was split into alcoves, each one divided from the others by tall woven screens. Beads hung across the entrance to each alcove. Talib took them toward the back and held back a curtain of beads to reveal an empty alcove. Michelle stepped in to find a low table with wide cushions arranged around it. She stood, unsure of what to do, but Wes nudged her forward with a hand on the small of her back. It was a quick touch—too quick. She wanted his hand to linger.

"Here, take off your shoes. Come sit," Wes said.

Michelle kicked out of her sandals and held onto his hand while awkwardly stepping across the cushions. The dress didn't make it easy to lower onto a cushion on the floor, but she did her best to be ladylike as she

sat. Michelle was electrified thinking she may have flashed her panties to Wes as she tried to sit. Finding a comfortable position was awkward. She swept her legs out to the side and leaned back against the wall. Wes came around the other side and smoothly sat to her right. The alcove was small, pressing them close together. It was a great, intimate spot for a date, Michelle thought. *It's a shame we're not on a date.*

A decanter sat on a mirror-polished tray, surrounded by little ice-filled glasses. Michelle realized the decanter was filled with Arak. Wes poured them two fresh drinks. "It's traditional to use a fresh glass each time."

"I told you. You are not getting me drunk, mister."

"Just sip, Michelle. It goes very well with the food. There is water, too."

"This is an interesting place. Do you bring all your women here?"

"What makes you ask that? And what makes you think I have all these women?"

Michelle didn't say what she thought. *You're so hot, of course you have your pick of women. You probably get laid whenever you want.* Thinking that of him only made Michelle feel more special. Wes could have his pick and he was spending a Friday night with her. It wasn't right, but the attention of a man like Wes made Michelle feel sexier than her husband ever could. It was a window into why Clay was tempted by Piper, but she was not there to think about her husband.

"You're not going to try to convince me you're celibate like a monk, are you?" she asked, smiling playfully.

"Of course not."

"You don't have trouble getting women, do you?"

"I don't want to brag..."

"That's a yes!"

"But that doesn't mean there's a different woman in my bed every night."

“Just every other?”

Wes shook his head, but he was smiling. “Why is it so important for you to paint me as some kind of gigolo?”

“I didn’t say that.”

“But you really want me to be a manwhore. Why is that, Michelle?”

“Hey, I was asking the questions.”

“I think it’s because you’re attracted to me and it makes it easier for you to dismiss me if I’m just a playboy.”

“Is that right?”

“It is.”

“Would you like to tell me what else I think? It seems to be your favorite pastime.”

Wes fixed her with his deep brown eyes and Michelle felt it down to her core. Her heart trip-hammered in her chest and she was sure he was going to kiss her. She knew she just might let him.

“I don’t think you’re just here to pick up your prints.”

“No?”

“I think you’re here because you want to be—for you. I think you’re ready for that fling you’ve been talking about.”

“Maybe I’m already having one. He could be waiting for me...”

“Is he, Michelle? Is there a man out there who’s rocking your world? Is there a man who’s giving you toe-curling orgasms? Does he make you ache for it...”

Michelle’s mouth hung open, voice deserting her. Each of his words struck like a thunderbolt. She knew she wanted all those things, but not from some hypothetical man. She wanted them from the man right in front of her. Wes *did* know what she was thinking—even the things she couldn’t admit to herself. If he didn’t kiss her, she might kiss him. She closed her mouth and licked her lips...

“Excuse me, I have food. I hope you’re hungry.”

It was a pretty teenage girl coming through the beads, carrying a tray laden with savory and exotic smelling foods. Wes gallantly took the tray from the girl and set it on the table. Michelle sagged back against the wall while Wes and the girl fussed with the food. She trembled. Something was about to happen, she was sure, but she'd been saved by dinner—saved from making a mistake. But was it? Michelle thought of Clay and Piper—again. It was her trump card. She deserved to be as selfish as Clay had been. Why did she have to stay on the high road?

“Thank you,” Wes told the girl, dismissing her.

Michelle took a deep breath and found her voice. “We didn’t even order.”

“You don’t order here. Talib just sends out whatever they’re cooking up back there. I haven’t been disappointed yet. I hope I was right in guessing you’re an adventurous eater.”

“I am. I wish the rest of my family were. Their idea of exotic food is Taco Bell.”

“Then I’m pleased to introduce you to something new, Michelle.”

She just smiled, rather than take the bait.

Wes went into explaining the meal. “This is meze, which is like something of an appetizer sampler. It comes at the beginning of a feast in the Middle East, but here it is the meal since not a lot of people sit for hours long, multi-course meals. Be careful, some of the dishes are spicy.”

“I can handle spicy,” she replied.

The array of foods was almost overwhelming, but Michelle dove in, trying a bit of this, a little of that. There were strong cheeses and spiced lamb, eggplant salad, olives, fava beans in sauce, and fried vegetables and seafood. She particularly liked the stuffed leaves and the tzatziki. Dinner was a good distraction from where they’d been headed before the food arrived, and they didn’t talk much while they ate. She did feel Wes spying

on her though, and Michelle did her best to be dainty and ladylike while she ate. It wasn't so easy with all the finger foods, but she tried.

"You have a little something there," Wes said.

"Where?" she asked, dabbing at her face, but unable to find it.

Wes wiped at her cheek with his thumb, just barely brushing her lips. Michelle fought the urge to kiss his thumb, but his touch was electrifying. "There ya go," he said.

"Thanks."

The dinner was perfect in that it was light, not that Michelle would have stuffed herself in front of Wes. One did not do that on a date—not that this was a date. It was a salty dinner, though, and while she drank a lot of water, she also had more of the arak than she'd planned. It was the perfect complement to the meal. Michelle wasn't drunk—not by a longshot—but she was warm and happy. Wes was charming company, the space was intimate, and the night felt perfect. It was like they were in their own little world, making it too easy for Michelle to pretend it was just the two of them and let all of her other cares fall away. Wes leaned closer and sometime during the meal his arm had slipped behind her. When she leaned back to the wall, Michelle leaned back into him, and it felt right. Rather than pulling away, she pressed into him.

"This is nice. I'm glad I came," she said, not catching the double entendre until it was out of her mouth.

Wes chuckled. "I never get tired of hearing that."

"Very funny." Michelle lightly punched his chest.

"Although I have to admit, I usually get a better reaction than glad."

"Will you stop? You know what I meant!"

"Maybe we should find out if you'll be more than glad."

"You think so?"

Michelle looked up at Wes and the moment between them was perfect. For the second time that evening she felt drawn to him, like gravity was

pulling them together. Their kiss seemed inevitable, but when it came it was still shocking. Her eyes fluttered closed when his lips brushed hers and Michelle leaned into him, pressing her lips tightly to Wes. She reached up, caressing the side of his face, then ran her fingers through the twists of his afro—a stark reminder that it was not her husband she was kissing. The hair wasn't the only difference. Wes had soft, full lips and his kiss was strong, despite Michelle being the aggressor. Once she started kissing him, Michelle couldn't stop. She wanted to devour him.

Wes dropped a hand to her hip and pulled Michelle closer, while his other hand lightly rubbed her back. His big hands on her only inflamed Michelle and she slipped her tongue past his lips. Wes met and dueled her, his strong tongue promising other pleasures. His hand dropped from her hip as she moved closer and found the slit in the side of her dress. His fingers touching her bare leg exhilarated Michelle and felt almost dizzy for a moment.

“We shouldn't be doing this,” she panted, pressing her forehead to his.

“Why not? I want to do this. You want it too.”

“I'm married. It's wrong.”

“Then why are you here? Why are you kissing me?”

Michelle gazed up into his eyes and became lost there. She lamely answered, “I don't know.”

Wes answered with a kiss. This time he was possessive, his arms around her showing Michelle how badly he wanted her. She melted into him. She wanted it too. Michelle was there because she wanted Wes to kiss her. She'd wanted it for weeks. And now that she felt the heat of his kiss, she wanted more.

His hand pressed inside her dress, dragging it up by the slit until he was cupping her ass. She wore a thong to avoid panty lines and his fingers trailed along her bare cheek. She moaned into their kiss. Michelle felt her self-control rapidly deserting her, replaced with burning desire. This time,

she welcomed his tongue into her mouth and dug her nails into his afro as the kiss made her heart pound.

“I need to stop. I need to think clearly,” she breathed, leaning her head on his shoulder. God, it was a muscular, broad shoulder.

“Maybe we should get out of here,” Wes suggested.

“And do what?”

“Come back to my place, Michelle.”

“I...I don't know.”

Wes summoned their waitress and quickly paid the bill. Michelle felt guilty when the girl came into their little alcove. She was flushed from the kiss, and swore the girl looked at her knowingly, judging her to be an adulteress. She self-consciously covered her wedding band with her other hand. Wes rushed her out of the restaurant and took her hand, pulling Michelle down the street. She docilely followed him, mind running a mile a minute. Michelle warred with herself, trying to find a way to reconcile what she wanted with what she knew was right.

They were back at Wes's too soon. Michelle needed more time to decide. He keyed in the code to unlock the front door, but Michelle stood firm when he tried to pull her inside his building. She stared up at him, chewing on her bottom lip, desperately wanting to go inside with him. And yet, something kept her rooted to her spot. Wes stared down at her and she realized he was letting her make up her mind. Of course, he was. A guy like Wes didn't need to drag middle aged women into his loft. If Michelle turned him down, he could probably have another woman there inside the hour. Michelle stared at him, willing him to drag her inside. She needed him to make her. If he did, she would give herself to him.

Wes did not drag her inside his building, but he did come down to the sidewalk and kiss her again. He kissed her hard and locked his arms around her and Michelle dissolved into him, flattening her long body to his powerful frame. The kiss, the full-body contact promised forbidden

pleasures that Michelle was dying for—but she couldn't. That last string of self-control tethering her to reality wouldn't snap.

Michelle pulled away and whispered, "I'm sorry, I just can't."

Before she could change her mind, Michelle turned and fled by the street, tears welling in her eyes. Wes let her go. If he pursued her, she might not have been able to stay strong. She jogged up the street and climbed into her minivan, flinging her purse onto the passenger seat. Tears dripped down her cheeks, half-shame and half-frustration. Michelle wasn't sure if she was angrier with herself for her lack of control, or her lack of selfishness. Clay had given her every reason to indulge herself with Wes, but she couldn't escape her morals. Even when she basically had a free pass, Michelle couldn't allow herself to be the bad girl. She couldn't do the wrong thing. Her hands were locked on the steering wheel and she tried to shake it, biting back a scream. Beneath the shaking and the tears and the angst, Michelle realized she was horny as hell. Just a taste of Wes left her dying for more. That might have been the worst part. She was left all worked up and no way to relieve it.

Michelle sniffed back her tears and sighed in frustration. She had to get out of there before she changed her mind and went running back to Wes. She cranked the key, but the minivan only clicked. She tried again and the clicking slowed. The minivan was not going to start. Michelle slammed a fist onto the steering wheel and cursed.

Good god, she thought. Her torture wouldn't end. She dug through her purse for the AAA card. Of course, she didn't have it. Clay would have their member number, but she was not going to call her husband and tell him she was stranded outside of Wes's loft. She was on her own and she wanted to scream again.

Wes would be glad to help, she was sure. Michelle didn't know if she could face him. She ran away like a scared little girl. She'd never been so embarrassed. Michelle could call one of her girlfriends, have them send

their husband for help, but it seemed unfair to call any of them downtown late on a Friday night. *Wes is right here*, she thought.

Michelle swore the universe was pushing her into Wes's arms.

TWELVE

“DID you realize you forgot the prints?” Wes asked through the intercom.

Michelle cursed under her breath. She’d forgotten all about the portraits, the alleged reason she was there in the first place. In a small voice, she answered, “My car won’t start.”

“Sorry, can’t hear you against the background noise. Just come on up.”

The loud buzz of the door releasing made Michelle jump, and she stared at the handle like it was some alien object. She sucked it up and pulled the door open.

Wes’s door was open and waiting for her when Michelle reached his floor and she charged into his loft, head held high. She wanted to project strength, but the heavy *clunk* of the door sliding closed sounded like her trap snapping shut. The envelope with the prints waited on the counter and she held it up in front of her chest like a shield. Wes followed her and stopped so close she was right back in his gravitational field. Michelle took a step back, but it didn’t help. Her stomach summersaulted with anticipation.

“Is that what you came for?” he asked. “I’m surprised to see you back.”

“My, uh, car won’t start.”

“That’s the only reason you came back?”

“I...yes. Can you help me?”

“I think so. I know exactly what you need, Michelle.”

“Wes...”

“Why did you run away, Michelle?”

“Because...I...” She didn’t want to tell him the truth. She wanted him to see her as a woman, not a silly girl.

“It’s okay, you can tell me. You wanted to be here. I could feel it. Why did you run away?”

“I was scared.” The words escaped her lips as a whisper.

“Scared of what?” Wes touched her face, caressed her cheek. She tilted into his touch, closed her eyes.

“You...me...”

“Scared of what you wanted?”

His thumb touched her lips and she kissed the tip. Michelle’s heart hammered so hard she felt faint. Her entire body felt like a live wire, taut and ready for him. She knew she should run again, but she couldn’t. His touch captivated her.

“Yes,” Michelle gasped.

“Are you still scared, Michelle?”

She nodded, afraid to speak again because her words would betray her.

“You’re not going to run this time, are you?”

She shook her head. Wes tore the envelope from her hands and threw it on the floor, like he was tearing away her normal life so it wouldn’t come between them again. He grabbed Michelle with both hands, one on the small of her back, the other cradling her head, and pulled her to him. Their lips crashed together, and her arms went around Wes. She loved being enveloped in his powerful arms. Being pulled against his big frame drove home that she was cheating. This man was so different from her husband. Clay was handsome, but Wes was the kind of man women dreamed about.

Wes backed her against the island and dropped her into one of the bar-height chairs lining it. He pulled at the thin straps holding up her dress,

stretching them and yanking them off her shoulders. The lacy bralette underneath was virtually see-through and her crimson nipples were plain through it. They kissed frantically as he palmed her breasts, his big hands dragging over her thick nipples, which made Michelle moan into their kiss. She was so aroused, her nipples screamed for attention.

Michelle gasped when his lips drew across her cheek and he nibbled on her ear. Her long chestnut hair was swept aside, and Wes delicately suckled the side of her neck. He went right to that sensitive spot that short circuited her brain and Michelle moaned. She trembled in his arms and dug her nails into his back. He played her body perfectly, like they'd been lovers for years. She wondered if he was just that good or she was just that easy. Michelle clung to Wes like she was starved for his attention, and she realized she was. When was the last time she'd had sex? Touching herself wasn't the same. Long stretches without sex had always been difficult for her.

Wes held her face in both hands, smeared his thumb over her lips, and stared deeply into her eyes. Michelle looked up at him like she was lost, which she was, in way. She had to lose herself to end up in his arms. Her lips moved, but no words came out.

"You're so goddamned beautiful," Wes whispered.

His lips descended on her again. Michelle leaned up at him, grabbing fistfuls of his shirt to pull him to her. His thumbs strummed her nipples and she squirmed in her seat, jolts of pleasure shooting straight from her chest to her sex. She used her grip to pull his shirt over his head, reluctant that they had to break their kiss for even a second.

Wes stepped closer, moving between her legs, which rode her dress up her thighs. He gripped her bare hip with a subtle strength. It was yet another gesture of possession, which made Michelle realize how badly she wanted him to possess her. He groped around her bralette, seeking the clasp. The racer-back lingerie had a front clasp and Michelle thoughtfully popped it

free for him. Wes leaned her back, elbows resting on the island behind her, and feasted on her breasts.

“God...ahh...” Michelle murmured, tightening her fingers in his afro, pulling at the little twists.

Wes was not gentle, but she couldn't say he was rough. He was commanding. Wes wanted her and wasn't holding back. He sucked hard, nearly covering her small breasts, and then drew out her nipples, just reaching the point where it almost hurt. She swooned. Michelle panted as she tried not to scream, but she couldn't help yelping when Wes pinched her other nipple.

“Wes...ahh...god...Wes...”

Her dress was all twisted up and gathered around her, making it all too easy for Wes to slip his hand into the slit and up between her humid thighs. Michelle tensed when he touched her there—a place that was supposed to be reserved for her husband. It was a tension point in their coupling—one that made her pause for at least a moment and realize how wrong this all was. It had been over fifteen years since anyone but Clay had touched her there—and no other man was ever supposed to again—but Wes's fingers brushed her damp lips through her thong and Michelle didn't stop him because she didn't want to. Did Clay have a guilty pause before he touched Piper? She doubted it. Michelle gasped Wes's name and relaxed her thighs.

The scrap of lace that was her thong offered no impediment to Wes. He swept it aside and his fingers pressed between her slippery lips, tracing the length of her sex. He flicked her clit and Michelle moaned into their kiss, her nails digging into his afro. Wes kept his attention there and she tore her mouth from his, resting her forehead on his shoulder while his name slipped gutturally from her lips.

“What? Wes...wait...ohh...I...” Michelle moaned, weakly pulling at Wes.

Wes ignored her, going to his knees in front of the tall chair. He rested a leg over his shoulder while pushing her thighs wider apart and holding her dress out of his way with one hand. Her thong was stretched, biting into her flesh, but Wes needed it out of his way. His tongue, so skillful when they kissed, touched her pussy and Michelle almost jolted out of the chair. Wes explored her slick folds, muscular tongue pressing deep inside and teasing her most intimate places. Michelle trembled in the chair and dug her heel into his shoulder.

“Ohh...ahhh...mmm...Wes...god...”

The more vocal she became, the more aggressive Wes got. He released her dress to keep her thighs pressed open. His thumbs splayed her lips, and his tongue was everywhere. Michelle grabbed her dress as it threatened to cascade over his head. She stared down at his unfamiliar head buried between her thighs, as if she had to see it to believe it was happening. But it was happening. The thrills rocketing through her body were proof of that. His tongue danced on her clit and two thick fingers pressed inside her. His big digits were as thick as her husband’s cock, and Michelle pushed back. Michelle could hear how soaked she was as she thrust at his fingers.

“Yes! Yes!” she cried, leaning back, grabbing the island counter behind her.

Michelle used the leg hooked over his shoulder as leverage, fucking her lover’s mouth and fingers. He’d let her control the pace until then, but when he sucked on her clit, Wes fingered her hard. He played her pussy like it was his instrument and the music of erotic moans poured from her mouth. Michelle stared at the high ceiling, unable to control the moans that echoed through the loft—unable to slow her oncoming orgasm.

“Wes...god...yes! Yes! Oh god! Yes! Oh god yes!” she cried, bucking wildly on the chair.

Her world turned sideways, and Michelle would have slipped from the chair as the throbbing pleasure overtook her entire body, but he kept her in

place. Wes drank deeply of her as she came, which kept her climax going and going. When she thought she might pass out, Michelle pushed him away, but Wes didn't go far. He stood and kissed her. Michelle's juices covered his face and she thrilled at tasting herself on him. Michelle kissed him so hard it was like she was trying to climb inside him. God, she wanted all of him. That kiss was her entire world until she felt something thick and blunt pressing to her sex.

"Wes...I...babe..."

"You fucking want it. Don't lie to me. Don't lie to yourself," he groaned, nudging forward.

His fat head split her lips, promising deeper pleasures. She had no idea when he took his cock out. Michelle was panicked, but in her core, she wanted it. It took all she had to keep from pushing forward and drawing him into her.

"But...Wes...I'm..." Her words melted to a moan when he pushed deeper. Wes was barely inside her and Michelle was stretched open. He was so *thick*. It was just like her toy at home. Her resistance weakened. "Wes... I'm married..."

"You're married, Michelle, and you want to fuck me," Wes stated.

Wes covered her mouth with his and pressed. Michelle half-kissed him and half-cried out. She reached between them and grabbed for him. She had to know what he had. She was already so open, but she knew he was barely inside her. Her fingers could hardly close around him, confirming the truth. Wes was huge. Her grip prevented him from pressing deeper, but he didn't cede any ground. Wes slowly rocked half his cock in and out of her and Michelle slowly lost her mind. He didn't make her do anything. Wes had been right. Michelle wanted him. She wanted him so badly she might have begged under other circumstances, but she couldn't quite silence that little voice in the back of her mind—the voice that shouted this was wrong. The voice shouted that it didn't matter how good it felt. She should not be

fucking Wes. But god she wanted to! He only slowly rocked his cock in and out of her and she was building to another intense orgasm. Michelle was almost embarrassed by how easily Wes made her come, but she doubted she was the first woman with that reaction.

“Ahh...ahh...ahh...god!” she cried, her second climax not quite as powerful as when he went down on her.

It was coming on his cock that weirdly strengthened her resolve. Even as she moaned with pleasure, Michelle pushed on his chest and shook her head. Wes was a gentleman, of course. When Michelle pushed him away, he stopped, his cock slipping from her sex with a wet plop. She drew in on herself on the chair, trembling. She’d never felt so out of control. She closed her eyes and tried to calm her breathing and still herself. Time seemed to stop, and she didn’t know how long it took to come back to herself, but when she opened her eyes, only moments seemed to have passed. Wes still stood in front of her, his slick cock standing out in front of him.

Michelle stared at his cock. It was her first good look at it, and she couldn’t help herself. She didn’t like to think in stereotypes—it wasn’t good for a teacher—but Wes was black, and he was big. She’d been with a really big guy back in college—a member of the baseball team—and he was a white guy. Sex with the college boyfriend hurt if he didn’t take his time, but even when it did Michelle usually came anyway. The sense of being so filled was overwhelming. She stared at Wes’s prick and thought about how much he’d fill her if she took all of him. Even if it hurt, she wouldn’t care, but Michelle suspected he was an expert with that piece of meat. He’d only make her feel good.

Wes pulsed with his heartbeat and Michelle gasped when she saw his cock jump like that. She could not let him fuck her, but she realized how inherently unfair it was to leave him like this. He’d made her come three or four times. Michelle couldn’t refuse him.

“I can’t fuck you,” she said, forcing her eyes away from his cock to meet his. “I want to, but I can’t. I’m sorry.”

“You have nothing to apologize for, Michelle. I know you don’t do this every day. I don’t want you to feel pushed, baby.”

The sincere answer made Michelle want him even more. She almost pushed him back to the couch and attacked him.

“I didn’t do anything I didn’t want to.”

“I know.” Wes smirked.

“Come here,” she said, slipping off the chair.

Her dress fell around her, covering her nudity like nothing had happened. Michelle boldly grasped his cock and led Wes the short distance to the sitting area. She sat on the couch, but he remained standing in front of her. Michelle added a second hand and stared up at him while stroking his shaft. He was slick with her juices, making her hands glide up and down him.

“You like that big dick, don’t you, Michelle?”

She smiled.

“I can see it in your eyes. You want it. Why are you holding back, baby?”

“Because I know how to control myself. I’m not ruled by my privates.”

“Even after you felt it?”

Michelle had *barely* controlled herself, but she was not going to tell him that. Wes didn’t need to know that if he’d given her one good thrust, she would have been his. She’d probably still be bouncing on his cock. Michelle doubted he was quick. *Clay’s been so quick lately*, she thought.

“Don’t make this harder, Wes,” she groaned, thinking of him inside her. She looked down to his cock, inches from her face, the tip dripping with pre-cum. Two hands together didn’t cover his length. Wes would absolutely skewer her. Her pussy tingled, like she could still feel him inside her. It would be so easy...

“I’m being good, aren’t I?” she pleaded.

“Shit, momma, you are fucking good. Your hands...” Wes moaned deeply and flexed his hips, pushing closer to her face.

“Come on, babe. I want to make you feel good. I want to make you happy,” she cooed.

“Feels fucking great, Michelle. But I know you want to taste it. Just give it a little kiss, baby. That will make me so happy.”

Michelle knew she was being silly, like a high school girl trying to keep her honor intact. She knew her arbitrary lines were ridiculous. Wes had been inside her. He started fucking her! She hadn’t saved a thing, but she stopped him and that meant something—at least it did to her. It was some kind of moral victory. And she was sorely tempted to suck Wes off. He wasn’t looking for a handjob, but again it felt right to keep his cock out of her. If he was in her mouth, it was just a short hop to fucking her again, wasn’t it? The pretzel logic made her smile as she jerked his prick.

“Wes,” she whined. “Don’t make me, babe.”

Michelle knew how it sounded as soon as it left her mouth, and so did Wes. He took half a step forward and his tip bobbed against her lips, leaving a string of pre-cum dangling. She instinctively licked her lips, tasting the salty nectar and Wes pressed forward again. Her lips parted wider, and she kissed the tip. Kissing quickly turned to sucking and she closed her eyes as she nursed at the head of cock. She swirled her tongue around him and hummed slightly as she sucked, a trick Violet had told her about once. She’d never tried it with Clay, but from the way Wes moaned it was a winner.

“Shit, Michelle. That’s hot, baby. You’re hungry for that dick,” Wes moaned.

Wes pressed and more of his cock slipped into her mouth. Michelle wouldn’t have said she was *hungry for that dick*, but Wes was right. She *wanted* to suck him. She *wanted* to please him. Clay put his cock in her

mouth during his kinky games, but Michelle couldn't remember the last time she'd just dropped to her knees and blown him. Maybe Wes was right, because she didn't hunger for her husband's cock the way she did for his.

"Come on, Michelle, suck it. Nice and hard, just like that. Uhn, fuck, hot momma, that's it."

Michelle did suck him hard, but she kept most of him out of her mouth, resisting his pressure to take more. Blowing him still felt wrong, and while she wanted to do it, she resisted. She still stroked his shaft with both hands, but she dropped one to his balls. She wanted to make him come—and quickly. If she drained his balls Michelle could get out of the danger zone. She massaged his balls and extended a finger to tickle his taint with a nail.

"Oh fuck...oh fuck...fuck Michelle...aww shit...gonna come...gonna come baby...get ready..."

He was warning her, but she didn't take him out of her mouth. It wasn't enough warning. The first powerful blast hit the back of her throat, and unprepared, Michelle gagged on it. She reflexively pulled him from her mouth and another shot blasted her lips and dripped from her chin. He shot again and again, catching her across the cheek and into her hair. Michelle kept jerking his prick with her eyes closed, squeezing until he was finished. His load was huge, coating her cheek, her nose, her lips. She was not prepared for that. Her eyes blinked open and she looked up at him. Wes smiled down at her, proud of his handiwork. Was that a thing for him, coming all over a woman's face? Michelle knew she was a mess. Had she ever taken a load to the face like that? She didn't mind—not really. It felt slutty, which fit the situation. But she also thought she must look ridiculous, a middle-aged married woman sitting on some strange man's couch with cum all over her face.

Michelle couldn't help herself. She burst out laughing. She laughed so hard she snorted, almost sucking come into her nose.

"What's so funny?" Wes asked, chuckling along.

“This. Me. God, what a cliché! I hate being a cliché!”

“You’re anything but a cliché, Michelle. You’re sexy as hell. I want to throw you over my shoulder and carry you up to my bed.”

She kept laughing but tried to catch her breath. “But you can’t.”

“I know. You’re not ready—yet.”

“Don’t I look ridiculous?”

“Momma, you’re the sexiest thing I’ve ever seen.”

“But you’re not going to kiss me, are you?” She paused laughing to challenge him with her crooked grin.

Wes laughed now, loud and hearty. “Not this second, no.”

“I am going to go clean up now.”

“The bathroom is down the hall,” he replied, gesturing.

Michelle took a moment to admire his large clawfoot tub before turning to the mirror to face herself. *Wow, I’m a mess!* she thought. It looked like someone had melted candle wax all over her face. She used a washcloth to scrub her face clean and reapplied her make-up. Michelle only had her usual, natural look make-up—not the more dramatic *date make-up* she’d worn for Wes—but she was not going to face Wes make-up free. She couldn’t do much with what he shot into her hair. It was too long for her to try and wet it, so she used the washcloth to clean up the best she could and pulled it back into a long ponytail with a scrunchie from her purse. The woman looking back at her when she finished looked much more like the suburban mom she was than when she’d arrived. Seeing her everyday self in the mirror expanded the pit of guilt in her stomach and she knew she had to get out of there. Michelle would put on a confident, calm front for Wes. She wasn’t not going to go running away from him like a scared girl again. She found mouthwash under the sink and gargled.

“I did the best I could. How is it?” she asked, emerging from the bathroom.

“You’re even more beautiful than before. You look better without make-up.”

Michelle laughed. “Oh, I’m wearing make-up.”

“You’re perfect either way.”

Wes pulled her to him, and she stiffened, until he kissed her, melting her once again. Wes was dangerous because Michelle just couldn’t resist him.

“I really need to go, if you can get my car started. It’s late,” she said, brushing her lips away from his, but pressing her cheek to him.

“If I let you go, will I see you again?”

“I don’t know. It’s complicated, you know that.”

“I know. I guess I’m at your mercy, Michelle.”

“Don’t put it that way,” she replied, knowing it was really the other way around.

“I am.”

“Let me go home, Wes. Please.”

“Of course.”

Michelle knew what was implied in her words and was relieved when Wes let her go instead of dragging her to his bed, but his restraint only made her want him more. She staggered when he let her go and hunted for his keys.

They made a stop at his truck, where he produced a jump box. Michelle’s dead battery was brought back to life and Wes closed the hood. They stood beside the minivan staring at each other, until Wes finally spoke.

“I guess I’ll wait for your call.”

“Don’t wait on me, please. My life is too crazy. I don’t know what I’m going to do.”

“It’s my choice, and I think you’re worth waiting for, Michelle.”

“Okay.”

Michelle acted on impulse and lunged at him, kissing Wes deeply right there on the street, then retreated to her minivan without looking back.

THIRTEEN

CONFUSION WAS THE NEW NORMAL. Michelle's thoughts and emotions whipsawed from one extreme to the other, almost minute by minute. It was no way to exist, but that was where she found herself the day after her assignation with Wes. If her brain lingered on it, the guilt would gnaw away at her, like a squirrel consuming a peanut until only remnants of the shell remained. She felt like a hollowed-out shell when she let the guilt sweep through her. Fifteen years of marriage, a life she'd built with her husband, all thrown away because she couldn't control herself around a sexy stranger. When the guilt occupied her, Clay's transgressions no longer mattered. His poor behavior didn't excuse her own. But the guilt only held sway for so long. The guilt eventually receded like the low tide and the high tide swept in, knocking Michelle over with its force and ferocity. Wes flooded into her brain, and it was all-consuming.

Wes was like her heroin, because after that one evening she was addicted. Words failed when she tried to understand the hold the handsome black photographer had over her. Michelle was a rational, professional woman. It didn't make sense that just one encounter—one night of crossing lines—had her so jumbled up. Wes was handsome and interesting, but he was still just a man. She barely knew him. He'd made her feel good, but that didn't explain the hold he seemed to have over her now. Michelle did

not want to think that she was so weak that a night of fooling around on her husband had broken her. But what a night it was! Her eyes closed and she recalled those lips. God, those lips!

His kiss took her breath away and she knew it would only lead to trouble. She felt that kiss all the way down to her core. The kiss promised deeper pleasures, and it wasn't a lie. Michelle thought his lips felt magical on hers, but when he deployed them lower—when Wes kissed her pussy—he took control of Michelle in a way no man ever had. She'd never had such a reaction to a man—not even her husband. It was like Wes had been chosen for her.

Michelle knew she was lucky to escape his place without fucking him. She'd let him inside her, and even if it was only a bit, it was so wrong. Michelle had not so much as kissed another man in almost twenty years, let alone do that to her. She'd never come close. It was never even a consideration—until Wes came along. And now she had to deal with what she'd done.

The worst part was that even when her guilt reigned, her deep-seated need for Wes didn't leave. It may have even been stronger, as the sheer wrongness of being with him tapped into some deep, dark part of her Michelle hadn't been aware she had. If she allowed herself, she was right back there in Wes's place, his hands on her body, his face between her thighs, drinking of her. She almost felt his thick cock filling her hands—yes, *hands*, she needed both—and how much she wanted to do more than just hold it. She wanted Wes inside her, filling her. Michelle was in a near constant state of arousal as her brain filled with daydreams of Wes bedding her.

Violet texted several times, digging for details on her night with Wes. After those went unanswered, Violet called, but Michelle dodged that too. It was only when Michelle felt like a pressure cooker about to explode that

she finally reached out to Violet. She had to talk to someone. Putting it all out there might help her get her head straight.

The women sat together in Michelle's backyard, wine glasses in hand. It was dusk and the worst of the day's heat was dissipating, but the thick humidity still hung in the air and a fine sheen of perspiration clung to Michelle's dewy skin. Her long chestnut hair was up in a ponytail to keep it off her neck. Violet seemed fine with the heat, despite wearing more than Michelle's cami top and little shorts. Both women were reclined in Adirondack chairs and Michelle stretched her long legs out to scrunch her toes in the grass. A symphony of insects skittered around them.

"The other girls couldn't come out on a weeknight?" Violet asked.

Michelle considered inviting the rest of their group over, but she couldn't have the conversation she wanted in front of the others. Eva might get a kick out of her story, but Sarah would be scandalized. Sarah would never look at Michelle the same way again if she knew what happened with Wes, and Michelle feared gossip would spread.

"They probably can't, but I didn't even ask. That's not terrible, is it?"

"It's your house, 'Chelle. Invite who you want."

"I'm a little out of sorts. I don't think I'm up to a party."

Violet snorted. "I don't think you could call it a party when we hang out. Anyway, I can tell something's up. You look like you're about to jump out of your skin. This is about your hunky photographer, isn't it?"

Michelle's cheeks burned, answering the question for her. "I saw him that night."

"And?"

"And..."

"Am I going to have to drag this out of you, hon?"

"It's just...god...I can't believe I...we...shit, where do I start?"

"Did you fuck him?" That was Violet. Right to the point.

“No!” Michelle’s eyes darted away, and she drank more wine. “Not really.”

“Chelle, there’s no *not really* about fucking. You did or you didn’t. It’s like being a little bit pregnant.”

“He...uh...” Michele sighed. She had to just push it all out. “Okay, so I went to his place to pick up the prints.”

“Just to pick up the prints?”

Michelle allowed a smile. “Yeah, sure. He looked *good*, Vi. I mean, like, *really good*.” She had more wine. It was helping. “He started in on me right away. He’s so smooth. I swear it’s like Wes has my instruction manual because he was pushing all my buttons like he’d known me forever. He had my mind filled with dirty thoughts the second I got in there. I knew I should grab the prints and go.”

“But you didn’t.”

“I didn’t. I let him take me to dinner.”

“That sounds mostly safe.”

“It was this cool little Middle Eastern place. Clay and I used to love to discover those kinds of out-of-the-way spots when we would go into the city before the boys.” She was paused by a pang of guilt at the memory of better times with her husband.

“Wes didn’t throw you down on the table, did he? He had to behave in public, or didn’t he? You’re killing me dragging this out, Chelle.”

“It was tiny and intimate, and we were really close together. The waitress brought us this weird, thick, sweet drink. I think it was pretty strong.”

“He got you drunk?” Violet sounded concerned.

“No, I’m a big girl. I know how to take care of myself. But I probably had too much. I had enough that I was feeling good, if you know what I mean?”

Violet grinned. “Oh, I know what you mean. I’m sure that made everything easier.”

“You have no idea,” Michelle replied. She would have loved to have blamed the booze for her behavior that night, but it was all her. Blaming getting drunk for your behavior was for college kids. Michelle was a grown-ass-woman and had to take responsibility for her actions.

“You went back to his place,” Violet prompted.

“We kissed at the restaurant. I don’t really remember who kissed who. It was more like we just came together, and it happened.”

Michelle gulped her wine and stared at Violet searching for a reaction. Her friend looked genuinely surprised for a moment, like she couldn’t believe Michelle really had it in her. Surprise gradually turned to a wide, approving smile. Violet sipped her own wine and looked like she was going to high five Michelle.

“You go girl! Good for you! That is exactly what you needed after all the shit Clay’s pulled.”

Michelle turned deeper crimson as she spoke. “It was like a spark to a wildfire, Vi. We kissed and then we were making out like horny teenagers. He kissed me and I just wanted him! Oh my god! I’m such a cliché.”

“You are not a cliché, ‘Chelle. You’re a hot momma who goes for what she wants. That’s who you are.”

“It’s terrible. The waitress came back and caught us. That was embarrassing.”

“It is not terrible. It’s awesome. Is that when you went back to his place?”

Michelle laughed. It was cathartic. “I did not just run up to his place and fuck him, if that’s what you’re thinking. I actually pulled myself together and told him goodnight without going back up there.”

“Good for you, I guess. I mean, I wouldn’t be this freaked out by one kiss, or making out with a guy, but I’m not you. The way you were

acting...”

“It wasn’t just the kiss—or kisses.”

“You little slut! You went back for more!” Violet raised her glass for a toast and Michelle reluctantly clinked it.

“Not my fault!” Michelle protested. “It’s like the universe was pushing me to him. I went back to the car and the battery was dead.”

“Shut up! It’s just like a movie!”

“I know! Isn’t that crazy? I freaked out, because I knew what would happen if I went back to Wes’s, but I didn’t want to call Clay and I didn’t know who else to call.”

“There are people you could have called, hon. You *wanted* to go back up there. The universe sent you a message and you got it loud and clear.”

Michelle didn’t want to admit that was true, but it was. She felt Wes’s gravitational pull all the way from her family minivan that night. Her morals were screaming *NO!* but her body knew what it wanted. Even sitting there with Violet, she felt the pull. Michelle was almost tipsy enough to call Wes and invite him over, too. She had a wild thought about sharing him with Violet and blowing his mind with two crazy MILFs. Michelle would never do that, though. She did not want to share, and she was afraid her wilder friend would show her up. No, if she was going to have Wes, she’d have him all to herself—not that she would be having Wes.

“I went to his place to ask for a jump,” Michelle said.

“I bet you did!” Violet shouted.

“You’re as bad as a guy!”

“I bet your minivan wasn’t the only thing that boy jumped!” Violet cackled, cracking herself up. Michelle used the pause to top off their glasses.

“He was not surprised to see me back. It was like he knew. That made me a little mad. He’s got this annoying habit of acting like he has me all figured out.”

“It sounds like he does but sounds like you’re kinda transparent around him.”

“Oh, stop it. Anyway, he’s waiting at the door and he brings me into his place—he’s got this great industrial loft space—and he started kissing me. Kissing turned to other things...”

Violet gave her a stern look. “You are not going to hold out on me, ‘Chelle. I want details. You said you didn’t fuck him—*not really*—so what happened?”

Michelle took a deep breath, expelled it, and braced herself. She leaned closer to Violet and whispered, as if there was anyone there to overhear. “He went down on me, Vi. He’s got these bar-height chairs and he sat me down and...he went down on me.”

“Yes! That’s what I’m talking about. A boy who knows to take care of business first. He’s a keeper, ‘Chelle!”

“I have someone. Stop it!”

“Was he good?”

The smile came unbidden. She got the tingles everywhere. Michelle could almost feel his tongue teasing her clit. “Oh my god, Vi. You have no idea. It’s been so long since a man... I don’t know if anyone’s done it like that.”

Violet forced her to toast again. “I am now officially jealous. You’re married and you’re having better sex than I am. That’s not right.”

“It wasn’t sex.”

“Whatever.” Violet rolled her eyes.

“And he’s not my husband.”

“All the better, with how Clay’s been acting.”

“Don’t remind me about that.”

“So, is this the *not really fucking* part, hon. Because, I know you know the difference. That boy may be good, but it’s not fucking.”

“No, after he made me...after I *finished*...”

“You came, ‘Chelle. You can say it. The stud photographer took you up to his place and he made you come. Say it! Be proud!”

“Okay, he made me come! Wes made me come! God, did me make me come!”

The women collapsed into a fit of giggles like they were schoolgirls. It was just the tension break Michelle needed. She didn’t have to think about what came next—what she almost did—what she *wanted* to do.

“And after you came? I hope you didn’t leave him hanging, or maybe you did, which would be pretty fucking cool.”

The levity left Michelle as she faced the guilt of her infidelity. She had to confess it. “It happened so fast, Vi. I still don’t know how. It’s like his pants disappeared and he was between my legs and then he was inside me.”

“You *did* fuck him! You little slut!”

“No, I stopped him. He started, but I stopped him.”

“Oh, you’re a little tease,” Violet scolded, turning on her.

“Don’t say that,” Michelle complained, knowing it was true. She felt like she did tease Wes. She shouldn’t have stopped him. She hadn’t *wanted* to stop him. But she had too, didn’t she?

“Okay, you’re not a tease, but how the hell did you stop him? I get going and it’s like a train, hon. It’s going down the track.”

“I just couldn’t. You know, I couldn’t.”

Violet patted her arm. “I get it, hon. Seriously, I admire you. You were strong enough to stop yourself from doing something you’d regret. You weren’t ready and you stood up for yourself.”

“You make it sound like I’m a virgin.”

“Or was he a letdown? Big, handsome guys aren’t always big everywhere.”

Michelle laughed. She couldn’t help herself. “He was *not* a letdown. Oh no, far from it, Vi.”

“Really?” Violet drew the word out. “Now I really do admire you.”

“You should!”

Michelle laughed, hoping Violet couldn’t read her face as she thought about what Wes had. He was the literal opposite of a letdown. He was as perfect as if he’d been chiseled from ebony stone. Michelle squeezed her thighs together as her sex tightened and she thought about how Wes felt inside her. It was exactly the thing she’d been trying so hard to *not* think about these last few days, because when she did Michelle ached for him. If she thought about it too much, she was sure she would call him—see him.

“I didn’t leave him hanging,” Michelle went on. “I’m not that much of a bitch.”

Violet mimed giving a blowjob, forming an O with her lips and pumping her hand.

“I tried not to, but yeah.”

“Tried not to.” Violet laughed. “It just fell in your mouth? You wanted to, and you did it. And it felt good, didn’t it?”

Michelle grinned. “I did, and it did. It was dirty and wrong, and it was hot.”

“You should have just fucked him, ‘Chelle.”

“What? No!”

“You do you, but these lines we draw for ourselves are silly, like we’re playing kids’ games. The boy was *inside you*, hon. He may have taken it out, but he put it in you. *He fucked you*, Michelle. He fucked you, and you liked it, liked it so much you sucked his dick, but you thought you got off the hook because you only let him put in it a little bit. That’s high school shit, hon. I’m not judging you. I’m just saying, if you’re going to carry the guilt, you might as well get all the pleasure. Now you’re just left thinking about what it would have been like, aren’t you?”

Violet stared at her, compelling an answer.

“Maybe,” Michelle conceded. When her friend put it that way, she felt silly, but Michelle needed to believe she’d done something positive when

she stopped Wes. If not...

“You going to see him again?”

“God, no! Why would I?”

The staring continued.

“I can’t. I shouldn’t. I dodged it once.”

“Like his dick is a speeding bullet and you’re Keanu.”

“What does it say about me if I call Wes and see him again?”

“It says your husband is a cheating sonofabitch and you’re taking care of yourself. I know you’re a good girl, ‘Chelle. I know you’re all about doing the right thing, but you can’t be the only one doing it.”

“I don’t *know* he’s cheating.”

“You’ve got to take care of yourself, because if you don’t, you’re going to feel like a fool for missing your chance when the truth comes out.”

“You don’t know what Clay did or didn’t do,” Michelle protested, knowing it sounded weak.

“You’re going to feel like a fool, hon. Do not throw away your shot. Call the boy.”

“Vi...”

Violet grabbed for Michelle’s phone, which sat on the arm of her chair. Michelle scrambled to keep it, just snatching it away from her friend.

“Call him. Text him. I’ll do it if you’re chicken. He won’t know the difference.”

“Vi, I can’t. I shouldn’t.”

“Do it.”

Michelle stared at her friend, at war with herself. Violet was the devil on her shoulder, and the devil was winning. It really wasn’t so hard to push her to doing the thing she really wanted to do. Michelle didn’t know if she could resist—because she didn’t want to.

FOURTEEN

SHE DIDN'T RESIST. Michelle started simple because she didn't know what to say. Her experience pursuing boys was scant. Pretty and athletic, there were always enough boys after her that Michelle never had to go after a guy who caught her interest. They always came to her. She never made the first phone call. Interaction with boys had always been an easy, breezy experience for her. Michelle never had to think much about it. If she'd been more conceited, all that attention would have gone to her head, but she was raised to be humble and she never resorted to using her looks as a weapon.

[Michelle] *hi*

The reply didn't come for a couple hours, leaving ample time for her to think she'd made a mistake and wishing she could recall the text. It was like she was waiting for a jury to come back and deliver her sentence. Not that she needed it. Michelle knew she was guilty. Her hand shot out for the phone when it chirped with a new text, knocking it to the grass, and she almost fell out of the hammock retrieving it. Michelle struggled to maintain her cool, as if Wes could see her through the phone.

[Wes] *Wondering when I'd hear from u*

She bristled that he said *when* and not *if*. He thought he had her all figured out.

[Michelle] *So sure you would?*

[Wes] *Thought I would. Was pretty sure*

[Michelle] *Glad I didn't disappoint you*

[Wes] *I'm sure u never disappoint*

[Michelle] *Haha. Ask my mother about that*

[Wes] *what's up Michelle?*

That caught her off guard. She didn't have a plan and didn't know what to say, expecting Wes to do the heavy lifting for her. Every reply that came to mind sounded lame.

[Michelle] *Just wondering what you're up to*

[Wes] *Getting my gear together to shoot a wedding*

[Michelle] *that sounds fun*

That sounds fun? Michelle thought. She wanted to slap herself for sounding like an insipid, infatuated girl.

[Wes] *Want to come?*

[Michelle] *to your work?*

[Wes] *I could use a hand. My usual assistant backed out at the last minute. It'll be fun. When's the last time u were at a wedding?*

[Michelle] *It's been years. I don't know anything about photography*

[Wes] *It's mostly holding and carrying stuff. I'll even pay u*

A shiver went through her. If the night went as she feared and hoped, it would be like he was paying her for sex. That was so wrong, so why did it give her such a perverse thrill? The good angel on her shoulder urged Michelle to stop the conversation and take out her frustration on one of those toys in the bedroom closet. That was the safest course. But Violet was still the devil on her other shoulder—wearing a slutty, sequined red dress in her imagination—telling her to go for it. Michelle's hands shook so badly when she texted her response that she had to retype the simple words three times.

[Michelle] *Okay*

[Wes] *Great. Can u be at Woodfield Country Club by 4*

Michelle had to search for it on her phone. It was doable.

[Michelle] *Ok*

She decided that sounded too timid and added: *I'll be there.*

[Wes] *Wear all black. Can't wait to see u momma*

Michelle didn't reply. She was too fixated that a man other than her husband had called her *baby*.



The Woodfield Country Club was just about the fanciest place Michelle had ever seen. She was hardly a country rube, but this was rarified air for her. Her first encounter with the place was when a smartly uniformed guard directed her to back up her twelve-year-old minivan and circle around to the service entrance. The driver of the sleek little Mercedes that had to back out of her way shot her an annoyed look when she passed. He knew she didn't belong there.

The heavy sliding gate at the service entrance a half-mile away was far less grand than the tall, gilded wrought-iron gates of the main entrance. The same guard spoke to Michelle through an intercom—she recognized his voice—and buzzed the gate open once she re-explained the reason for her presence. She followed the narrow road and turned off to the left to find a small, unpaved parking lot obscured from view by trees. Her minivan was much more at home among the Chevys, Toyotas and Kias parked there than it would have been with the silver sports coupe she'd encountered at the main gate.

Her makeup was fine when Michelle flipped down the visor and opened the lighted mirror, but she still touched up her crimson lipstick. Her long, chestnut hair was pulled up and pinned back by a wide hair clip. She hoped it looked cute.

A sweet kitchen worker understood her broken Spanish enough to direct her to the catering manager, who directed her out to the veranda off the back of the clubhouse. Calling the building a clubhouse felt like a bit of an understatement, like calling Notre Dame just a church. It was a huge, luxurious mansion, and Michelle suspected that any of the art lined up on the wood paneled walls was worth more than her minivan and Clay's Jeep combined. The opulent, alien surroundings only added to her disorientation as she navigated the maze of hallways to find her way out to the veranda. Michelle felt like an actress on a movie set. *I do not belong here*, she told herself. The urge to turn back grew stronger as she came closer to that veranda, but she persisted. She admitted to Wes that she was frightened once. She would not do it again. She would see this through, whatever happened.

Wes was not on the veranda, but in a service room just off a large ballroom. He faced away from the door when Michelle came in and she had a moment to appreciate just how great his ass looked in his tight black slacks. The black shirt hugged his shoulders too, and he looked more like a linebacker from behind than a photographer and an artist. He was bent over, unpacking and examining his equipment. She left him to it and admired him, feeling her pulse quickening. The intensity of her desire to lock the door behind her and pounce on the photographer was unnerving. Michelle cleared her throat to alert him of her presence before she gave into her carnal desires.

"Nice to see you, Michelle," he said. His broad smile gave her all the feels.

"Why do you look surprised? You asked me here. You didn't think I'd show?"

"I wasn't sure and I'm glad you did."

"I said I'd come. I always keep my word."

Michelle remained by the door, keeping her distance as a precaution. The temptation to run into his arms was powerful. Wes closed the distance, nakedly appraising her as he came at her. His gaze climbed up her long legs, up her slender body, and over her freckled cheeks to settle on her eyes. His smirk said he knew she liked the attention. It was true. Her black blouse was tight, filled out by her push-up enhanced boobs, and a snug black skirt hugged her ass, falling several inches above her knees. Although she knew she'd be on her feet all night, Michelle chose heels anyway. They made her the perfect kissing height when Wes stopped in front of her.

"Good to know. I admire that in a woman," he said, brushing away a stray lock of hair from her cheek. The slight touch scorched her cheek. "Damn, you're beautiful, Michelle."

Her lips were suddenly dry, and she licked them. Michelle wanted him to kiss her. The wedding was a pretense, but she was past pretending she was there for any reason other than to see Wes. Her heart pounded so hard she felt woozy, and Michelle was sure the kiss was going to happen. Her eyes began to flutter closed when he turned and walked back to his equipment. Michelle stumbled, like that soft, strong finger on her cheek had been holding her up.

"I'm assuming you know your way around cameras and such from your modelling days," he said, lifting a camera from a case.

"Uh, yeah, that was a long time ago, but I know a little." The words tumbled from her mouth as her cheeks flashed crimson. It felt like Wes was toying with her, and she didn't like it. She felt foolish. But she would not show him. Michelle straightened her shoulders and walked over to him.

"I'm sure it will all come back to you. I have a videographer here too, so that end is covered, but I might ask you to go around with her and interview guests and get them to wish the couple well. Are you good with that? You're not the shy type, are you Michelle?"

She quirked a smile, forcing a confidence she didn't quite feel. "I can handle anything you throw at me, Wes."

He smiled too, and it made her tingly all over. "We'll see about that."

Wes explained the ceremony would be on the veranda at sunset and they would have to discreetly move around to get the best angles. He wanted Michelle to take up a camera for that. She assured him she could handle it. Painting gave her a good eye for composition. During the reception, she'd mostly serve as his assistant, performing whatever tasks he had for her. If she felt bolder, Michelle would have told him she was ready to tackle all his needs, but instead she simply smiled as she thought it.

They carried equipment out to the veranda and Wes introduced her to Jewel, the videographer. The redhead was a couple inches shorter than Michelle. Jewel was professional, but Michelle caught a vibe between Jewel and Wes—despite Jewel's wedding ring—and it piqued her jealousy. The women were left to chat while Wes went off to coordinate with the wedding planner.

"Where's Aya?" Jewel asked, checking a camera. There were two at set positions on tripods on the veranda.

"Who's Aya?"

"His usual girl. At least, the latest one."

"His assistants don't last?"

"Wes seems to go through them pretty quickly. You know what I mean."

Michelle did, but didn't want to think about it. She wasn't surprised if Wes's usual assistants were pretty, young women, and somehow it didn't shock her that he slept with them. She wasn't under any illusions that Wes wasn't a player. "I don't really know Wes that well," she conceded. "We've only really just met. He took some portraits for me."

Jewel gave her the once over and smiled knowingly. "He's good at that. His boudoir stuff is incredible. I bet you looked great."

“It was family portraits,” Michelle defensively replied.

“He’s good at that, too.”

Michelle noted her wedding ring. “Has he done yours?”

“He’s taken photos of me. Of us.”

“How do you know Wes?”

“We met in an online group. He’s quite the charmer. Wes knows how to get what he wants. It just so happened our professional interests aligned, and we began working together.”

“Oh?” Michelle had so many questions but was not about to pry with a total stranger.

“I guess your husband is home holding down the fort?” Jewel asked.

Michelle self-consciously fingered her wedding band. “He’s away. The kids are away too—at camp.”

“That works. You don’t have to rush home tonight. My husband is home with the kid, but he’s happy for me to be out. Is your husband the jealous, possessive type?”

“He, uh, no. Not really.”

The questions threw Michelle off-balance. She was sure Jewel was getting at something, but Michelle was not about to go there—not with a woman she hardly knew, and not on the subject of Wes. Her stomach had that flip-floppy guilty feeling, like she’d been caught with her hand in the cookie jar. She wanted to shift the focus of the conversation off herself.

“Is your husband jealous? Does he mind you out working with Wes?”

Jewel laughed. “You mean because he’s so hot?”

“I didn’t...”

“It’s okay, honey. It’s just us girls here, and neither of us is blind. We both know Wes is sex on a stick, right?”

Michelle looked down and smiled. “Well, yeah, he is good-looking.”

“Wes is a stone-cold hunk, and you know it. You’re not one of those uptight types, are you?”

“No, of course not. Okay, yes, Wes is hot.” Michelle was oddly relieved to admit it. She wasn’t about to open up to this virtual stranger, but it was good to talk to someone who understood what she felt. “He is really fucking hot, isn’t he?” she whispered conspiratorially.

“Yeah, honey, he is *really* fucking hot. And he’s smart, and he’s smooth as silk. Almost too smooth. He’s like the perfect package, but like silk he slips away so easily.”

Michelle had more than a vibe now. She was *sure* Jewel had slept with Wes—despite her wedding ring. Or maybe because of it. Maybe Wes had a type. She wished she had the nerve to press Jewel for answers.

“But to answer your question, no Charlie doesn’t mind I’m out with Wes. He encourages me. He used to practically push me out the door. He’s a big fan of Wes’s.”

“Do you mean...”

“You seem to understand. Is your guy the same way?”

“Clay, uh, he’s, like I said, he’s out of town.”

“So, he doesn’t know you’re here? That’s juicy. Not going to say I’m not jealous, but I won’t get in your way, honey. You deserve your turn.”

“I’m...I’m just here to help out. I’m here for work,” Michelle insisted.

“Of course you are, hon.”

Wes rejoined them before Michelle could respond, which was just as well. She was reeling. It sounded like Jewel implied her husband, Charlie, was good with her screwing Wes. Was he one of those cuckolds she’d read about? Her mind went right to Clay, of course, the last person she wanted to think about tonight. Would Clay be excited she was out with Wes? Michelle just couldn’t accept that. It was too twisted. If Jewel’s Charlie was one of those cuckolds, how did she accept it? Jewel was a cool customer, so maybe she was happy to take advantage when her husband encouraged her to be with another man. Michelle wasn’t wired that way. She couldn’t understand

it, no matter how many times she tried. It was easier to think Clay was having an affair than believe he was that twisted.

“Why do you girls look like you’re scheming?” Wes asked, turning on that thousand-watt smile.

“You know me, babe. I don’t have to scheme. I just take what I want,” Jewel replied.

“That’s what I love about you, Jewel. You put it all out there,” he said.

“Life’s easier that way. Less misunderstandings. Right, Michelle?” Jewel quipped.

“Yeah, of course,” Michelle agreed.

“Michelle, we need to go up and get photos of the bride getting ready. Come with me,” Wes said.

“Let’s do it,” she replied brightly, plastering on a smile. She was happy for something to do, hoping it would stop the wild thoughts spiraling through her head.

The bride was in a big room that looked like an expensive hotel suite. The kind Michelle and Clay couldn’t afford to stay in raising two boys on teachers’ salaries. The decorations were opulent, the wallpaper like something out of a French palace, and the furniture more beautiful and expensive than comfortable.

A small retinue surrounded the bride, who waited in a silky robe. The bride seemed annoyed she had to wait for the photographers to continue getting ready, until Wes turned on the charm. After that, she insisted he call her Caroline, and followed his direction like a submissive doll. Michelle didn’t blame the woman. She knew first-hand how Wes took over with his charm. Even the mother of the bride—who demanded Wes call her Esther—was taken with the handsome photographer.

Caroline, the bride, struck every pose Wes asked for, looking shy and joyous in turn. Her hair was done, and make-up applied, but she mimed going through the process for Wes’s lens. Michelle was sure the stern Esther

would object to that, but the bride's mother blushed when Wes suggested she looked more like Caroline's sister and agreed it might be fun. The bride parted her robe at Wes's direction, and he snapped a couple pictures, but he wanted more. He asked if he could take the liberty of touching her to pose her and Caroline looked like she'd drop to her knees if he asked.

Michelle was hot with jealousy, even though she got what Caroline was feeling. She just felt less special seeing the patented Wes charm turned on other women. It was foolish, but she wanted to be the only woman on Wes's mind. The bride was a tall, willowy, patrician blonde, and Michelle could well imagine Wes having his way with her if they were left alone in that room. It wouldn't come as a surprise if he had a bride or two on his resume. The strange mixture of disgust—that Wes was probably a man-whore—and pride—that a man like him, who could have anyone he wanted, wanted her, confused Michelle. She was supposed to disdain men like Wes, but it was his confident masculinity that made her want him even more. It was the very thing that should repel her that attracted Michelle.

Caroline dropped her robe when Wes asked, revealing her ivory, wedding-night corset, matching panties and stockings. The bride giggled like she was being oh-so-naughty as she struck the sultry poses Wes demanded. Michelle noted the photographer no longer asked Caroline to pose, but directed her, as if she were about to be his wife. There was no way Michelle would have revealed her body to another man like this on her wedding day—let alone posed like that for him—and she was scandalized on the bride's behalf. And yet, she wanted to be that bride. She wanted Wes's full attention back on her. She sat back and watched Wes work and was impressed by the sensual photos he got out of the previously prissy blonde bride but wanted to be the one posing. She rushed for the wedding dress when he asked her to fetch it.

When they finished, the bride and her mother were gushing over Wes and Esther asked for his card. Michelle was sure the woman would try to

schedule a boudoir session of her own with sexy Wes. Caroline may have even been having second thoughts about her husband, thinking she could have a man like Wes. Michelle trudged after Wes when they left the bride, carrying the camera bag.

“Is something wrong?” he asked, pausing before they turned the corner to the stairs. They were alone in the hallway, for the moment.

“What would be wrong?”

“You seem stiff.”

“I am not stiff.”

“You have nothing to be jealous about, babe.”

“I’m not jealous.” He gave her a skeptical look. “Oh, I forgot, you can read my mind,” she snidely replied.

Wes came closer and she backed against the wall. There was nowhere to escape. She swallowed hard. The jealousy fed her passion for him, but the anger evaporated. It was impossible to stay angry when he was this close.

“That was just me doing my job. Caroline’s not my type.”

“Isn’t she every guy’s type?”

“I prefer my women more real, fierier.”

“Am I fiery?” Her voice was a skeptical whisper.

“The fire’s there, Michelle. You just need a man to bring it out. You want it to come out.”

“You’re so sure of yourself.”

“Tell me I’m wrong.”

She couldn’t, not honestly. Instead, she pivoted. “Did you fuck Jewel?”

“Does it matter? I’m not here to fuck her tonight. She’s here for business.”

“Am I here for business too? Just your assistant?”

“That’s up to you,” he parried, moving another inch closer. His strong, masculine scent intoxicated her.

“You didn’t answer...about Jewel.”

“Do you really want the answer, Michelle? Will it change anything?”

“What about her husband?”

“If you must know, he doesn’t mind. Some men like that sort of thing.”

Like my husband? The thought came unbidden. “That’s...”

“Is tonight about Jewel or about you, Michelle?”

“I’m just trying to understand.”

Wes gave her something she understood. He kissed her. He held the back of her head and plied her thin, ruby lips with his soft, full lips. The camera bag slipped from her shoulder, down her arm, and to the floor. Her arms closed around him and she clung to his strong back as she struck at his tongue with her own. His energy poured into her, scorching her entire body. She was aflame for him. The kiss felt eternal, yet far too short when he ended it. Her bottom lip clung to his when he pulled away.

“I hope that clears up things for you, Michelle.”

Wes kissed her forehead and turned to go down the stairs, leaving Michelle agape.

FIFTEEN

THE WEDDING WAS AN ELEGANT AFFAIR. It was like the glorious, over-the-top culmination of some 90s romcom. Michelle had never been to anything so fancy, not that she had time to enjoy it. Wes didn't take it easy on her because she was a fill-in assistant. They were on the go for most of the night. Michelle trailed Wes with a heavy camera accessory bag over her shoulder and a camera of her own. Wes encouraged her to snap anything she thought would make for an interesting photo. As the night went on and her confidence grew, she snapped away more and more, in between handing Wes fresh batteries and new SD cards. They separated for a bit when Michelle acted as guest interviewer to Jewel's videographer.

The women went from table to table asking guests for funny stories about Caroline and the groom, and for well-wishes and advice on how to maintain a satisfying, happy marriage. Michelle was particularly interested in the latter, given the current state of her own marriage. How odd was it that she was there celebrating the happy occasion of a new couple starting their life together, while her husband was hours away in the woods with his hot, young protégé, and Michelle was only present because she was chasing after her hunky photographer?

Much of the advice consisted of meaningless platitudes and clichés or milquetoast suggestions like *love each other* and *communicate*. Michelle

used to believe those things were enough. She thought she had them in her marriage. They talked about their dreams and aspirations. They shared their frustrations. But she questioned all that now. Clay had obviously been keeping things from her. He kept his relationship with Piper—whatever it was—a secret. And then there were his strange new bedroom fantasies. Unless they were a guilty reaction to his affair, he had to have been harboring them for some time. He still hid the whole truth. Michelle didn't like grappling with the implications, but it was clear she'd only seen the tip of the iceberg and that her husband wasn't coming clean any time soon. Could Clay have been secretly bi-sexual all these years? Was he one of these cuckolds she'd read about? Michelle shuddered at the thought.

A couple of the drunker guests offered racy advice. One obscene suggestion was a *never go to bed without fucking* variation on the old bromide, while another was to do whatever it takes to always keep things spicy, the commenter insisting that if they stayed happy in the bedroom they'd be happier everywhere else. Michelle would have wondered if that man was married if he hadn't been seated next to his wife. Yes, being happy in the bedroom was important to a marriage—it was important to Michelle—but she knew it was not a guarantee of happiness elsewhere in the marriage. The suggestion to *keep things spicy* brought her right back to thinking about Clay and his toys and his insistence that was his only motive. If Michelle was edgy and outspoken—not a high school English teacher—she would have told the wedding guest all about her husband's bag of toys and fantasies of her fucking other men and asked if that was the sort of thing he had in mind. As they walked away, Jewel laughed, and said, “Don't worry, I'll cut the crazier shit out.”

While they were apart, Michelle kept scanning the crowd for Wes. Even in a huge ballroom crowded with wedding guests, she still found herself drawn to his presence. The inextricable pull of his gravity never weakened, no matter how many people were between them. Their eyes met through the

crowd, he smiled, and she felt a deep warmth down in her core. The outcome would be morally wrong and mean crossing a line she never thought she'd cross, but Michelle couldn't wait to be alone with the dark hunk.

They came back together, and his arm slipped around her waist possessively. His masculine scent gave her the tingles and her hand rested on his chest as she fought the urge to pull him into a kiss. He fixed her with those soft brown eyes, piercing her.

"You know you're the hottest woman here, right Michelle?"

Michelle glanced around the crowd, saw the stunning bride in her gown, the other guests in their sexy little cocktail dresses, and she refused to believe it, but Wes saying it still made her glow.

"You don't have to lie," she demurred. "I saw the bridesmaids with you during the party photos. They're young and pretty and I bet you could have any of them tonight."

"I don't want them," he insisted.

"Damn, Wes. I bet you could even have the bride, if you wanted her."

Wes couldn't help grinning because he knew it was true. Humility was not in his toolbox. "None of that matters. There's only one woman here I want." He swept her off the floor and back into their ready room. She heard the snick of the lock behind them when he closed the door.

"Wes," she said, uncertainly.

"Michelle," he replied, setting his camera down and pulling her to him.

"I think Jewel is disappointed I'm here." She barely managed to get the words out before his lips covered hers. Her arms went up over his shoulders, while his folded around her. A hand rested on her ass. She kissed him hungrily, finally getting what she'd been craving all night.

"You don't need to worry about her. Jewel knows the deal," he answered, between kisses, while guiding her back toward a black leather couch against a wall.

The backs of her legs touched the couch and Michelle would have fallen backwards if not for Wes gently guiding her down like she was feather light. He knelt on the edge of the couch between her knees, parting her thighs and forcing her skirt to hike up higher. She pulled him down to her, but he braced a hand on the back of the couch, staying up, forcing her to come up to him. She did, devouring him with kisses while caressing his smooth, handsome face and running her fingers through his kinky, tufted hair. Wes plucked open a couple buttons and slid his hand inside her blouse, his huge, powerful hand covering her small breast, kneading tender flesh through the soft, warm padding protecting it.

Michelle gasped his name and trailed her hand down granite chest, over his belt, to grasp that massive lump in his expensive slacks. They seemed tailored to show off his size. Her fingers trailed down his pant leg and his length felt endless. She squeezed and it jumped in response, straining its tight confines.

“Take it out,” he instructed, nibbling at her ear, then finding that spot behind it that shot chills down her spine, straight to her sex. She kept caressing his length through his slacks. “Take it out, Michelle.” His second command was more forceful.

“Wes...not here...we can’t...Jewel...someone will come in...”

“I want you, baby. Don’t you feel it?”

“Yes...”

“Take it out, Michelle. You want to take it out.”

“I do, but Wes... Later. Take me home.”

“Take it out now, or I won’t take you home. Show me how much you want it, Michelle. Show me now.”

Michelle was torn in two. She wanted nothing more than to take out his big piece of meat and have him fuck her right there while the wedding reception carried on. Maybe no one would hear her ecstatic cries if the band was loud enough. But she couldn’t risk being discovered.

Single Michelle would have been worried enough about being caught. Married Michelle was petrified, even though she didn't know a soul at the wedding.

"Do it, baby. Take what you want. Show me you want it," he breathed in her ear. He nibbled at that spot on her neck, and she gasped.

That'll leave a mark, she thought, worried her hair might not hide her new mark of Cain.

Wes pulled back—no more than an inch—but it was enough to spur her to action. Michelle grabbed for his belt. It was stubborn and she needed two hands to pull the prong from the stiff, expensive leather. She didn't usually need such effort with her husband—Clay was usually in boxers in bed—and she was out of practice. The belt popped free and she unclasped his slacks. Michelle bit her bottom lip, impatient that his slacks didn't just magically evaporate so she could have him. Every second of delay raised the possibility of being caught. The fear made her heart pound harder, made her tingle everywhere. She'd never felt more alive.

A yank of his tight, silky boxer briefs and his heavy, dark meat sprang free, slapping into her palm. Her fingers tightened around its girth but couldn't close completely. She marveled at its size, its heat, its power. She'd seen it before, but Michelle suspected every time would be like a first time with this magnificent specimen. All her insistence over the years that size didn't matter felt like feeble lies, because she was inordinately impressed by Wes's manhood. She added her other hand, but her pale hands didn't cover the dark brown shaft—not even close. The light from the recessed fixtures in the ceiling was subdued, but enough to glint off her wedding band as she slowly stroked him. The brief distraction brought Clay to mind and the dark thought, *Maybe this is what he wants*.

"Feels good, momma," Wes sighed, applying a gentle hand to the back of her head as he slightly turned his hips. She moved with him, his end inches from her lips.

“Please, don’t call me that, honey. It’s...” Michelle found being called *momma* by her lover odd and creepy, but it was difficult to form words when she was so fixated on that magnificent cock.

“Sure, baby. Just do it, Michelle.”

A droplet of thick desire formed on his fat tip and drooped downward, hanging like a spider web. Michelle caught it with the side of her thumb. It clung like warm syrup, and just as she would with sweet syrup, she licked and sucked it from her thumb, staring up at Wes. He smiled down at her, stroking her hair. She would gladly have stretched this out, so she didn’t come off as too easy, but the risk of discovery weighed on her. Refusing him simply wasn’t an option. His cock seemed to leap at her when she opened wide and stretched her lips around its blunt head.

Wes groaned and his fingers tightened in her hair, pulling it from her up-do. Chestnut locks tumbled down as her cheeks hollowed. She sucked him hard. She sucked him hungrily. He was right that she wanted him, and Michelle was ready to show him just how much. Her tongue swirled around his head, straining for room in the tight confines of her filled mouth. Wes gasped her name and trembled. She pressed forward, taking more of him, stretching her mouth wider. Her hands stayed busy, caressing the portion of him not in her mouth—the portion that would never fit in her mouth. She accepted more and more in a steady rhythm, her slurping sounds filling the small room, but she could never take it all.

The last time he was in her mouth, Michelle struggled to hold him back, like that maintained some kind of virtue—like she was only a quarter guilty if she only sucked a quarter of his dick. It was silly, virginal schoolgirl math. This time, she wanted to prove how much she could suck. She was sure he’d been in Jewel’s mouth. Michelle had to be better. She closed her eyes and focused on her breathing. It was a struggle to breathe around such an enormous stab of man. He hit the back of her throat and it protested, closing. She fought her gag reflex.

“Come on, girl. Come on. You can do it. Suck that thing. Suck it like you want it, Michelle. Just relax and take it. Relax, girl. You can do it. You want it, baby. Yeah...yeah...shit yeah. Fuck that’s good, baby.”

His words poured into her ears like spiked honey, sweet and intoxicating. She wasn’t used to a man talking to her like that, like she was a sex object. Michelle liked it, even though she knew she shouldn’t. She breathed like she did during a hard run, trying to calm her runaway heartbeat and willed her throat to relax. She hardly had time to snatch a deep breath before Wes pushed into her throat. He plugged it and held his cock there, pressing on the back of her head.

“Yeah, that’s fucking good. That’s it, baby. Shit, that throat is tight! Suck it, Michelle. You need that big dick. Look at me, baby. I wanna see it in your eyes. You need it!”

Her eyes fluttered open and the intensity coming from him was frightening. He projected his need to dominate like he was performing for more than an audience of one. Wes was so very different than Clay. Michelle had no idea she wanted a man to possess her like this until she met Wes, but now it was exactly what she wanted. It was the piece she didn’t know was missing. She sucked him fervently even as she struggled to breathe with his cock embedded in her throat. She was close at the edge of panic when Wes withdrew and allowed her to breathe again.

“Oh god,” she gasped, embarrassed by the drool dripping from her lips as she sucked in cool air. Michelle still gripped him, and he bobbed right in front of her face, tapping her lips for re-entry.

Michelle wasn’t quite ready to take him again, but she opened wide when Wes pushed forward. He held her face in both hands now, making her look up at him while he steadily fed her his cock. The way he brushed back her hair was strangely loving, given the situation.

“Work your magic, Michelle. Make me cum with that beautiful mouth. You want it. Prove you want it, baby. Suck me dry, baby,” he groaned.

It was so easy to give herself over to his power. She sucked him harder and harder, pumping the ample shaft that wouldn't fit in her mouth. Her other hand cupped his sac and massaged his balls. It was an old trick she used in college to get blowjobs done faster. Michelle worked that sac and ran a finger back over his taint. Clay didn't need that trick these days. He always came incredibly fast.

"Shit, yeah. That's it. That's it, Michelle. Fuck! Work that dick! Love that big dick, baby! Oh fuck, you want it! Yeah...yeah...yeah... It's coming, baby! It's fucking coming, Michelle..."

Michelle coughed hard when the first blast caught the back of her throat. His massive load kept coming though, and she had to keep swallowing or drown in it. She pumped his shaft and milked his balls and swallowed rapidly. White cum bubbled from her lips, but she drank about all of it. When his half-flaccid cock slipped free, Michelle licked her lips and flopped back onto the couch.

"Damn, baby. Your husband's a fucking lucky man," Wes grinned, as he tucked that hose back into his pants.

"Thanks," she sheepishly replied. She didn't want this man bringing up her husband. Her mind was already reeling from her slutty, unfaithful behavior.

Wes knelt and got close. He brushed a bit she missed from the corner of her lips and of course and sucked his thumb clean. Michelle felt like she'd transformed into someone else. This wasn't her. Or was it? If she hadn't met Clay, married, and had children, would she be the kind of vixen who gave her lover blowjobs in the back room at a wedding reception? It was kind of delicious to consider, even if it went against everything she was raised to believe was proper.

"Be proud, baby. Be proud you're so sexy and sultry. You're an exciting woman, Michelle," he said, softly kissing her.

She felt that way when she was with Wes. Exciting and vibrant. It was who she wanted to be. The desire to be the woman Wes saw overrode the guilt and shame—at least while she was with him. Michelle managed a smile and said, “Take me home tonight, Wes.”

“You couldn’t stop me, Michelle.” He kissed her again. “We’d better get back out there before we’re missed. Come out when you’re ready.”

Wes left the room and Michelle was still on the couch trying to put her hair back up when Jewel came in with her camera.

“I...uh...” Michelle stammered.

Jewel smiled knowingly, while her eyes radiated with jealousy. “I’m just back here to get a fresh battery. You enjoy yourself while you can, honey.”

Michelle had so many questions, but Jewel fetched her battery and was gone in a flash.

SIXTEEN

THE REMAINDER of the wedding passed as a blur, like a television program half-watched while doing something else. Michelle recalled dutifully following Wes around and handing him whatever he asked for, and catching envious looks from Jewel, but that was about it. She helped him pack up his gear in the small, dark parking lot behind and waited while he paid Jewel. It felt like he was gone forever, and Michelle may have been jealous under other circumstances, but she was so abuzz with nervous energy and enflamed with erotic excitement she just paced in little circles in the parking lot while she waited for Wes to return to her.

Wes caught her by the side of her minivan and held her, hands on her waist. He forced her to still, but Michelle still paced on the inside. He turned those eyes and that brilliant smile on her. They shone brightly, even in the dark parking lot. They kissed and her body hummed.

“Are you ready?” he asked.

Michelle nodded, feeling meek, but hoping she projected confidence.

The drive downtown was too long. She followed him and fixed her attention on his taillights, trying to force away the maelstrom inside her. The last thing Michelle needed was the time to reflect the drive to Wes’s provided. Virtue put up a good fight, but she wanted what she wanted and base desire had the firm upper hand by the time she parked. Michelle took a

deep breath in the minivan, bracing herself to leave behind the world of sports equipment, spilled snacks, and carpooling it represented. She slammed the door of the minivan behind her and charged across the street into the arms of her lover.

Michelle expected a frantic tumble into the loft, kissing and groping at each other like in a movie, but the reality was that they had to get his equipment inside, and she helped carry it. She felt him watching her the entire time, appraising her. Wes probably thought she was going to chicken out and run again, but Michelle was committed. She watched him too, admiring the way his body moved under that smooth, perfectly tailored shirt and the way his pants clung to his rear. She mentally undressed him, picturing Wes as a fantasy lover off the cover of a romance novel. Michelle didn't know what to expect. Her husband was the only naked man she'd seen for decades, and Wes certainly would *not* look like Clay when his clothes came off.

Wes stowed his gear in the office section of the loft, while she wrung her hands by the kitchen island. The waiting was torture. It felt like he was making her wait purposely, enjoying her discomfort. If it was a test of her determination, she would pass it. Wes finally came to her, broad dazzling smile, dark eyes twinkling. He looked as excited as she felt, and it made her heart swell.

"Are you sure you want this?" he asked, voice soft, fingers pushing into her hair as he cradled her face.

Michelle smiled up at him and replied with a kiss. All her impatience and need poured out through that kiss and she aggressively darted her tongue past his lips. His tongue wrestled hers while he sucked on it, gripping her tighter in his hands, asserting his control. Wes pulled her back from the kiss and her wet lower lip trembled, her eyes were wide, her cheeks flushed crimson. Michelle quirked a smile.

"Did that answer your question?"

“God, I’ve wanted you from the first day I laid eyes on you, Michelle. You’re so beautiful. Your body is amazing. I saw that fire in you, and I knew if I was patient it would come out.” His rich brown eyes radiated sincerity.

“Wes...”

Michelle was a pragmatic woman and while the sweet flattery warmed her core, her brain rejected it, wanting to tell him, *You already have me. You don’t need the flattery anymore.* Instead, she whispered, “Take me to bed.”

Wes did indeed take her to his bed, but not right away. Instead, he kissed her and unbuttoned her blouse. He was slow and methodical, like he wanted to reveal her body, rather than just tear her clothes away. His fingertips brushing her skin as he peeled away her top gave Michelle the shivers and by the time he was pulling the black shirt away from her shoulders, her heart pounded so hard it felt ready to tear itself from her chest. Michelle clung to him for support as he reached for the zipper at the hip of her skirt.

Her skirt dropped to the floor and his eyes swept up her long, lean body, taking in her black thigh highs, tiny lacy panties, and the black push-up bra that gave her the amazing cleavage. Wes stared at her like he was deciding what he wanted to do with her first. It wasn’t the first time he’d seen her nearly naked. That night when he’d pulled down her dress was in almost the exact same spot. But Wes was rushed that night, while this time he seemed determined to take his time and enjoy her. Michelle felt like the treat he’d been holding out all day to savor.

Michelle gasped when he forcefully took hold of her and spun her toward the kitchen, bending her forward over the bar-height island. She was between two stools and felt trapped. Wes opened her bra with a snap and disposed of it. His hand ran up and down her back before he leaned her. His breath on her shoulder made hers catch in her throat. Her hair was still down from before and he pushed it aside when his soft, full lips brushed the

side of her neck. Michelle trembled. A hand pressed into her flat tummy, the other cupped a breast that dangled over the marble surface of the island. Michelle stared into the dark kitchen, feeling like she was going to hyperventilate. *This isn't me*, she thought. But she wanted it to be.

Wes massaged her breast and made contact with her jutting butt. She felt how his thick erection stretched his pants tight. She rubbed back against it. She couldn't help herself.

"You've been thinking about this, haven't you?" he breathed into her ear, between kisses.

"Yes," she hissed, closing her eyes as the moment consumed her.

"You wanted it that night, didn't you Michelle?"

Before she could answer, his big hand slid from her stomach to push into her panties. His fingers glided over her smooth, waxed mound to curl into her wet center. Michelle gasped, biting her lip, and hanging her head forward. Wes bit her neck and fear surged that he would mark her. The fear excited her, and she moaned.

"Didn't you, Michelle?" he persisted, fingers finding and stroking her g-spot.

"Yes!" she cried, louder than she intended. "Yes, please, Wes..."

He toyed with her like that, bent over the island, trapped between his fingers massaging inside her and his bulge grinding her from behind. Michelle panted and squished around his fingers, dripping as he worked her to a fever pitch. It was maddening. He knew what she wanted—she told him—but Wes made her wait. The waiting was almost too much. It drove her mad.

"Ahh...Wes...please..."

Wes released her, stepped back. It was so sudden, Michelle sagged to the island. She caught her breath and turned on him. He looked smug standing there, watching the effect he had on her. Even his smugness was attractive, dammit. Michelle sprung herself at him.

A lesser man would have staggered back under her assault, but Wes held his ground. Michelle was all over him, pulling at his shirt, sending buttons flying while kissing every bit of bare flesh her lips could find. She growled with frustration when she pulled at his belt, but it didn't want to yield. Michelle's clothes seemed to magically melt away, but she had to work to get at Wes's body.

His pants were finally undone, but she was distracted by his chiseled chest and her frantic attention returned there. Wes shrugged out of his hanging shirt while she kissed his chest and her slender fingers traced muscles and lines she never thought she'd experience on a man. He tasted citrusy. Her husband wasn't a disaster, but Clay was not built like Wes. Michelle might never have a man like this again, and she wanted to memorize every detail. Her tongue ringed his dark nipples and Wes grunted, lacing his fingers in her hair. Those fingers tightened when she sucked them, and his implied strength tightened her sex. Wes groaned her name and gasped as she feasted on his nipples, her palms flat on his hard, wide chest. His strong hands pulled her back and his gaze down on her was frighteningly intense. Wes looked like he wanted to consume her. Michelle closed her eyes in anticipation of a coming kiss, but he swept her up in his arms and carried her away.

The trip up the open stairs to the bedroom loft was harrowing, but Wes carried her effortlessly, like she was a doll. She loved his power. The bedroom was just a large open loft with an exposed brick wall behind the giant bed, low glass walls topped with metal railings on two sides, and the continuation of the tall windows that overlooked the street below. Shades were affixed to cover the windows in the bedroom, but they were open. Michelle felt exposed as the orangey streetlight poured in over the bed, but she didn't want to appear prudish by asking Wes to close the blinds. The bed was a low platform, and he deposited her there.

Michelle tried to arrange herself in the sexiest position possible while Wes stood over her undressing. She was distracted and openly stared. Wes was just a beautiful man. Big, strong, and masculine, but not rough or uncouth. His granite body almost seemed to shine in the streetlight. He was the most exquisite man Michelle had ever seen in the flesh. She felt she had to touch him again to make sure he was real. His handsome face smirked. Wes knew the effect he had on her. Michelle knew she wasn't the first woman to look up at him like that from this bed. She wasn't embarrassed. He could have her admiration. He deserved it. In that moment, Michelle didn't even care if she was just another notch on his bedpost. She just wanted to enjoy her turn on the ride.

Her attention was drawn to his jutting manhood—the showstopper. Michelle had seen it, touched it, kissed it, but it wasn't presented to her like this the last time. She didn't really have the chance to sit back and behold it like this. It was truly a wonder. Part of her was glad she wasn't single, because she'd never find another man who'd match up to Wes—she was sure of that. It stood out proudly from his body, twitching with his pulse, like it had a life of its own. Everything was so smooth, his dick, his balls. It made it seem even more unreal. But it was very real. Michelle knew that. She'd felt it and tasted it. She longed to do so again.

“Don't be shy, baby. You two are already friends,” he said, amused by her rapt attention. This was how a real man behaved—confident and assured.

Michelle spun up onto her knees and crawled to him. She ached to have him inside her, but she would do this first because she wanted to please him. Michelle pushed her long, chestnut hair back and grasped him, fingers not quite closing around his girth. Her slender, pale fingers stood out starkly against his veiny, ebony hardness. Her fist stroked him, stretching his skin as she leaned in closer.

“Look at me, babe,” he commanded.

A shiver shot down her spine as Michelle did as instructed. She tried to project confidence she didn't feel as she looked deep into those rich brown eyes of his. She softly smooched the tip, and the way his mouth hung open when he sighed emboldened her, and she stretched her lips around it, suckling. Her tongue swirled over the head and she tasted his salty discharge. Michelle may have only going down on her husband three or four times in the past year, but she was blowing Wes twice in one day. She couldn't get enough of his cock. If only Clay saw her like that, maybe he'd understand that turning his wife loose with another man was a dangerous thing.

"Damn, Michelle. You are fucking good at that. Fuck, baby."

Wes arched his back with his hands on his hips, a superhero pose that presented his cock to her. Michelle focused on his head, her lips locked just past the flared edge. Her cheeks hollowed and her tongue worked overtime. She added a second hand, using both to work his thick meat while she sucked, like she was trying to draw his essence out through his cock.

"C'mon, baby. Take it deep. I know you need that big, black dick. You proved it at the wedding. Stop holding back and suck it. Suck it like you want it, Michelle."

His words would have seemed silly in a porno, but they enflamed her in real life. It seemed like he was performing, but he didn't need to do that for her. The people pleaser in her came out in force, and Michelle took more and more of him into her mouth, stretching her lips around his dark shaft. It grew thicker as she bobbed lower, stretching her lips obscenely wide. Michelle whimpered around her mouthful as she struggled to accommodate him. She sucked him aggressively, like she really did hunger for it. His fat, blunt head hit the back of her throat before she even had half of it in her mouth and her nostrils flared as she struggled to balance breathing and sucking.

“Fuck, baby. You love black dick. That sweet little mouth of yours is perfect. Yeah, that’s it. Yeah, keep going, baby...”

Michelle strained to relax her throat enough to take him deeper. Wes didn’t have to force himself into her throat. She wanted to prove herself to him. Jewel looked like the kind of woman who’d deep throat this thing, she ruefully thought—even if she choked on it—and Michelle would not be outdone. Her gag reflex triggered and strange, alien sounds barked from her muffled lips, but she forced that meat deeper still. Michelle bobbed forcefully, like she was trying to ram it down her own stretched throat. Spit dripped from her lips. Her world centered on pleasing the big cock in her mouth. Michelle kept that dick embedded in her throat until she thought she might pass out before releasing it with a deep, whooshing breath.

“*Day-am*, baby. Ain’t nobody done that. That mouth is magical, Michelle.”

Wes stroked back her hair and his smile was everything in that moment. Michelle had proven herself to him. She’d accomplished many things in her life, her master’s degree, being a great mom and a beloved teacher, a fantastic wife, but perversely, being Wes’s best cocksucker ranked right up there in that moment. He leaned down and kissed her while she caught her breath and Michelle grabbed onto him, like she was trying to climb his powerful body. He lifted her again and crawled onto the bed, carrying her. Wes leaned forward and she hung from his powerful shoulders as he lowered her back to the mattress.

“Ahh...babe...god...” she sighed, fingers raking through his short, thick twists of hair and pulling him down.

Michelle moaned and stretched her body beneath Wes. He hovered over her and kissed and nibbled her neck. She still feared being marked but was powerless to stop him. His lips on that magical spot turned her to jelly. His huge hand stroked up her side, covering it. Fingers plucked at her dark, thick nipple. Michelle bit her lip, but still cried out. He moved lower and

those pillowy lips closed over the other nipple. He suckled and she arched her back off the bed, digging her nails into him. Wes wasn't gentle, but he didn't hurt her. He knew instinctively right where her line was. It was like he had her instruction manual and worked her body like a pro.

"Mmm...yeah...ahh...yeah...Wes..."

Wes held her just above the waist and his hands almost encircled her body. Everything about him was huge. It took her breath away. He held her there and feasted on her small breasts like they were the best he'd ever seen. Michelle was flooded with scorching pleasure. It was too much. Her cries filled the loft and her body burned for him. She was almost relieved when he dropped her to the sheets and moved even lower.

"Love the stockings, baby. You know how to work it, don't you?" he chuckled.

Michelle laughed and it came out like a sigh. "I don't know that anyone would say that about me. I'm a sweats and yoga pants kind of girl."

"If your husband doesn't notice how sweet this ass is in yoga pants, he's not fucking paying attention anymore, baby." Wes smacked the side of her ass and she yelped. It felt naughty and she liked it. "But don't worry, Michelle. I'm gonna appreciate the fuck out of this ass all night."

Wes had her legs up in the air while he knelt between them and kissed her stockinged thighs. Michelle's stomach dropped at the mention of her husband. In her ecstasy, she'd managed to forget she was a married woman for a moment. Guilt gnawed at her now, but Wes kissed above the lacy elastic band at the top of her thigh high and his warm breath so close to her wet center pushed that guilt away. Wes was right. Clay didn't appreciate her. If he did, he wouldn't need all those toys to get off with her. And he certainly wouldn't need to go sniffing after Piper. Michelle had nothing to feel guilty about. She wouldn't be in that bed with Wes if Clay hadn't pushed her to it. Michelle would enjoy herself tonight, and Clay's feelings be damned.

“Ahh...god...Wes...mmm...”

Michelle cried out as elastic bit into her skin when he tore away her panties, turning them to a useless scrap of lace. They were tossed aside. Wes curled forward, in a deep, worshipful bow, and dined on her pussy. Big thumbs spread her open and his strong, wide tongue dipped inside her. He sucked at her lips and slurped her flowing nectar. Michelle hooked her knees over his shoulders and her heels dug into his granite back as she levered herself up and pinned his head between her thighs. His tongue flattened over her throbbing clit and he effortlessly made her climax. She cried his name and trembled. Wes kept licking and sucking. Michelle thought she might pass out. One orgasm led into another. Wes kept licking and sucking. He ate pussy like it was his art. Michelle was thrilled to be his canvass. His hands covered her tight ass and gripped her to him. They were locked together, but it wasn't clear who was trapping who.

“Ahh...Wes...god...ahh god...mmm...fuck...”

Michelle cried and thrashed in his grip. Her thighs might have snapped a weaker man's neck, but Wes was a powerful bull. She pulled on his twists of hair like she was trying to rip them out, and still Wes kept licking and sucking. Wes didn't stop until Michelle finally went limp and whimpered for mercy.

“Babe...babe...please...god...I can't take it...Wes...”

Her entire body pounded with the force of her heartbeat.

“But I don't wanna stop, Michelle. You got a sweet little pussy. I could drink down here all night.” He grinned up from between her thighs, mouth and cheeks glazed.

“Mercy...Wes...babe...I need...” Her breath was ragged. She could hardly breathe.

“I know what you need, baby.”

Wes did, in fact, know exactly what Michelle needed. His massive body covered hers and they made out like long lost lovers. She kissed him deeply,

savoring her own tangy sweetness, sucking his tongue like it gave her life. He gently massaged her mound, keeping her enflamed, reminding her what she needed. He stopped moving that hand, and she rubbed herself against it, in heat for him.

Michelle's breath caught when his blunt head nudged her lips. It slipped along her slick furrow and she tensed in anticipation of the penetration. Wes pulled back her leg, spreading it out wide, the black pump dangling from her foot. He inched forward and Michelle was instantly stretched, his fat tip spearing her open. She tore her mouth from his and made a deep, guttural noise. It was just as astonishing as the first time she took his tip. Clay's favorite toy was big too, but it didn't compare to accepting this thick, powerful man between her legs. Michelle didn't panic like the first time he tried to put it in her. She didn't push Wes away. She closed her eyes and tried to relax, tilting her hips eagerly to take him. Wes slid deeper and deeper, opening her so wide. Just when she thought he might rip her in half, he paused, resting that huge slab of meat inside her.

"Ahh...ohmygod...ahh...Wes...babe..."

"That's it, girl! Just relax and take it. You can handle it, Michelle. Feels so good, doesn't it, baby?"

"Yeah...Wes...oh god, yeah..."

Wes throbbed inside her, and she throbbed around him. Their bodies seeming to join in one heartbeat. Every minute shift of him inside her sent sparks out through her body. Being opened so wide hurt, but that faded, leaving Michelle with a deep need for him—a deep need for his massive cock to take her.

Michelle held his head, pulling him toward her, and rising up, as he began to move inside her. She felt he was going to turn her inside out when he withdrew, but uttered a deep, powerful moan of satisfaction when he leisurely pushed it back inside her. As she recalled, a big cock was an extraordinary thing on a man who knew how to use it. And damn, did Wes

know how to use it. She matched his sensual rhythm, moving her hips with his, clinging to him and moaning around their shared kiss. Her legs snaked around his waist, ankles locking behind his back, her heels clicking together. Wes took it as a signal, and it spurred him to go deeper. He was fully inside her in a couple strokes. Michelle was adapting nicely, and her eyes went wide with a moan as his heavy balls nestled between her thighs.

“Love those moans, baby. You’re a sexy fucking woman, Michelle,” he groaned, looking down on her with pride. Michelle’s face was contorted with pleasure and he loved seeing the effect he had on her.

“Wes...ahh...oh god...ahh...”

“You love it, don’t you, baby?” he cooed.

“Yeah...yeah I do...”

“That’s everything you needed, isn’t it?”

“Yeah...babe...don’t stop...”

“Bet you haven’t had a good fucking in years, Michelle. Not like this.”

“No...nothing like this...ahh...nothing like this...Wes...”

The words twisted in her gut. It was a brief reminder of her husband, and it felt like a deeper betrayal to tell her lover how much better he was than Clay, but the supreme darkness of it struck a chord deep inside her—a chord that ignited a deeper passion. Michelle’s orgasm started as a tiny throb deep in her core, but it was building quickly, and Wes’s words supercharged it.

“Tell me you need it, Michelle,” he ordered.

“I...I need it, Wes. Ahh god...”

“What do you need, baby?”

“You! I need you, Wes. Oh, babe...”

“Say it, Michelle. Say you need that dick. Tell me you need that big, black dick!”

“I...I...”

Michelle struggled with the words. They felt wrong in her mouth. It felt racist to say them, but her Black lover demanded that she did. It was so dark. The darkness consumed her. The darkness poured through her and took her brain to a depraved place. Her body was on fire with lust, and now her mind was too.

“I need that dick, Wes! I need your big, Black dick!” she cried.

“Yeah, baby. Yeah! Let it all fucking out! You love that dick!”

Wes pumped harder into her. His thick root drove her down into the mattress, pinning her as it churned her insides. The bed protested beneath them, and her words and cries echoed loudly in the big, open industrial space. Michelle clung to him, losing her mind.

“Say it!”

“Give me your dick! I love your big dick! Your big, *Black* dick! Ahh... god... Wes...”

“Yeah, baby! Yeah! Fucking right, Michelle!”

Michelle howled and it felt like her mind emptied out as the stunning climax ripped through her. She howled and thrashed, body and mind exploding in bliss as his thick meat churned inside her. Wes pulled out and she groaned mournfully at the loss. She was suddenly so empty. Michelle was coming, but she wasn’t done with him yet.

“Let’s go, baby!”

Wes flipped her over and hiked her tight butt into the air, cramming it back into her from behind. Michelle’s face was buried in his pillows, her back a graceful curve as he began his pounding. Wes was no longer gentle. He was taking her now. He fucked her like a real man fucks a woman. He used her pussy like it belonged to him.

“Ahh! Ahh! Ahh!” she moaned rhythmically, turning her head out of the pillows so she could breathe.

“Here’s the fucking you need, Michelle. Gonna tear that pussy up!”

“Yeah...yeah...Wes...”

His grip was painful, fingers digging into her haunches. Wes possessed her. Michelle couldn't recall ever being so masterfully taken. Maybe it was because she was used to familiar married sex, but the way Wes fucked her—truly *fucked* her—made Michelle wonder if she could ever go back to the old way again. This was the way a man was meant to take a woman, and she wanted it. His balls slapped the backs of her thighs and the wet sounds of their coupling filled the room with her moans and his grunts. Michelle tried to push up to get on all-fours, but Wes pushed her down with a powerful hand on her back. The message was clear. He was in control, and she was there to be used now. Michelle discovered she loved being used by a powerful man.

“Fuck, Michelle...fuck Michelle...that fucking tight pussy...fuck it's good...fuck...”

“Yeah...yeah...yeah...” she cried, another climax chasing the first. The abuse her pussy was taking hurt, but it was a *good* hurt. Michelle was proud she could take it.

“Oh fuck, baby! Oh Fuck...*fuck!*”

Wes buried himself deep inside her, so deep he was pressed into her cervix. And he blasted her. His thick load felt endless as he pumped it inside her. His powerful seed filled her, and Michelle howled as her body instinctively climaxed in the moment. She scrambled on the bed beneath him, going rigid before going limp, howling like a trapped animal while the orgasm controlled her. Wes throbbed as his seed pulsed inside her. When he finally released her narrow hips, Michelle slumped to the bed—exhausted, blissful, and complete. She felt more like a woman than she had in years.

When Wes came down next to her, Michelle snuggled back against him, his slimy, spent prick nestled against her ass, and his hot, sweaty body pressed into hers. His arms wrapped around her, and Michelle closed her eyes, deeply content.

SEVENTEEN

MICHELLE DROVE IN A PANIC, flying up the interstate in the left lane, the other vehicles around her a blur. She was in a damned minivan, for chrissakes, not an Indy car. It was no surprise when she was pulled over. She cursed as she eased the minivan onto the shoulder and looked at the flashing lights in the rearview mirror. If she hadn't been in such a haze, she surely would have seen the trooper and slowed down. She just had too many things on her mind—like holding her marriage together—to worry about speeding tickets.

She watched the trooper approach in the sideview mirror and committed to getting out of this ticket if she could. The last thing she needed was points on her license. She wore a scoop neck black bodysuit with a denim skirt and pulled down the top until it just clung to her breasts without quite exposing them. She pushed the skirt higher on her long legs. This sort of thing worked in the past, but that had been long ago. It was so out of character for who she was now, but then Michelle had been doing a lot of things that were out of character. She began to wonder if she knew herself at all.

The trooper—his name tag read Spencer—rapped her window with his knuckles and Michelle lowered it. He was tall and handsome, but so

young. *Was he old enough to carry a gun?* Why did so many of the hot guys these days seem like kids to her?

“Do you realize why I pulled you over, ma’am?” Spencer was all business.

“Uh, was I speeding, officer?” Michelle tried for innocent and girlish—batting her eyes—but it felt silly when the trooper looked almost 20 years younger than her.

“Do you know the speed limit here?”

“I’m not sure, Officer. What is it?”

Michelle leaned toward Spencer, hoping to draw his attention to her shallow cleavage, which she’d left on display for her husband. She was braless too, and her nipples bumped out through the thin, stretchy knit. Spencer wore typical cop sunglasses with his Smokey the Bear hat, and she couldn’t follow his eyes, but he did skip a beat before he replied to her.

“It’s sixty-five, ma’am. You were doing seventy-eight. Do you have your license, registration and proof of insurance?”

She kept her sparse cleavage front and center—wishing she had bigger boobs, for about the millionth time—while she dug through her purse for her ID. She handed the documents over and Spencer examined them.

“I’m so sorry, Officer. I’m on my way to visit my kids at camp. I just miss them so much. It’s been a lonely summer. I guess I just wasn’t thinking.”

“I’m sure it’s hard on a good mom like you, Mrs. Winthrop” he replied. “But you need to stay safe for them.”

“Please, call me Michelle. Do you have children, Officer Spencer?”

“No, I’m single.”

“That’s too bad.” Michelle hoped her smile was seductive. Flirting with the young trooper gave her a flutter she didn’t expect.

Spencer cracked a smile. “I’ll be right back, Michelle.”

Michelle hoped she'd done enough as she waited for Spencer to return. The affair with Wes had her feeling sexier than she had in years and convinced her she still had the goods. Her mind couldn't begin to cope with the cognitive dissonance of feeling so good about herself and so ashamed of her behavior at the same time—it didn't. She let her newfound slutty side take over. If she really poured it on, could she have convinced Officer Spencer to join her in the back of the minivan? How far was she willing to go to avoid a speeding ticket? She laughed at herself and the break from the tension consuming her was a relief. She twisted the fringe of loose threads lining the hem of her skirt.

“Michelle?”

Spencer surprised her and Michelle jumped when he returned. One of her boobs almost fell out of her top and she fought the urge to fix it. She'd be pissed if she nearly flashed the trooper, and she still got a ticket from him. “Oh, hi!”

“You don't have any warrants and no tickets in the past year, so I've decided to let you off with a warning.”

“Thank you!” she exclaimed, positively bubbly.

Spencer removed his hat and leaned in the window as he returned her documents. He was close enough that she smelled his masculine aftershave. *There is something about a man in uniform*, she thought. She was sure he was staring at her barely concealed nipple.

“Just be careful, Michelle. It would be a shame for anything to happen to a pretty woman like you.”

“I will Officer Spencer. I promise.”

“It's actually Trooper, but please call me Shawn.”

Michelle shuffled through her returned documents and found Trooper Spencer's card with them.

“Feel free to call me if you need anything while you're up here, Michelle. I'm always available.”

Spencer had to know she was married. She wore her ring, and both hers and Clay's names were on the vehicle documents. He probably just took her behavior as a green light. Michelle was ashamed of herself—just a little—but prouder that Spencer was interested. The way she enjoyed attention now was just shameful, but she didn't care.

"I promise to keep you in mind, *Shawn*."

Michelle watched him walk away in the sideview mirror and noted how nice his butt looked in his uniform pants. *Get your mind out of the gutter, slut*, she thought. *You're already in enough trouble*. But then if she hadn't been acting like a slut she wouldn't be here, racing to see her husband, to see Trooper Shawn Spencer's butt.

Shifting into drive, she eased off the gravel shoulder and joined the stream of traffic. She would be up there to see Clay soon. That gave her less than an hour to come up with a plan to save her marriage. She had to do something, because if they continued down this path they would surely be divorced.



The Lenape Lodge was a quaint little motel that intentionally tried to hold onto its throwback charm. Michelle could have gone for one of the hotel chains, but they were all too far from the camp. She didn't know how long Clay could be away. The room had wood paneling and faux-Indian artifacts on the walls, beside paintings of traditional tribal scenes. She smiled ruefully, thinking her students would see it all as cultural appropriation and form a protest. They were right, but she liked the timelessness of it.

Michelle eyed the whirlpool tub at the back of the room wearily. It was surrounded by mirrors on three sides. If she had the supplies, she would have given the tub a good, hard scrubbing so they could use it, but absent that she wasn't going to go anywhere near that tub.

Her small weekend bag didn't require much unpacking. She had clothes for the next day, toiletries, a few choices of lingerie, and at the bottom of the bag Clay's favorite sex toy to use on her—the thick, black dildo. Michelle didn't know why she threw it in the bag. The night was supposed to be about reconnecting as a couple and having a come to Jesus moment about their marriage. Introducing sex toys to their lovemaking seemed counter to that goal. She wanted to leave the toy in the bag but ended up slipping it into the nightstand drawer.

Left alone with her thoughts, the guilt was overwhelming. Michelle sat on the end of the bed and stared at herself in the mirror, refusing to believe she'd come to this—waiting for a guilty assignation with husband in a rundown motel room. She'd woken that morning in a strange man's bed, wrapped in his arms. Michelle was stirred by Wes touching her and his thick cock rousing against her backside. She didn't have time to reflect on where she was or what she'd done before Wes had her soaked and panting for him. Wes took her slowly and sensually that morning. She cried out his name and begged him for more. It was dangerously close to making love.

Reality came afterward in the shower. Michelle broke down crying as she tried to scrub the guilt from her flesh. Yes, she felt justified by Clay's behavior with Piper. And yes, she badly wanted Wes. She didn't fall into his bed by accident. It was a choice. But none of that made her actions right. Michelle barely gave Wes a chance to speak with her as she threw her clothes on and stormed out of his loft, hair still dripping and clothes clinging to her damp body.

This was not how her life was supposed to work out. She tried to pinpoint a moment when she could have stopped all this in its tracks.

Should she have resisted when Clay got weird in bed? Should she have driven up to the camp and more forcefully confronted him when she learned about Piper? And what of her own guilt? She knew she was playing with fire when she encouraged Wes. But Clay's behavior made her feel justified, and she never thought it would go that far. By the time she realized everything was speeding out of control, she was so far down the road that she didn't *want* to stop it. Michelle never thought of herself as the type of woman who cheats. It was so wrong, but *god* it was so good!

Closing her eyes, she felt Wes's big, gentle hands on her body. She felt his thick, powerful cock pulsing deep inside her. She shivered, thinking about how she lay in bed, snuggled against her lover just the night before. Wes made her feel incredible, sexy in a way she hadn't felt in years. Even knowing full well he was seducing her, she was still easy prey. But sex wasn't the most important thing. She wasn't willing to be with Wes if it meant she lost everything else. There had to be a way to put her marriage back together.

Michelle snatched her phone off the bed and texted her husband, telling him she was at the motel. *I need to see you. Now.*



Clay could not come right away. *He probably can't tear himself away from Piper*, she ruefully thought. She didn't forgive her husband for Piper just because she felt guilty about Wes. Maybe they were even now, but Clay was the one who started them down this road.

Michelle had plenty to do while she waited for her husband. First, she tried to decide what she would say to him. It was during this that she opened one of the bottles of wine she'd brought with her and filled one of

the little wrapped plastic cups next to the ice bucket. She filled that little cup over and over. The wine didn't help her think, but it steadied her nerves. She moved on to thinking about how she was going to greet Clay. Before she started drinking, Michelle planned to sit him down for a talk when he arrived, but now that she had a little wine in her she realized she was there to make love to her husband. She needed that physical connection with him after what she'd done. Michelle did not drive a couple hours just to talk to Clay. Both lingerie options were laid out on the bed, but neither felt right to her.

She was still trying to decide—and half a bottle down—when the rap of knuckles on the door came. Clay called out her name, as if unsure he had the right room. Michelle looked at herself in the mirror and figured her black bodysuit was sexy enough. The denim skirt, fringed at the hem, came about to her knees, and she wiggled out of it before answering the door. She tossed the unworn lingerie back into her bag.

“Michelle,” Clay said, surprised to find her half-naked in the doorway. His eyes poured over her.

“Clay,” she replied, raking her long hair back from her face.

Michelle realized anyone in the parking lot could see her and grabbed him by his red Camp Lenape polo, dragging him into the room. She pulled his lips to hers and tugged at his shirt, desperate to get it off. Time began to move quickly, and Michelle needed Clay inside her *now*.

“Chelle...what...” he mumbled between kisses.

“Don't...talk...” she breathily replied, pulling his jeans down.

“But...”

“Make love to me, Clay. *Now!*”

Michelle pulled him onto the bed, and they landed with more of a thud than a bounce on the ancient, thin mattress. Clay started slow, but he was quick on the uptake. He began pawing at her body, mashing her breasts and pinching her nipples through the thin cotton bodysuit.

“Mmm...Clay...”

“God, I’ve missed you.”

“Me too, honey. Me too,” she breathed.

“So lonely up here without you, babe.”

Michelle became irritated. She wanted him to shut up and make love to her. He wasn’t lonely up here with Piper just a cabin away. Why did he have to keep pretending? Would he still, once she told him what she’d done? She grabbed his cock in his underwear. Clay was already hard and dripping. The difference between the way he fit in her hand and the way Wes filled it was immediately obvious. Guilt shot through her as she recalled how marvelous Wes’s cock was. Michelle didn’t want her husband any less—thinking of Wes made her hornier—but how different would it be now?

Clay popped the snaps at her crotch and peeled the bodysuit away. She was pantyless beneath it. Fingertips skimmed her smooth mound before pressing between her red, slippery lips. She swore he’d be able to tell she’d been with another man by looking at her swollen pussy, but Clay was oblivious. He traced up and down her slit and Michelle cried out, moving her hips at his fingers. She should have been ashamed and turned off, but her adulterous pussy couldn’t get enough. Despite the amazing sex with Wes, Michelle had been horny from the moment she left his bed, as if her body willed her to return to him for more. Instead, she came to her husband, confident he would satisfy her and put the other man out of her mind. His fingers slipped inside her, and she pushed, impaling herself on them. Clay curled his fingers, massaging her g-spot, and Michelle cried out.

“You’re so fucking wet, babe,” Clay marveled.

“For you, honey...”

“You’re fucking ready, aren’t you?”

“Yeah...honey...I am...don’t make me wait...”

“You’ve made me wait weeks, ‘Chelle,” he whined.

Michelle pushed Clay on his back and her bodysuit off completely, throwing it aside. She clawed at his clothes, needing them out of the way. Making love to her husband had become a biological imperative. Michelle straddled Clay once he was stripped, but paused over him while she grasped his cock, aimed at her.

Would he feel a difference? Wes was so much bigger than Clay. She couldn't be the same after being with her hung Black lover. Logically, she knew that was nonsense. Maybe if she went right to her husband from Wes's bed, he could feel she was freshly fucked, but not the next evening. But she still worried Clay would just be able to tell something was different. Her guilt and shame were pulling her in a million directions, and she wished they'd just make up their mind and pick a flavor of crazy.

Michelle sank onto her husband's cock with a low, satisfied moan. She arched her back and ground her pussy down on him, fully impaled. Her muscular thighs and strong core flexed as she gripped him inside her and worked his cock. It felt good. So good. Michelle had always thought Clay was just right for her, and Wes hadn't changed that. Her lover's thick cock was amazing, but her husband still felt perfect inside her. Clay held her hips and pulled her onto him, thrusting up from the creaking motel bed.

Her eyes flickered open and she caught him staring up at her with the oddest expression on his face. Clay looked like he was there with her but wasn't. He may have been imagining one of his strange new fantasies—she hoped that was it, anyway. Michelle didn't want to consider that he may be fantasizing about Piper. She wanted his full attention. They couldn't reconnect without it. Michelle suddenly dropped forward, catching her fall with hands on either side of Clay. Her hair fell all around them, veiling them as she churned her hips on him.

“Clay...honey...” she moaned.

“I've missed this, baby. Ohh...fuck...”

“Missed you too, honey...ohh god...”

“Yeah? You missed me?” he hissed.

“I did, missed you so much, honey,” Michelle gasped, kissing him.

“You needed to fuck, didn’t you, babe?”

A hard pit formed in her stomach, but the heat in her pussy ticked up too. It was an echo of what Wes had said. Michelle went right back to their kinky sex play before Clay left for the summer. It was all so different then. It felt like an eternity ago. She was a different woman when she was both scared and turned on by her husband’s dark fantasies. She’d given into them, even though Clay didn’t know—not yet.

“Didn’t you, Michelle. You needed to fuck...needed it so bad...”

“Ahh...yes...yes...” she cried, confessing. His demands kept Wes in the forefront of her brain. It didn’t help her guilt, but it drove her orgasm.

“It’s okay, babe. I know...I know you can’t help yourself...it’s so fucking hot...”

“Ahh...oh god...mmm...god...”

“Fuck...Michelle...fuck...ohhh fuck...”

Clay tensed up beneath her and Michelle felt him swell and detonate inside her. He came so fast! Michelle was climbing, charging toward her own orgasm, but Clay didn’t get her there. She moaned in frustration and kept riding his cock, even as it deflated. He shrank smaller and smaller, and she thrust harder. Her body vibrated with pleasure, but she just couldn’t get that final burst of release. Clay shriveled and slipped from her and she stopped moving—panting and trembling.

“Sorry, babe. It was just so fucking good...” Clay explained.

“It’s okay, it felt good, honey,” she panted, tamping down her disappointment.

“Really, it’s been so long. You can’t expect me to hold out. If you give me a minute...”

“It’s okay, really Clay. It’s okay.”

Michelle fought the urge to touch herself and finish the job. Clay would certainly love to see her do it, but she also feared it might make him feel bad—especially given what she was up there to tell him. No, she couldn't do it. Michelle closed her eyes and willed her heart rate and breathing to slow, hoping her persistent arousal would follow and dissipate. Her clit throbbed, begging for release, but she ignored it.

“Are you okay?” Clay asked.

“Yes, just coming down.”

“Do you want me to-”

“No, just give me a minute.”

Her body calmed, but the unfulfilled desire hung on. Michelle pushed it to the back of her mind and opened her eyes. Clay stared at her. She stared at the yellowing, cracked ceiling. She couldn't look at him.

Michelle hopped off the bed and retreated to the bathroom to avoid what came next. It was time to come clean and confess, but she still didn't have the words. She came out of the bathroom and poured more wine into her cheap plastic cup. In the mirror, she saw Clay on the bed, messing around on his phone. It raised her hackles. That was probably Piper, asking when he would be back—Clay telling her as soon as he could get away from the wife. Anger sizzled through Michelle, tamping her guilt down and for a moment she considered *not* confessing her indiscretion to Clay. She could just go home and call Wes and fulfill her every carnal desire. Perhaps this was what their marriage would be now—a sham they indulged in while they sought their satisfaction elsewhere. No, Michelle could never live like that. They had to fix this.

Michelle fluffed the pillows up against the headboard and leaned her back on them, joining Clay on the bed. He put his hand on her leg, and she stiffened but didn't pull away.

“Chelle, something is going on with you. You didn't drive all the way up here just to fuck me. Is this still about the Piper thing?”

“Partially, yes.”

“Babe, look in my eyes and maybe you’ll finally believe me.”

He waited for her to do it. It was painful, but Michelle forced herself to look into his eyes. Clay looked sincere. So sincere that she wanted to believe him, which made her own guilt come roaring back to stab her in the stomach.

“I did not sleep with Piper. I promise you. Yeah, I flirted inappropriately because I’m an idiot, but I did not touch her. I would not do that to you.”

Michelle’s bottom lip trembled. Her eyes burned and dampened. She believed him. Despite all the evidence, she believed him. Michelle didn’t want to believe her husband could lie to her that convincingly. And if he wasn’t lying that made what she’d done so much worse. Yes, she wanted Wes—wanted him from the moment they met—but she would have never gone down that road if she didn’t think Clay was cheating on her.

“I have something to tell you,” she said haltingly.

Michelle gripped the plastic cup so tightly she almost crushed it. She drained the wine—just to be safe—and set the cup aside. Clay took her hand, oddly calm. She would be freaking out if the tables were turned.

“Whatever it is, it’ll be okay,” he assured her.

“You don’t know that.”

“I know I love you. I know nothing could change that.”

He had to stop talking. Clay had to stop, or she would scream.

“I cheated on you!”

“What?”

“I cheated on you. I slept with someone else.”

Tears streamed down her cheeks.

“You…”

“I was so sure you were cheating, and I felt horrible, and he was there, and he wanted me, and I knew it was wrong, but it felt so good, and he wanted to see me, and I knew I should say no but I didn’t and when he—

when he—I did it. I couldn't help myself. Oh god, Clay. I'm a terrible slut. I'm so sorry." The words came out in a rush between sobs. Her tears dripped from her cheeks onto her naked body.

"Chelle, calm down. It's going to be okay. Really, it is."

"How can you say that?"

"Because I love you and we can work through anything."

"How can you even look at me? I betrayed you."

"You thought I betrayed you first."

"But you didn't! I should have had more faith in you, too! God, I really am awful!"

"Michelle, babe, come on. Take a deep breath. I understand. I get it."

Michelle dared to look at him and could not believe his calm. Clay looked serene. Almost happy. He should have been raging, screaming at her. She didn't understand.

"Clay..."

He took both her hands and squeezed them. "You thought I was cheating on you. You were home all alone. I should have come home to work it out. I should have made you understand, but I didn't."

"Don't, Clay. Don't try to put this on you."

"I'm not *completely* innocent. Those messages I shared with Piper were inappropriate. I admit it, and I'm sorry. And when you caught me, I didn't explain myself very well."

"But you didn't make me cheat. You didn't make me meet him or put those thoughts in my head."

"I know you never would have done anything if you didn't think I was cheating on you."

"I want to believe that, but I don't know..." she cried.

Clay pulled her into a tight embrace, and she went with it, even though his comforting just made her guilt worse. Her mind slipped back to being in

Wes's arms and how big and powerful her lover was. She let out a deep body sob and whimpered, "I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry. This is *not* all your fault, 'Chelle. I don't blame you, so you shouldn't blame yourself."

Michelle disentangled from Clay and sniffled, bringing her tears under control. She had to find her strength. Going to pieces wasn't going to solve anything and it was time to figure out how they moved forward, the problem was that the world no longer made sense. When this scene played out in her mind, Michelle's confession prompted Clay's own, which let them clear the air and try to put the past behind them. Instead, Clay convinced her he'd never been unfaithful, which left Michelle hanging out on her own. She still couldn't comprehend her husband's equanimity. How could a man sit there so calmly when his wife confessed to cheating? Unless he didn't care, or worse... No, she refused to believe he'd lied about Piper. He looked her in the eye and didn't flinch. Even if he'd been lying before, surely he'd have come clean when he saw how upset she was. No, he was innocent-*ish* and in a crazy twist *she* was the one who cheated.

"I don't know what to say. I don't know how you're taking this so well," she finally whispered, hardly audible.

Clay didn't speak, not right away. Michelle watched him, ready to flinch away from angry words, but he didn't look angry at all. He did, however, look like he was choosing his next words very carefully.

"Aren't you angry? I want to know how you really feel. Don't hold back, Clay," she pleaded. Michelle wanted him to give it to her full bore. She knew she deserved to be punished.

"Yeah, I'm mad. I'm mad as hell," he said, though he didn't sound it. "I mean, you're my wife. But I'm not going to throw away fifteen years of marriage over one indiscretion. I know we can work through this."

"I swear, it'll never happen again. I'll never see him again."

"I hope not!"

Michelle studied her husband. Something was not right, but she couldn't put her finger on it. Clay's reaction was just *off*. It felt like he was going through the motions. She chided herself. It was unfair to judge his reaction to her infidelity. Clay was entitled to react any way he chose.

"Clay, are you really okay?"

"I'm not *okay*. You slept with another man. I'm just trying to process it."

"I'm so sorry, Clay."

"Really, Michelle, stop apologizing. You're making me feel guilty now."

"Why would you feel guilty?"

"Like I said, you thought I was cheating. There were those things I was doing before I left. Maybe they put something in your head. You thought I was acting strange, and I didn't explain myself to you very well."

Michelle tried to process what he said, and it left her more confused. Clay couldn't really be implying what she thought. That would be insane, and if he thought that, did he think she was that weak? Her shame was evaporating as her suspicions reared up again.

"Do you mean those things we did in bed? You think they put ideas in my head?"

"Hey, I'm not saying anything. I'm just trying to consider all possibilities. I'm trying to make this make sense in my head," Clay said defensively.

"Your games did not push me to do anything, Clay. That's absurd. I'm not that gullible."

"Okay, okay. Hey, don't get mad at me."

"You're right, I'm sorry."

They were both silent, consumed by their thoughts. Michelle still felt like something was off but put that aside. She was just projecting, grasping

for something to absolve her guilt. She was in no position to question Clay—if he was telling the truth about Piper. *Stop it*, she chided herself.

“Is there anything you want to know?” she asked.

“What do you want to tell me?”

“I don’t really want to get into it, but I figure you have the right to know whatever you want.”

Clay thought it over and Michelle braced herself for a barrage of questions. He hadn’t been curious so far. He hadn’t even asked her who the other man was. That was the first thing she would have asked.

“I don’t want to push you, babe. There will be plenty of time to talk about all that later. That stuff isn’t important right now.”

“So, where do we go from here?”

“What do you think?” he asked.

“We should go talk to someone, I guess. Try to work this out?”

Clay groaned. “Maybe we can do it on our own.”

“Do you think that’s wise?”

“I really don’t want to go talk to some stranger.”

“Aren’t you worried about us?” she asked.

“Maybe I’m naïve, but I’m really not. I trust in us. I know we can survive this. We can survive anything.” Clay checked the time on his phone. “Listen, I have to be back soon. I should jump in the shower, unless...” His hand went to her thigh, near her pussy.

Michelle couldn’t believe sex was still on his mind.

“No, go take a shower.”

“Okay.”

Clay kissed her cheek and it felt awkward. Michelle was sure making love would bring them close again, would make all of this easier, but it wasn’t like that at all. She began to question if she understood anything about anything. Her whole world was upside down. Clay left the door open when he went into the bathroom and she heard the shower start. Michelle

stared after him and wondered if she still knew Clay at all. He was not the man she married—not anymore. It was normal to grow and change, especially for a couple that had been together for almost twenty years, but it felt like Clay had turned into someone else all at once. And what about her? Could Michelle claim to be the same after what she'd done? And she was kidding herself to keep thinking of it in the past tense. Wes was not out of her system. She hoped reuniting with her husband would flush the desires for her lover away, but Clay's mild reaction left her in limbo. She wanted Clay to reclaim her, but he almost acted like her sleeping with another man was no big deal.

All she could do was think of his crazy, kinky fantasies. Was there more to it than he'd admitted? Clay claimed it was all fantasy—and that it was all about her—but what if it wasn't? What if it was something that turned him on in real life? Could it be that her husband wasn't angry because he was excited by the thought of her screwing another man? Michelle shuddered and shook her head. No, she couldn't believe it. It was just so... *No, that could not be it!* Far more likely, Clay *was* cheating, and Michelle's own indiscretion relieved him of the guilt for his. He just wasn't coming clean.

Michelle leaned across the bed and snatched his phone from where he'd left it on the nightstand. He'd changed his passcode, but Clay wasn't that creative. She got it on the second try. It was Hayden's birthday. She went straight to his messages confident she'd find the evidence she needed there. She'd throw it in his face when he came out of the shower. But she froze in confusion.

Michelle found several recent notifications from a messaging app. They weren't from Piper. They were from Wes. Michelle was so confused she thought she had to be hallucinating. That couldn't be right. How could that be? She flicked the message thread open. The last one came from Wes.

[Wes] *glad to be of service. But don't worry. This isn't over yet. She'll be back.*

If she was confused before, now she was fully through the looking glass. The world did not make sense. What was Wes talking about? The gnawing feeling in her stomach said it wasn't the family portraits. Michelle paused before scrolling back. She wasn't sure she wanted to know what awaited her. She didn't think she could handle the truth. But she had to know. Michelle was in a haze as she went back to the beginning of the day in the message thread. Wes texted Clay in the wee hours of the morning, right after Michelle left his place.

[Wes] *she just left*

[Clay] *and?*

[Wes] *u guys are all the same. Think ur wives will never go for it. Michelle was amazing. I haven't seen that kind of passion in a while.*

[Clay] *so she did it? you fucked her?*

[Wes] *she was begging for it bro. she's incredible. tight in all the right places*

[Clay] *sweet. Part of me still can't believe it really happened*

Michelle's stomach heaved and she only dodged vomiting by force of will. She took a deep breath, but her lungs seized with panic. Eyes closed, she focused on her yoga training and brought her breathing back under control. She was still panicked, but it was a controlled panic. The cause of her trauma was still there in her hand. Michelle stared at Clay's phone like it was some alien thing. The words on it might as well have been some alien language for as much sense as they made. They spelled out a reality that made no sense. She willed herself to read further.

[Wes] *that's typical. You'll believe it when I send the video link. I'll pull some stills before if I can, but it's late, y'know? Your wife really wore me out. :)*

[Clay] *jesus. Give me something man*

[Wes] *Michelle was on fire. She couldn't get up to my bed fast enough. Glad we're past the playing coy phase. She was ready to fuck. And she was*

up for everything. You'll see

[Clay] *damn*

[Wes] *tired. Gonna take a break. I'll send you something as soon as I have it*

The texts for the morning ended there. Pictures followed a few hours later. The images were stills of Wes and Michelle together, obviously pulled from video cameras secreted around Wes's place. The lighting was surprisingly good, considering how dim the loft was that night, but then Wes was a professional, wasn't he?

The first stills were Michelle and the handsome photographer kissing by the kitchen, shot from a couple different angles. Her skin crawled. Michelle involuntarily glanced around the motel room, searching for hidden cameras, but she was safe there. It was her room. There she was in the stills, half-naked in her lingerie and bent over the kitchen island, his hand in her panties. The other images were in Wes's bedroom. Michelle elegantly arching her back on his bed as Wes went down on her, then several stills of her sucking his cock. A close-up showed how her lips strained and stretched around his girth. It was obscene, and she bet her sick husband loved it. And finally, stills of Michelle with her legs wrapped around while he rode her, and then her butt in the air as he rode her hard. Clay's reaction was expectedly damning.

[Clay] *holy shit! You gotta be kidding me! Fuck! That's fucking unbelievable!*

[Wes] *told ya bro. she was primed. Ur gonna lose ur mind when u see the video*

Michelle bit back the bile and scrolled backwards. The men had been texting for weeks, since before she ever hooked up with Wes. It was mostly Clay begging for details on her seduction and Wes telling him to be patient. She burned with shame over so easily being played the fool. All that time she struggled with her morality and her desires, the men in her life were

manipulating her like she was just a pawn in their sick game. There were references to other messages on some kind of online chat. She would have to find those. Michelle saw photos from that first night at Wes's, when she thought she so valiantly resisted temptation and was numb to them. Michelle sitting on the stool while Wes licked her pussy, head thrown back in ecstasy then sitting on the couch while she sucked his huge cock. She laughed aloud at her naivete. She should have followed the script and just fucked Wes that night. Or was it sweeter for the perverts that she resisted and had to be convinced?

The world was tipped sideways, and it was impossible to find her bearings. Nothing made sense. Not the scratchy sheets and quaint décor of the motel room, or the fact that her husband of fifteen years was suddenly a total stranger. She didn't think it was possible to be so fundamentally wrong about another human being. Now she wished that Clay was simply having an affair.

The shower went silent, followed by the whoosh of the curtain being pulled aside. Michelle jumped and threw Clay's phone onto the nightstand, realized it didn't look right, and locked it and set it back to how she'd found it. Clay came out of the bathroom drying his stubbly head with the towel. Everything about him that was once so familiar now seemed alien. Every gesture seemed like a lie. Michelle stared at her husband like a zoologist who'd just discovered a new species.

"Is everything okay?" he asked, pausing to stare back at her.

Michelle kept staring. She didn't even know where to begin. She opened her mouth, but no words were issued. Did they even speak the same language?

"Michelle?"

She shook her head, and everything snapped into focus—at least for the moment. A confrontation wasn't going to happen. The whole situation had to be revealed first. Michelle blinked and forced a smile.

“Sorry, I think I’m just overwhelmed. This is all too much to deal with. Coming up here was probably a mistake.”

Clay crossed the room and sat on the bed beside her. He reached for her hand, but she pulled it away.

“Chelle...”

She scooted away from him. Michelle didn’t want to be anywhere near her husband, especially naked as she was. She pulled the sheet up to cover her body. “Really, I just need time to think. I need to process everything that happened.”

“I’m okay with what happened. I really am, babe. I understand what happened and I forgive you.”

Breath seized in her chest and she tried to calm her racing heartbeat. “You should go. I want you to go. Let me work everything out on my own.”

“I don’t like leaving you like this, but if that’s what you want.”

“It is. You need to go now, Clay. Please.”

Clay dressed, giving her plenty of space as he moved around the room. He wised up and didn’t even try to kiss her before leaving. “Call me, Chelle. I mean it. I’m worried about you.”

“I will. I just... I will.”

A perplexed Clay showed himself out and Michelle flopped back on the bed. *Oh my god! This isn’t happening!* Her head spun as she tried to piece together what she’d been able to learn from the text messages. She wouldn’t have the full picture until she got onto his laptop and found his other messages, but she knew enough. Michelle laughed mirthlessly and longed for the innocent days when she thought her husband was fucking Piper. The truth was so much worse.

Clay—her husband—the man she’d loved most of her life—recruited another man to fuck her. That much was clear. He did it behind her back and with an apparent level of stealth and planning that would make the CIA

proud. He'd missed his true calling. *What kind of a sick fuck would do that?* Michelle kicked herself for letting Clay walk out of there without explaining himself, but she had no idea how to confront him. This was soap opera level crazy drama. A normal person didn't have the tools to deal with it. Besides, she couldn't believe a word out of his mouth anymore. He'd been manipulating her for months with his little buddy Wes.

Michelle thought about Wes seducing her at her husband's behest and she felt dirty and used. Every moment with Wes was viewed through a different lens now, tainted by the sinister plan. *Did he pick Wes for his big dick?* she wondered. *Were there auditions?* Michelle felt her nausea rise again and she ran for the bathroom. All of the wine came up and the violent retching left her trembling. She curled into a ball on the dingy linoleum of the bathroom floor.

She needed a break to think and plan her next move. *Go to the police?* Surely some laws were broken. No, she would be humiliated for being their pawn. Michelle would deal with this herself. She would calm down and come up with a plan, but she didn't need to do that tonight. Tonight, she had to clear her head.

Michelle had to get out of that tiny motel room, but she was in no condition to drive home. Luckily, she had the perfect out. The best tonic for what she was feeling was to take control, and she could think of no better way to do that than to make an affirmative decision about how to use her body. Michelle dug through her purse and found Trooper Spencer's card. *If he wants me to fuck other men,* she thought, reaching for her phone.



To be continued in Michelle's Revenge. Coming August 2021.

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ALSO BY KIRSTEN MCCURRAN

Carol's Trinity:

A Hotwife's Reverse Harem Series

It was a birthday surprise Carol didn't ask for, but she would never forget. Carol had a feeling that things wouldn't be the same after that magical night her husband, John, shared her with three sexy, younger men. She just couldn't anticipate all the ways it would change her. At 40, she feels like a new woman, with powerful new desires.

Conner, Noah and Matteo are never far from her mind in the months afterward, but Carol doesn't quite know how to tell her husband she wants another round with "her guys". Was her 40th birthday present a onetime thing? Isn't it safer if it's left that way? She doesn't want to hurt John's feelings, and she doesn't to come off as a wanton woman. But after a moment of honesty with John, Carol comes home from a morning of yoga to find an incredible surprise waiting for her!

Fiona's Summer Vacation

Fiona was at loose ends with her kid at camp and her husband working endless hours. Faced with all that time and nothing to do, Fiona takes on a project: drawing nerdy young Sam out of his shell and away from his videogames. What seems like a harmless distraction at first, becomes something more as Fiona discovers the young man's crush on her. Surprisingly, Fiona finds herself crushing back as she revels in Sam's attention.

Fiona's husband, Josh, sees no threat and encourages his wife to indulge the young man's crush. He even suggests his wife play Mrs. Robinson to the awkward young man. But it all gets real when Fiona's feelings deepen, and lines are crossed. Fiona is worried by her behavior and annoyed that her husband is not. Can Fiona be a good and loyal wife AND luxuriate in Sam's attention? Can she come to terms with her husband's willingness to share her? The only thing Fiona knows for sure is that she will never be the same after this summer.

Gentrified:

A Wife Seduced

Jessica is a fish out of water when her husband, Kyle, moves their family from the cushy suburbs to a fixer-upper in an up-and-coming neighborhood. The new arrivals get the cold shoulder from most of the neighborhood old-timers, except for one. Winston has designs on Jessica the moment he sees her on the street. After deciding he must have her, Winston sets about seducing the pretty young mom, and making sure he has her husband's blessing.

But no great plan comes off without a hitch, and when Winston meets Jessica's best friend Nicole he finds his attention split. Can Winston seduce Jessica while romancing her best friend? Will Nicole be a wrench in his plans, or become an unexpected ally?

Stephanie's Hotwife Seduction

Stephanie is on a rare date night with her husband Andy when they spy a curious sight. Her coworker Dez, an attractive younger black man, is out with an older white couple. Curiosity gets the better of her and Stephanie asks Dez what his deal is. Dez explains he's a Bull and a whole new world is opened to Stephanie and Andy.

Stephanie can't help but be tempted by the hotwife lifestyle...and her handsome coworker. Will Stephanie lose herself to her new lifestyle or can Andy reel her back in and keep the woman he fell in love with?

Shoot the Messenger:

A Hotwife Adventure

A favor to his wife Haley turns Matt's life upside down. Matt is fixing her computer when an instant message comes through from an old flame, Travis, her college boyfriend. Haley and Travis had a wild, crazy time together, and their affair burned so hot, it had to burn out. It's a time in her life that Matt has always been obsessed with, so seeing Travis pop up in their lives again sends Matt into a tailspin.

Matt watches in fascinated horror as Travis digitally seduces Haley. The old Haley, up for anything, comes out again, and Matt feels that old obsession return. Thoughts of Haley being with Travis again drive arouse and tear him apart. And Travis will get a chance to have his way when they all attend a wedding together. Can Haley resist her ultimate temptation? And will Matt stand by and let her go through with it just to satisfy his own twisted fantasies?

Hawaiian Swing

After 10 years of marriage the flame isn't quite gone, but it's flickering, so Kristen and Steve head off on a second honeymoon to find the magic again. But some things are easier said than done. The demands of being a wife and mother—physical and mental—have Kristen wondering if she can ever again be the passionate, exciting woman Steve met back in college. Just when she thinks getting her mojo back is out of reach, they meet a sexy younger couple intent on turning their world upside down. Kristen doesn't mind that her husband is infatuated with pretty blonde Ambyr, because when she sees herself through the eyes of tall, hunky and tattooed Riley, Kristen finds her passion burning hotter than ever.

These and other titles are available at online booksellers.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KIRSTEN MCCURRAN

Kirsten McCurran is the nom de plume of an average fortysomething woman with a dirty mind and the drive to share her vivid fantasies. She is especially interested in tales of women like her, who are tempted by the forbidden and give in—only to discover the complications that can cause. Like many of her characters, Kirsten lives in the ‘burbs with her loving husband and children, so she understands how difficult it might be for one of her characters to balance a real life with her erotic adventures. Her neighbors may be scandalized to discover what is going on in her head, but Kirsten’s husband fully approves, and even lends a hand in the creative process where he can.

Kirsten has written over 40 ebooks, all of which can be found on Amazon. Some ebooks are available in other formats on BN.com and Smashwords. She loves to hear from her fans and can be reached by email at kmccurran@gmail.com.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KENNY WRIGHT

I'm just a guy who writes what I like to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. I write romantic erotica. I write about characters that I like, and endings that feel natural. I write stories where husbands watch their wives get naughty. I write about MILFs and erotic games and loss of innocence. I believe in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

Liked what you read? Have an idea for something else? Drop me a line. I can be reached at kennywright.writer@gmail.com, or at the following social media links.

